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ANCIENT INDIAN HISTORY

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Acknowledgement

Ancient Indian history holds a crucial place in the UPSC examination, particularly within the syllabus of the Civil Services Preliminary and Main Examinations. Understanding this segment of history is not only essential for scoring well in the examination but also for developing a comprehensive understanding of India's rich cultural and historical legacy. Ancient Indian history provides insights into the early development of Indian civilization. It covers significant periods and events such as the Indus Valley Civilization, the Vedic Age, the rise of major empires like the Maurya and Gupta dynasties, and the spread of Buddhism and Jainism. Knowledge of these eras helps aspirants appreciate the foundational aspects of Indian society, politics, and culture.

The ancient period of Indian history is marked by remarkable achievements in various fields including art, architecture, literature, philosophy, and science. Understanding these contributions helps aspirants recognize the continuity and transformation of cultural practices and ideas over centuries, which is crucial for framing contemporary societal issues in a historical context. Studying ancient history encourages analytical thinking and critical analysis. Aspirants learn to evaluate sources, interpret archaeological findings, and understand historical narratives from multiple perspectives. These skills are invaluable for answering complex questions in the examination and for the analytical tasks expected of a civil servant.

Ancient Indian history is interconnected with other subjects in the UPSC syllabus such as Art and Culture, Geography, and Polity. For instance, understanding the historical context of ancient Indian political systems aids in grasping the evolution of governance in India. Similarly, knowledge of ancient geographical texts and trade routes enriches the study of Indian geography. Many contemporary governance practices, administrative structures, and legal frameworks have roots in ancient India. For instance, the Arthashastra of Kautilya provides valuable insights into statecraft and economic policies. Recognizing these historical precedents enhances an aspirant's understanding of modern administrative principles and challenges. A thorough understanding of ancient Indian history enhances an aspirant's general knowledge, which is essential for the Preliminary examination, the Essay paper, GS Paper 1 and History Optional in the Mains examination. It also contributes to a well-rounded personality, which is beneficial during the personality test (interview).

Creating this booklet on Ancient Indian History for the UPSC examination has been a deeply enriching experience, and it would not have been possible without the support and guidance of many individuals and institutions. Here are some of the study materials which have been referred to for this Plutus IAS booklet:

1. NCERT Textbooks: The NCERT textbooks, especially for history, are foundational sources. They provide a comprehensive overview of various topics and help build a strong base.
2. Standard Reference Books: Consult authoritative books R.S. Sharma's "Ancient India", Upinder Singh's A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India, and A.L. Basham's The Wonder That was India.

I would also like to acknowledge the invaluable support of my family and friends. Your unwavering belief in my abilities and your patience during the long hours of research and writing has been a source of great motivation. This booklet is a testament to the collective effort of many minds, and I hope it serves as a useful tool in your preparation for the UPSC examination.

Your suggestions are welcome for the improvement of this booklet.

Best wishes!

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Chapter 1| Sources of Ancient Indian History

All events of history depend on the sources through which a particular narrative is written. There are two types of historical sources for understanding our ancient Indian history, archaeological and literary sources. Further, both sources can be further divided into various categories of sources. The following diagram shows how the sources are divided

1. Literary Sources

1.1. Brahminical Literature

Shruti Texts

In the Hindu tradition, the Vedas have the status of ***shruti*** (literally, 'that which has been heard'). They are thought to embody an eternal, self-existent truth realized by the *rishis* (seers) in a state of meditation or revealed to them by the gods. The smriti (literally, 'remembered') texts include the Vedanga, Puranas, epics, Dharmashastra, and Nitishastra.

The word Veda comes from the root *vid* (literally, 'to know') and means 'knowledge'. There are four Vedas—*Rig, Sama, Yajur*, and *Atharva*. The *Rig Veda* contains the world's oldest surviving poetry, some of it of extraordinary beauty and philosophical depth. Each Veda has four parts, the last three of which sometimes blend into each other—the **Samhita**, Brahmana, Aranyaka, and Upanishad.

The *Rig Veda* Samhita is a collection of 1,028 hymns (*suktas*) arranged in 10 books (Mandalas). The Rigveda is the oldest one, and therefore, is also known as **'the first testament of mankind'**. After the addition of the eleven Bal Khilya Sutra, the total no. of hymns becomes 1028. The tenth mandala, said to have been added later as its language differs from the other nine mandalas, contains the famous *Purushasukta* explaining the four *varnas* (*Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya and Shudra*) born from the mouth, arms, thighs and feet of the creator. Thus, the Rigveda has 10 Mandalas, 1028 Suktas and 10,580 Richas. The 7th and 2nd Mandalas were the very first composition, later on, the other mandalas were composed. The 7th and 2nd Mandalas are called '*Vansha Mandal*'; the handwritten scriptof the 8th Mandal is called 'Khila' and the 1st and 10th are known as 'Kshepak'.

The *Sama Veda* consists of 1,810 verses, mostly borrowed from the *Rig Veda*, arranged according to the needs of musical notation. The Samaveda is a collection of melodies. These were meant to be sung at the time of soma sacrifice. Samaveda has two parts: Purvarchika (having six subdivisions called 'Apathaka) and Uttrarchika (having nine subdivisions called 'Prapathaka).

The *Yajur Veda* deals with the details of the performance of rituals. It has 40 chapters and 2000 hymns. It is a *ritual Veda* and has two main texts: Krishna Yajurveda and Shukla Yajurveda. It isalso called the Book of sacrificial prayers. Krishna Yajurveda contains *mantras* (*hymns*) and the Shukla has commentary *in prose*. Kasthak, Kapishthal, Maitrayani, Taittiriya and Vajasneyi are the five branches of Yajurveda in which the first four are related to the Krishna Yajurveda and the lastone is to Shukla Yajurveda. Yajurveda is a good collection of hymns composed in both prose and poetry. *Ishopanishad*, the last chapter of Yajurveda, is philosophical and metaphysical whereas the rest of all parts of Yajurveda's subject matter isthe law and legislation of various yajanas.

The *Atharva Veda* is the latest Veda and contains hymns (some from the *Rig Veda*), but also spells and charms which reflect aspects of popular beliefs and practices. It is the latest of the four. It describes the popular beliefs and superstitions of the humble folk. It is divided into 20 volumes. It contains 731 hymns and 5,987 mantras. About 1200 Mantras have been taken from the Rigveda. The hymns of Atharvaveda tell how to overcome the evil spirit. Shaunk and Pippalad are the two available branches of this Veda. The Atharvaveda is also known as Brahmaveda or Atharvagirasveda. For a very long time, it was not considered in the category of the Vedas. It is a book of magical formulae.

The Brahmanas are prose explanations of the Samhita portions and give details and explanations of sacrificial rituals and their outcome. The Brahmanas were composed after the Vedas to explain the hymns of the Vedas. Every Veda has several Brahmanas attached to it. **Kausitiki** and **Aitareya** are the Brahmans books of the Rigveda composed by **Hotri priests.** Taittiriya is the Brahman of Krishna Yajurveda and Shatpath is attached to shukla Yajurveda composed by Adhvaryu priest Yagyavalka. It narrates the progress of culture from Kuru-Panchal to Videha. The Samaveda has three Brahmanas i.e. Tandayamaha Brahman, Khadvisha Brahmana and Jaiminiya Brahman were composed by **Udgatri priests.** The Gopath Brahman is attached to the Atharvaveda.

The **Aranyakas** (forest books) interpret sacrificial rituals in a symbolic and philosophical way. There are seven Aranyakas, i.e., Aitareya, Sankhyayana, Taittiriya, Maitrayani, Madhyanandin, Talvakar and

Jaiminiya. These books are opposed to sacrifices and rituals and lay emphasis on meditation and moral virtues to form a bridge between the Karma Marga (way of work) and the Gyan Marga (way of knowledge).

There are 108 **Upanishads**, among which 13 are considered the principal ones. The Upanishads contain a great variety of philosophical ideas about sacrifice, the body, and the universe, but are most closely associated with the concepts of ***atman*** and ***brahman***. The word Upanishad is a combined form of the two Sanskrit word, i.e., upa and nishad which means to sit down near someone and get the secret knowledge from him. Jesh, Kath, Ken, Mandukya, Brihadaranyka, Mundaka, Chhandogya, Taittiriya, Aitareya and Kaushitiki are some important Upanishads. The Upanishads are anti-ritualistic discussing the theories of creation of the universe and defining the doctrine of action with the goal to attain salvation through meditation and self-control. Upanishads also contain stories in order to give teachings on the meaning of life. Most of the Upanishads were written between 800 BC to 500 BC. The famous national statement 'Satyameva Jayate' has been taken from the Mundaka Upanishad.

Smriti Texts

The six Vedangas - Shiksha, Kalpa, Vyakarana, Nirukta, Chhanda and Jyotisha were composed in the later Vedic period.

1. Shiksha deals with the appropriate pronunciation of the Mantras.
2. Kalpa is related to rituals, duties and sanskara.
3. Vyakarana deals with grammar and the science of language
4. Nirukta with etymology. Yaskacharya's Nirukta is very famous.
5. Chhanda deals with rhyming schemes. Chhandasutra was composed by Aacharya Pingle.
6. Jyotish deals with astronomy in which we find the proper calculation of the right position of the sun and the moon and various heavenly bodies to perform rituals and ceremonies. Jyothish Vedanga is a famous book for it in which we get as many as 400 slokas.

Epics are another source of smriti texts in which the Ramayan and Mahabharat are most important. The Ramayana, the oldest epic in the world, is known as 'Adi Kavya'. It consists of 24,000 shlokas divided into 07 Kandas (Bal Kand, Ayodhya Kand and Aranya Kand, Kishkindha Kand, Sundar Kand, Lanka Kandand Uttar Kand). The first and seventh Kands were the latest additions to the Ramayana. The Ramayana is said to be composed in the 5th century B.C. Originally it had only 6,000 verses. Later on, it became 12,000 and finally, it has 24,000 shlokas.

The Mahabharat of Ved Vyasa is the longest epic in the world consisting of 1,00,000 shlokas in 18 parvans or chapters in which shanti parvan is the largest parvan. The Bhagavad Gita is extracted from the Bhishma Parvan of the Mahabharata. The Mahabharata is said to be composed between 400 B.C. to A.D. 400. Originally it had only 8,800 shlokas under the name of Jay Samhita, later on, it was called chaturvinshati sahastri samhita or Bharat consisting of 24,000 shlokas and finally, it became Mahabharata or Shatasahastri Samhita with 1,00,000 shlokas. It is also called 'Panchamveda'.

The 'Purana' means 'the old'. There are 18 'Puranas' in which the Matsya purana is the oldest puran. These puranas describe the genealogies of various royal dynasties, i.e., Maurya, Andhra, Shishunag, Gupta, etc. The name of puranas is: Brahma, Padma, Vishnu, Shiva, Bhagvat, Narad, Markandey, Agni, Bhavishya Brahma-vaivartya, Linga Varah, Skanda, Vaman, Kurma, Matsya, Garur and Brahmand. Besides these, there are 19 Upapuranas. Lomharsha or his son Ugrashrava is said to be the compiler of Puranas.

Smriti means 'remembrance'. Smiritis, the auxiliary treatises of the Vedas, are regarded as a part of the revelation. There are six famous smritis: Manu smriti, Yajnvalkya smriti, Narad Smriti, Parashara smriti, Brihaspati Smriti and Katyayana Smriti.

1.2. Buddhist Literature

Early Buddhist literature is generally divided into canonical and non-canonical texts. Canonical texts are books which lay down the basic tenets and principles of a religion or sect. The various Buddhist schools classify their canonical literature in different ways, some into 9 or 12 Angas, others into 3 Pitakas. There are Pali, Chinese, and Tibetan versions of the *Tipitaka* (The Three Baskets/Collections). The Pali *Tipitaka* of the Theravada school is the oldest of them all.

Pali was a literary language which developed out of a mixture of dialects, particularly those spoken in the Magadha area of eastern India. The *Tipitaka* consists of three books—the *Sutta, Vinaya*, and *Abhidhamma*. In the Buddhist context, *sutta* (from

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the Sanskrit *sutra*) refers to texts that are supposed to contain what the Buddha himself said.

The *Sutta Pitaka* contains the Buddha's discourses on various doctrinal issues in dialogue form. With the exception of a few *sutta*s, the authority of this work was accepted by all Buddhist schools. The *Vinaya Pitaka* has rules for monks and nuns of the *sangha* (monastic order). It includes the *Patimokkha*—a list of transgressions against monastic discipline and atonements for these. The *Abhidhamma Pitaka* is a later work, and contains a thorough study and systemization of the teachings of the *Sutta Pitaka* through lists, summaries, and questions and answers.

The three Pitakas are divided into books known as the Nikayas (analogous but not identical to the Agamas of the Buddhist Sanskrit tradition). For instance, the *Sutta Pitaka* consists of five Nikayas—the *Digha, Majjhima, Samyutta, Anguttara,* and *Khuddaka Nikaya*s. The *Jatakas*—stories of the previous births of the Buddha—are one of the 15 books of the *Khuddaka Nikaya*, and their composition can be placed between the 3rd century BCE and the 2nd century CE.

The *Khuddaka Nikaya* also contains the *Dhammapada* (a collection of verses dealing mainly with ethical sayings), and the *Theragatha* and *Therigatha* (songs of Buddhist monks and nuns). The *Therigatha*, which describes women's experience of renunciation, is especially important because it is one of the very few surviving ancient Indian texts composed by or attributed to women. According to Buddhist tradition, the *Sutta* and *Vinaya Pitaka*s were recited at the first council of monks at Rajagriha immediately after the Buddha's death, and 100 years later at the second council at Vaishali. But their composition must have extended over several centuries, up to the time of the third council convened in the 3rd century BCE during the reign of Ashoka.

Non-canonical Buddhist literature in Pali includes the *Milindapanha* which consists of a dialogue on various philosophical issues between King Milinda—no doubt the Indo-Greek Menander—and the monk Nagasena. The *Nettigandha* or *Nettipakarana* (The Book of Guidance) gives a connected account of the teaching of the Buddha. Commentaries on the *Tipitaka* include a 5th-century work by Buddhaghosha. The first connected life story of the Buddha occurs in the *Nidanakatha*. The Pali or Sri Lankan chronicles—the *Dipavamsa* and the *Mahavamsa* contain a historical-cum-mythical account of the Buddha's life, the Buddhist councils, the Maurya emperor Ashoka, the kings of Sri Lanka, and the arrival of Buddhism on that island.

Apart from texts in Pali, there are several Buddhist works in Sanskrit, and in a mixture of Prakrit and Sanskrit that is often referred to as Buddhist Sanskrit or Buddhist hybrid Sanskrit. For instance, the canon of the Sarvastivada school is in Sanskrit. Sarvastivada Vinaya refers to the monastic code of the Sarvastivada school of Buddhism which was founded by Kātyāyanīputra. The Lalitavistara Sūtra is a Sanskrit Mahayana Buddhist sutra that tells the story of Gautama Buddha from the time of his descent from Tushita until his first sermon in the Deer Park at Sarnath near Varanasi. The *Lalitavistara*, a hagiography of the Buddha associated with the Sarvastivada school but strongly tinged with Mahayana elements, is in Sanskrit and mixed Prakrit-Sanskrit. The *Mahavastu*, which has some Mahayana elements, gives a hagiography (sacred biography) of the Buddha and describes the emergence of the monastic order in mixed Sanskrit–Prakrit. Sanskrit Buddhist texts include Ashvaghosha's *Buddhacharita* and the Avadana texts. Visuddhimagga is a comprehensive manual of Theravada Buddhism written by Buddhaghosa in the 5th century AD, which is later than Sanghabhuti's time and unrelated to him. The Prajnaparamita Sutras are a large body of Mahayana Buddhist literature dealing with the Perfection of Wisdom. Sanghabhuti (who went to China in the 4th century) wrote commentaries on these sutras, particularly on the larger Perfection of Wisdom Sutras. His work contributed to the understanding and dissemination of Mahayana teachings in China. Nettipakarana, written by Buddha's disciple Kaccana, is a Buddhist text that deals with logic and epistemology. Later works of Mahayana thinkers such as Nagarjuna, Vasubandhu, Asanga, Aryadeva, Buddhapalita, and Dignaga are all in Sanskrit.

1.3. Jain Literature

The sacred books of the Jaina are collectively known as the Siddhanta or Agama. The language of the earliest texts is an eastern dialect of Prakrit known as Ardha-Magadhi. The Jaina monastic order came to be divided into the Shvetambara and Digambara schools. The Shvetambara canon includes the 12 Angas, 12 Uvamgas (Upangas), 10 Painnas (Prakirnas), 6 Cheya Suttas (Cheda Sutras), 4 Mula Suttas (Mula Sutras), and a number of individual texts such as the Nandi Sutta (Nandi Sutra) and Anugodara (Anuyogadvara). There is some overlap in the content of the canonical literature of the two schools.

According to Shvetambara tradition, the Angas were compiled at a council held at Pataliputra. The compilation of the entire canon is supposed to have taken place in the 5th or 6th century at a council held in Valabhi in Gujarat, presided over by Devarddhi Kshamashramana. Some of the material in the canon may go back to the 5th or 4th century BCE, but changes and additions continued to be made till the 5th–6th centuries CE.

Parishisthaparvan by Hemachandra is a Jaina text, which is often considered an appendix or supplement to the Mahabharata. It provides additional narratives and elaborates on various stories related to the main events of the Mahabharata from a Jain perspective.

The author of Trishashtilakshana Mahapurana is Acharya Jinasena. Jinasena was a distinguished Digambara Jain monk and scholar from the 9th century. Trishashtilakshana Mahapurana, also known as the "Lives of the Sixty-Three Great Beings," is a major Jaina text. It is one of the canonical texts of the Digambara Jain tradition, detailing the life stories of the twenty-four Tirthankaras and other significant Jain figures. It provides a comprehensive account of Jain cosmology, mythology, and the ethical and moral teachings of Jainism.

The non-canonical Jaina works are partly in Prakrit dialects, especially Maharashtri, and partly in Sanskrit, which started being used in the early centuries CE. Commentaries on the canonical works include the Nijjuttis (Niryuktis), Bhashyas, and Churnis in Maharashtri and Prakrit; the early medieval Tikas, Vrittis, and Avachurnis are in Sanskrit. The Jaina Puranas (the Shvetambaras call them Charitas) are hagiographies of the Jaina saints known as Tirthankaras (literally ‘ford makers’), but they contain other material as well. The Adi Purana (9th century) narrates the life of the first Tirthankara Rishabha, also known as Adinatha.

The 8th century Harivamsha Purana gives a Jaina version of the stories of the Kauravas, Pandavas, Krishna, Balarama, and others. The Trishashtilakshana Mahapurana by Jinasena and Gunabhadra (9th century) has life stories of various Jaina saints, kings, and heroes. It also has sections on topics such as life-cycle rituals, the interpretation of dreams, town planning, the duties of a warrior, and how a king should rule. The Parishishtaparvan (12th century) by Hemachandra gives a history of the earliest Jaina teachers and also mentions certain details of political history.

1.4. Secular Literature (Non-Historical & Historical)

1. Arthashastra: It was composed by Kautilya (Chanakya). It gives a methodological analysis of the political and economic conditions of the Mauryan period.
2. Mudra-rakshasa: It was written by Vishakh Dutt during Gupta Period. It explains the destruction of the Nandas by Chandra Gupta Maurya with the help of Chanakya.
3. Astadhyayee composed by Panini, is a grammar on which Patanjali has written annotation.
4. Gargi Samhita describes the onset of the yavanas in India.
5. Similarly, Kalidash’s Abhijnayan Shakuntalam and Malvikagnimitram explain the conditions of society and culture of the Gupta’s period. The fight between the Yavan and Pushyamitra Sunga is also mentioned in it.
6. The Swapnavasvadutta of Bhasa throws light on the various events of the Gupta period. Madhyama-vyayoga is a one-act play attributed to Bhasa, a classical Sanskrit dramatist. Bhasa is known for his several plays that are based on themes from the Mahabharata and Ramayana, and "Madhyama-vyayoga" is one of them.
7. Kavyalankara is a work on poetics and literary theory by the poet Bhamaha.
8. Natyashastra is an ancient Indian treatise on performing arts, including theatre, dance, and music, attributed to the sage Bharata Muni.
9. Mahabhashya is a major commentary on the grammar of Panini, written by Patanjali.
10. Mudrarakshasa and Devichandraguptam by Vishakhadatta are the compositions of the Gupta period.
11. King Harshavardhana wrote Naganand, Priyadarshika and Ratnavali. In the very period his courtier poet Banabhatta wrote ‘Harshacharita’. In all these compositions we gain the knowledge of Harsha’s kingship and administration.
12. Gaudvaho by Vakpatiraj explains the victory of king Yashovarman of Kannauj and the subjugation of Gauda. Padmagupta Parimal wrote Navsahsanka Charit. It describes the various events of the Parmara of Malva.
13. Bilhana in his epic Vikramankdevcharita has described the achievements of the King of Chalukya Vikramaditya (VI).

14. Nayachandra Suri wrote the "Hammira-Mahakavya," which narrates the life of Hammira, a ruler of Ranthambore.
15. "Nitivakyamrita" is a work on polity and statecraft authored by Somadeva Suri, a Jain scholar.
16. Avdanashataka is a Sanskrit anthology of a hundred verses attributed to Hāla, a Sanskrit poet.
17. Chand Bardai's (Prithviraj Raso), Jayanak's Prithviraj Vijay and Kumarparpal Charit, Jaganakas' Parmal Raso are some important compositions through which we understand the various events of Rajputana Period.
18. In 1148-49 AD, Kalhana wrote 'Rajtarangini' describing about the rulers of Kashmir. Rajtarangini is considered to be the first historical book of India. Kalhan is said to have been the son of a former minister by the name of Campaka in the court of a Kashmiri king, Harsha. It has 7826 verses and is divided into eight cantons.
19. Sandhyakar Nandi's Ramcharit is also a historical creation describing the works and achievements of Rampal, the pal ruler of Bengal.

1.5. Sangam Literature

Sangam was a college or assembly of Tamil poets held under the Royal patronage of Pandayan Kings in Madurai. It is said that the assembly lasted for 9,990 years and was attended by 8,598 poets and 197 pandyas. According to the legends, there were three Sangams (Academy of Tamil poets) held in ancient South India popularly called Muchchangam. The First Sangam is believed to be held at Madurai, attended by gods and legendary sages. No literary work of this Sangam is available. The Second Sangam was held at Kapadapuram, only Tolkappiyam survives from this. The Third Sangam was also held at Madurai. A few of these Tamil literary works have survived and are useful sources to reconstruct the history of the Sangam period.

The Sangam corpus includes six of the eight anthologies of poems included in the *Ettutokai* (The Eight Collections), and nine of the ten *pattus* (songs) of the *Pattuppattu* (The Ten Songs). The style and certain historical references in the poems suggest that this literature is most likely composed between the 3rd Century BCE and the 3rd century CE. Around the mid-8th century, they were compiled into anthologies, which were further collected into the super-anthologies (the anthologies of anthologies) called the *Ettutokai* and the *Pattuppattu*. It is rather interesting to note that the anthologies include a total of 2381 poems ascribed to 473 poets, out of whom 30 poets were women. Apart from these poems, the first two books of the *Tolkappiyam* (a book on Tamil grammar and poetics written by Tolkappiyar) are also a part of the corpus of Sangam Literature. There is also mention of the *Agattiyam*, which was the first known book on Tamil grammar. It was supposedly written by the sage Agathiyar and is believed to be lost beyond redemption. The sage Agathiyar, according to Hindu legends, brought the Tamil language and its syntax to the Tamil people from the god Shiva. It is believed that Tolkappiyar, the author of *Tolkappiyam*, was the disciple of Agathiyar. Poems within Sangam literature was composed on two broader themes of *akam* (love) and *puram* (mostly based on war but also included public poetry such as poems on good and evil, community and kingdom).

Sangam literature can be divided into two groups: narrative and didactic. The narrative texts are called Melkannakku (18 Major Works consisting of eight anthologies and ten idylls) and are considered works of heroic poetry in which heroes are glorified and perpetual wars and cattle raids are frequently mentioned. The didactic works are called Kilkanakku (18 Minor Works).

A large number of Tamil didactic works such as Tiruvalluvar's *Tirukkural* (famous work on ethics, philosophy, polity, and love, and considered the fifth Veda of Tamil Nadu), Tamil epics such as *Silappadikaram* written by Ilango Adigal (considered the brightest gem of early Tamil literature which deals with the love story of Kovalan, who prefers a courtesan Madhavi of Kaveripattnam to his noble wedded wife Kannagi) and *Manimekalai* (a sequel to *Silappaddikaram* and is considered the 'Odyssey of Tamil poetry', which deals with the adventures of the daughter born of the union of Kovalan and Madhavi and her subsequent conversion to Buddhism) were written in the period between the 5th and 6th centuries. Bharatam, a Tamil epic, was composed of Perudevanar. It also has great importance in Tamil literature.

1.6. Foreign Traveller's Writings

The earliest references to India in Greek texts date from the 5th century BC and their frequency increases thereafter. One of the most famous works is the *Indica* of Megasthenes, ambassador of Seleucus Nikator to the court of Chandragupta Maurya. The book is lost, but later Greek works preserve paraphrases of some of its sections. The

many Greek and Latin texts of the 2nd century BCE to the 2nd century CE referring to India include the works of Arrian, Strabo, and Pliny the Elder, and the anonymous *Periplus Maris Erythraei* (Periplus of the Erythraean Sea). These texts are especially important for the history of Indian Ocean trade.

Many Chinese monks made long and arduous overland journeys to India, crossing mountains, plateaux, and deserts, in order to collect authentic manuscripts of Buddhist texts, meet Indian monks, and visit places of Buddhist learning and pilgrimage. The best-known among those who wrote accounts of their Indian travels are Faxian (Fa Hien) and Xuanzang (Hiuen Tsang). Faxian's travels extended from 399 to 414 CE and were confined to northern India. Xuanzang left his home in 629 CE and spent over 10 years travelling the length and breadth of the country. Yijing, another 7th-century Chinese traveller, lived for 10 years in the great monastery of Nalanda. The accounts written by these pilgrims throw light on the history of Buddhism and various other aspects of their time.

The rapid political expansion of the Arabs, the unity given to them by Islam, the spread of urban centres, and the patronage of the Caliphs had an important and far-reaching impact on intellectual ideas and technology in Asia and Europe. Arab scholars initially relied heavily on Greek works, but men such as Jaihani, Gardizi, and Al-Biruni developed their own independent critical points of view. Abu Rihan or Al-Biruni, a native of Khwarizm or Khiva (in modern Turkmenistan), was one of the greatest intellectuals of early medieval times. Only 40 of the 180 books he wrote have survived. Al-Biruni travelled to India to satisfy his curiosity about the land and its people, and to study their ancient texts in their original language.

His *Tahqiq-i-Hind* covers a large number of topics including Indian **scripts**, sciences, geography, astronomy, astrology, philosophy, literature, beliefs, customs, religions, festivals, rituals, social organization, and laws. Apart from the historical value of his descriptions of 11th-century India, Al-Biruni helped modern historians identify the initial year of the Gupta era. The *Tahqiq-i-Hind* states that the Gupta era began 241 years after the beginning of the Shaka era. Since the Shaka era began in 78 CE, this place was the beginning of the Gupta era in 319–20 CE. Suleiman, Almasudi, and Ibna-Batuta were other travellers who wrote about India. The *Shahnama* of Firdausi, a classic of Persian poetry, and the *Gulistan* by the famous poet Saadi refer incidentally to aspects of Indian trade.

2. Archaeological Sources

Archaeology—the study of the human past through material remains—is closely connected with history. Material remains range from vestiges of grand palaces and temples to the small, discarded products of everyday human activity such as pieces of broken pottery. They include different things such as structures, artefacts, bones, seeds, pollen, seals, coins, sculptures, and inscriptions. Archaeologists increasingly rely on various scientific techniques in order to obtain precise information about the lives of past communities. These are especially useful in dating archaeological material. Many dating methods are based directly or indirectly on the principle of radioactive decay. Carbon-14 or radiocarbon dating is the best-known of these, but others include thermoluminescence, potassium-argon, electron spin resonance, uranium series, and fission-track dating.

The credit for excavating the Pre-Aryan past goes to Sir William Jones of the Asiatic Bengal Society. James Prinsep, the Secretary of ABS succeeded for the first time in deciphering the Brahmi script. Sir Alexander Cunningham, the father of Indian archaeology, arrived in India in 1831. He judged the ruins of ancient sites of pre-Aryan civilisation. He also identified the ruins of the ancient side of pre-Aryan culture. Later on, in 1901, Lord Curzon revived this work and John Marshall was appointed as its director general and he discovered the cities Harappa and Mohenjodara. Rakhal Das Banerji, in 1922, found seals at Mohenjodaro. It was the remains of pre-Aryan civilization. Later, the sites were excavated under the direction of Marshall from 1924 to 1931. Sir R.E. Mortimer Wheeler made important discoveries at Harappa after the Second World War. Indian epigraphists such as Bhanu Daji, Bhagavanlal Indraji, Rajendralal Mitra and R.G. Bahndarkar contributed to the excavations of new sites.

The study of coins is called numismatics. Important historical facts are obtained through it. Samudragupta's Aswameda coins and lion slayer coins reflect his ambitions and love of hunting. He has been seen playing on a lyre in a coin which gives an idea of his love of music. The Punch Mark Coins (of silver and copper) are the earliest coins of India. The Kushanas issued gold coins depicting many deities on their coins. The coins of Vima Kadphises bear the figure of Lord Shiva. Thus, coins help discover ideas about the complementary economic condition and provide facts with date that help us in fixing chronology. In Panini's Astadhyayee, Brahmin literature and Upanishads we find the

descriptions of Vedic coins or currency named Nishka, Shatman, Suvarna, and Panishka. The Gold coins of Gupta's period are quite important in this context. Inscriptions are the words cut on stone or metals. The study of inscriptions is called epigraphy.

Inscriptions are the most reliable evidence and are free from interpolations. Ashokas's rock-cut edicts, pillar edicts, inscriptions of Kharvela and Allahabad Prasasti by Harisena and the inscriptions found at Khalimpur and Bhagalpur of the Gupta Age are important evidence.

Monuments and buildings reflect the growth of material prosperity and the development of culture. The ancient monuments of Taxshila provide information about the Kushanas and its sculpture imparts the knowledge of Gandhar Kala. The Mauryan history is known by the Stupas, Chaityas and Vihars.

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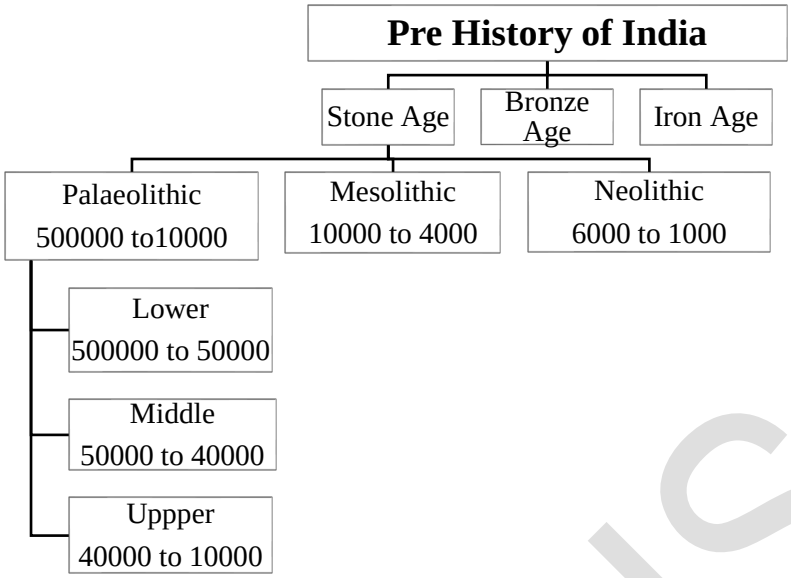
Chapter 2| Pre-History of India

The Prehistory of India is divided into three phases. The first one is the age of Stone Age, the second is the Bronze Age and the third is the Iron Age. The Stone Age is further divided into three phases, Palaeolithic, Mesolithic and Neolithic.



1. Palaeolithic Period

The Palaeolithic Age is the earliest period of the Stone Age, which developed in the Pleistocene or Ice Age. It was spread in practically all parts of India except *the alluvial plains of the Indus and Ganga.* The Palaeolithic man of India is said to have belonged to the Negrito race and lived in caves and rock shelters. They were food-gathering people who lived on hunting and gathering wild fruits and vegetables. They had no knowledge of agriculture, house building, pottery, or any metal. It was only in later stages that they attained the knowledge of fire. During this period, man used tools of unpolished, undressed rough stones — mainly hand axes, cleavers, choppers, blades, burin, and scrapers. Since the stone tools were made of a hard rock called 'quartzite', Palaeolithic men are therefore also called 'Quartzite men' in India. Following are the features of this period.

Art & Cult: In the Palaeolithic age, art was dependent on the Ostrich Egg Beads and people used to worship the Mother Goddess.

Life Style: The People depended on a reciprocity system. They were living in the band society in which around 50-60 people were living. Their settlement was not permanent. The children and old people were not working as the hunting and gathering process required active participation.

Food Resources: They were dependent on hunting-gathering, fruits and the eggs of ostrich. The major differences between the different phases of the Palaeolithic period are the types and quality of tools used by people.

Lower Palaeolithic Age (5,00,000-1,00,000 B.C.): It covers the greater part of the Ice Age. The people were wanderers. They did not know how to grow food. They used to eat fruits, birds and raw animal flesh, etc. The tools were usually made of hard rock, 'Quartzite' and therefore the man of the Palaeolithic age is called 'Quartzite Man'. For hunting they used hand-axe, cleavers, flaxes and choppers of irregular shapes. A fossil of "Homo Erectus", from Hathnaura (Narmada basin), of this age has been found. This age is represented by Sohan culture (Now in Pakistan). Sohan Valley (Punjab), Belan Valley (Mirzapur), Narmada Valley (Madhya Pradesh), Didwani (Rajasthan), and Bhimbetka (M.P.), Singrauli basin (U.P), Chhotanagpur (Jharkhand), Assam, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and in whole India except Sind and Kerala.

Middle Palaeolithic Age (1,00,000 - 40,000 B. C.): It was an age of flakes. A bit of change in the shape of tools made of stones or bones is remarked. Now they started using blades, points and scrappers made of flakes. Still, they had no house to live in. They lived under the rocks in caves and hollow tree trunks. They were afraid of wild creatures. Neanderthal man dominated this stage of human evolution. Important Sites are Bankura and Purulia (West Bengal), Nevasa, Nodur Madhmeshwar, Suregaon and Nevasa (Maharastra), Malprabha and Ghatprabha basin (Karnataka). Narmada Valley, etc. In Bhimbetka (M.P) 200 rock shelters, caves and thousands of paintings have been traced which are of **the** middle Palaeolithic age, i.e. scrapper and borer culture.

Upper Palaeolithic Age (40,000 - 10,000 B.C.): In this period, humans lived as nomadic hunter-gatherers. The traces of Homo sapiens have been discovered. Rock paintings and carvings have been found in Bhimbetka that reflect the art and rituals of this period. The animals depicted in these are mostly bison, elephants, tigers, bears, rhinoceros, etc. The upper Palaeolithic art is characterised by red and green colours. Important Sites are Andhra Pradesh,

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Karnataka, Maharastra, Bhopal (Bhimbetka) and Chhotanagpur (Jharkhand).

2. Mesolithic Age

The Mesolithic Age represents the intermediate stage in Stone Age Culture. Both Mesolithic and Neolithic Cultures belong to the Holocene era (which succeeded the Pleistocene era around 10,000 years ago). The Mesolithic man lived on hunting, fishing, food gathering, and in later stages, also domesticated animals. One of the key aspects of the Mesolithic Age was the reduction in the size of well-established tool types. The characteristic tools of this age were microliths (miniature stone tools usually made of crypto-crystalline silica, chalcedony, or chert, both of geometrical and non-geometrical shapes). They were not only used as tools in themselves but also to make composite tools, spearheads, arrowheads, and sickles after hafting them on wooden or bone handles. Some of the other aspects of the Mesolithic Age are: Pottery is absent at most Mesolithic sites, but it is present at Langhnaj in Gujarat and in the Kaimur region of Mirzapur (UP). The last phase of this age saw the beginning of plant cultivation. The Mesolithic era initiated rock art in pre-history. In 1867, the first rock paintings in India were discovered at Sohagighat (Kaimur Hills, UP). Now, over 150 Mesolithic rock art sites have been discovered across India, with a rich concentration in Central India such as the Bhimbetka Caves, Kharwar, Jaora, and Kathotia (M.P.), Sundargarh and Sambalpur (Orissa), Ezhuthu Guha (Kerala). Animals dominate the scenes at most Mesolithic rock art sites. However, no snakes are depicted in Mesolithic Paintings. Burials and rock paintings give us ideas about the development of religious practices and also reflect the division of labour based on gender.

Terminology	Geological age	Typical Indian stone tool types	Main subsistence base
Lower palaeolithic	Lower Pleistocene	**Pebble** and **core tools** like handaxes, **cleavers**, and **chopping tools**	Hunting and gathering
Middle palaeolithic	Middle Pleistocene	Flake tools, including those made by prepared core techniques such as the **Levallois technique**	Hunting and gathering
Upper palaeolithic	Upper Pleistocene	Blade tools made on flakes—e.g., parallel-sided blades and burins	Hunting and gathering
Mesolithic	Holocene	**Microliths**	Hunting, gathering, fishing, with instances of animal domesticatio in a few places
Neolithic	Holocene	**Celts** (ground and polished handaxes)	Food production based on animal and plant domestication

Important Mesolithic sites are: Bangor in Rajasthan is India's largest Mesolithic site. Tilwara, Pachpadra basin and Sojat Area are some of Rajasthan's other notable Mesolithic monuments. Mesolithic sites include Akhaj, Valsana, Hirpur, and Langhanj in Gujarat among others along the banks of the Sabarmati River.Sarai Nahar Rai, Morhana Pahar, and Lekkahia are major Mesolithic sites in Uttar Pradesh. Bhimbetka, Chaturbhujnath Nala and Adamgarh in Madhya Pradesh are other significant Mesolithic sites in India. The Chhota Nagpur plateau in Jharkhand is another prominent Mesolithic site. Mayurbhanj, Keonjhar, and Sundergarh are well-known mesolithic sites in Odisha. Mesolithic sites are found in Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, and Andhra Pradesh in South India.

3. Neolithic Period

In northern India, the Neolithic age emerged around c.8000−6000 BCE. At some places in south and eastern India, it is as late as 1000 BCE. Its significance in pre-history can be gauged by the fact that V. Gordon Childe termed the Neolithic phase as Neolithic Revolution. It introduced a lot of innovations such as:

Advent of food production: The Neolithic man cultivated land and grew fruits & corn like *ragi* and horse gram (*kulathi*). He domesticated cattle, sheep, and goats.

Innovations in technology: The Neolithic man innovated in the production of stone tools, producing implements such as polished, pecked, and ground stone tools. They depended on polished stones other than quartzite for making tools. Based on the types of axes used, three important areas of Neolithic Settlements can be identified: North-Western: Rectangular axes with curved cutting edges. North-Eastern: Polished stone axes with rectangular butt, has occasional shouldered hoes. Southern: Axes with oval sides and pointed butts.

Invention of pottery: The Neolithic era communities first made pottery by hand and then with the help of the potter's wheel. Their pottery included black burnished ware, grey ware, and mat-impressed ware. It can therefore be said that pottery on a large scale appeared in this phase.

Emergence of self-sufficient village communities: In the later phases of the Neolithic era, people led a more settled life. They lived in circular and rectangular houses made of mud and reed. They also knew how to make boats and could spin cotton and wool and weave cloth.

Division of labour based on sex and age: As society was progressing, the need for additional labour was recognised and thus labour was procured from other non-kin groups too.

Some of the important excavated Neolithic Sites along with their unique aspects are as follows: Burzahom (unique rectangular chopper, domestic dogs buried with their masters in graves) and Gufkraal in Jammu and Kashmir (famous for pit dwellings, stone tools, and graveyards located within households). Maski, Brahmagiri, Piklihal (proof of cattle herding), Budihal (community food preparation and feasting), and Tekkalakota in Karnataka. Paiyampalli in Tamil Nadu and Utnur in Andhra Pradesh. Garo Hills in Meghalaya, Chirand in Bihar (considerable use of bone implements, especially those made of antlers). Saraikhola, near Taxila on the Potwar plateau, Amri, Kotdiji and Mehrgarh (the earliest Neolithic site known as the Breadbasket of Baluchistan, a province of Pakistan). Koldihwa, in Belan valley (unique in terms of the presence of a three-fold Neolithic, Chalcolithic and Iron Age settlements), Koldihwa and Mahagara, south of Allahabad (many strata of circular huts along with crude hand-made pottery; the earliest evidence of rice cultivation in the world). Chopani – Mando, Belan Valley (earliest evidence of use of pottery). Belan Valley, on the northern spurs of the Vindhyas, and the middle part of the Narmada valley (evidence of all the three phases of Paleolithic settlement, followed by Mesolithic and Neolithic settlements).

4. Chalcolithic Period

This age is marked by the use of copper as copper was the first metal used by man of this age. The economy was based on subsistence agriculture, stock-raising, hunting and fishing. The dead were buried in the North-South position in Maharashtra but in South India, it was in the East-West direction. The chalcolithic people slaughtered animals for food. Some perforated stone discs are found which were used for jhum-cultivation. The supply of copper was limited. People did not know the art of mixing tin with copper. The decline in rainfall from about 1200 B.C. led to the decay of this culture. Due to the agitation of epidemics, the culture of chalcolithic people came to an end. The transitional stage between the Stone Age and humans started living a settled life.

Important sites: Probably, this culture was extended from the Chhotanagpur plateau to the upper Gangetic basin. Some sites are found at Brahmagiri near Mysore and Navada Toli on the Narmada. Copper hoards have been found in a wide area from West Bengal, Orissa, Haryana, Andhra Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh. From Gungeria (M.P) we have found 424 copper tools and weapons and 102 thin sheets of silver objects. Stone tools have also been found in excavations. Mostly the copper hoards were supplemented by stone tools that paved the way of a settled life in a good portion of the Ganga - Yamuna doab. Besides these, the two types of pottery, i.e., O.C.P. (Ochre Coloured Pottery) and B.R.W. (Black and Red Ware), showing Harappan influence, have been excavated from various sites.
Some Important Features of the Chalcolithic Age: Both Kharif and Rabi crops were cultivated. Barley was the main crop. A highly specialised store blade industry of siliceous store is found. Cotton was produced for the first time in this period. First village communities in Peninsular India were found. Jhum cultivation was practised. First-time fortified settlements were built, e.g., sites of Daimabad, Inamgao, Nagada, etc.

5. Megalithic Culture

Definition and Context of Megaliths: Megaliths are large stone structures associated primarily with graves, constructed by various people across different periods globally. Their significance and construction techniques varied across regions and times, reflecting diverse cultural practices. Key sources of information on early people and kingdoms in the region include Ashokan inscriptions, Sangam literature, and accounts by Megasthenes.

Megaliths as a Single Culture: Archaeologist B.B. Lal's extensive work suggests that the Black and Red Ware Culture (BRW) was contemporaneous with the Painted Grey Ware Culture in the Ganga Valley, a proto-urban culture linked to Hastinapur. The overlapping periods, dating back to 2000 BC, indicate an evolution from Neolithic, Chalcolithic, and Harappan cultures, suggesting some connections among these cultures.

Megaliths as a Homogeneous Culture: Mayank Vahia's studies on the genetic history of the subcontinent indicate no significant migration into India between 40000 BC and 2000 BC, when the

Sanskrit-speaking Indo-Europeans arrived. As megalithic societies were preliterate, determining the racial or ethnic origins of these people is challenging, making it difficult to ascertain if they represented a homogeneous culture.

Megaliths as Contemporaneous Culture: Domesticated animals such as sheep, goats, dogs, pigs, horses, buffaloes, fowls, and asses suggest a contemporaneous Neolithic tradition of cattle keeping. The Megalithic Period, ranging from 3000 BC to 900 AD, overlapped with the Harappan and Chalcolithic eras. In southern India, megalithic culture represented an Iron Age culture, while in the north, cities like Shravasti, Hastinapur, and Kausambi were undergoing their second urbanization.

5.1. Material Life in Megalithic Cultures

Agriculture: Agriculture was the economic foundation, with crops like rice, lentils, barley, pulses, ragi, millets, and horse gram. The introduction of tank irrigation in southern India revolutionized agricultural practices. Pestles and grinding stones found at megalithic sites support this agricultural emphasis.

Animal Husbandry: Domesticated animals included cattle, sheep, goats, dogs, pigs, horses, buffaloes, fowls, and asses. This continuity of Neolithic cattle-keeping traditions underscores the significance of pastoralism in megalithic society.

Hunting & Fishing: Hunting supplemented food supplies, as indicated by equipment like arrowheads, spears, and javelins. Depictions of hunting scenes at sites such as Marayur, Attala, and Hire Benakal further highlight this practice. Terracotta net sinkers from Takalghat and fish-hooks from Khapa and Tangal, along with fish skeleton remains, provide evidence of fishing activities.

Industry and & Trade: The variety of iron artifacts suggests diverse occupations, including carpentry, cobbling, bamboo crafting, blacksmithing, coppersmithing, and goldsmithing. Some megalithic sites were likely craft production centres linked to exchange networks. The discovery of carnelian beads at coastal sites points to an active trade.

5.2. Cultural System in Megalithic Societies

Burial Practices: Megaliths served as burial sites or commemorative memorials, indicating various community interactions through their burial customs. Types of burials included hood stones, menhirs, alignments, solenoid cists, cairn circles, stone circles, and pit burials.

Sedentary Life: Megalithic people lived in villages with sizable populations, favoring urban life but slower to build large cities compared to their Gangetic valley contemporaries. Their houses were typically huts with thatched or reed roofs supported by wooden posts.

Social Organization: Small communities (Band Society), usually under 100 people, exhibited rigid labor divisions based on age and sex. Burial types and house sizes reflect social stratification, with multi-chambered rock-cut tombs and rare bronze or gold artifacts indicating higher-status individuals.

Religious Beliefs: The presence of daily use goods in graves reflects beliefs in an afterlife and the existence of the soul. Animistic practices are inferred from terracotta animal figurines adorned with garlands and ornaments.

5.3. Burial Practices of Megalithic Culture

The burial practices of the Megalithic Culture in India indeed reflect the differences and classification of people, showcasing varied social, economic, and cultural statuses. Megalithic burials, which are large stone constructions associated with death and burial, can be found across various sites in India, including:

1. Brahmagiri (Karnataka):
   - Types of Burials: Cairns, stone circles, and dolmens.
   - Differences: The variations in the size and complexity of the megaliths suggest differences in social status. Larger and more elaborate structures likely indicate higher status individuals.
   - Important Facts: Excavations have revealed a variety of grave goods, including pottery, beads, iron implements, and even gold ornaments, indicating the social hierarchy and the belief in an afterlife.

2. Adichanallur (Tamil Nadu):
   - Types of Burials: Urn burials and pit burials.
   - Differences: The presence of grave goods such as iron weapons, bronze objects, and pottery signifies different social ranks.
   - Important Facts: The site is noted for its rich assemblage of artifacts, providing insights into the social and economic life of the people.

3. Porkalam (Kerala):
   - Types of Burials: Dolmens, cists, and stone circles.

- Differences: Variations in burial styles and the presence of personal ornaments and tools reflect social stratification.
- Important Facts: The discovery of iron implements and weapons suggests that these people were skilled in metallurgy and had a warrior class.

4. Junapani (Maharashtra):
- Types of Burials: Cairn circles and cists.
- Differences: The size and contents of the burials vary, with some containing more valuable items, indicating differences in wealth and status.
- Important Facts: The site is significant for its large number of megalithic structures, providing a wide range of data on burial practices and social organization.

5.3.1. Classification and Social Stratification:

The megalithic burials often include items that indicate the status and occupation of the deceased. For example, burials with weapons and tools suggest a warrior class, while those with jewelry and fine pottery might belong to the elite or wealthy individuals. The differences in burial construction, from simple pit burials to elaborate dolmens and stone circles, further highlight the social hierarchy.

The diverse burial practices also point to regional variations and cultural exchanges among different megalithic communities. The presence of similar megalithic structures across vast regions indicates a shared cultural heritage, yet the specific burial customs and grave goods reflect localized traditions and beliefs.

In summary, the burial practices of the Megalithic Culture in India not only provide insights into the mortuary customs but also reflect the social stratification and cultural diversity of the time. The differences in burial types, grave goods, and construction techniques underscore the varied social statuses and classifications within these ancient communities.

6. Iron Age

The introduction of iron technology in ancient India marked a significant watershed in the development of human history, catalyzing profound changes in socio-economic structures, urbanization, agricultural practices, and state formation. The impact of this technological advancement can be traced through various historical narratives and archaeological findings, reflecting the transformative influence of iron on Indian society.

The earliest evidence of iron use in India dates back to around 1200 BCE. Sites such as Atranjikhera in Uttar Pradesh and Hallur in Karnataka have yielded iron artifacts that suggest the early advent of iron smelting and tool-making technologies. The technology spread unevenly across regions, with the Ganga-Yamuna doab, the Deccan, and Eastern India showing early signs of iron use, while the Northwest and the far South integrated iron later. Ancient texts, including the Vedas, refer to iron as "Shyam Ayas," indicating its known existence and use during the late Vedic period.

6.1. Impact of Iron

1. Forest Clearance and Expansion of Agriculture: Iron tools, such as ploughshares and axes, enabled large-scale clearance of dense forests, particularly in the Gangetic plains, facilitating the expansion of agricultural land and settlement. The use of iron ploughshares enhanced agricultural productivity by allowing deeper tillage of soil, which was not possible with earlier copper or stone tools.

2. Urbanization and Second Urbanization: Expansion of Settlements: The clearing of forests and expansion of arable land contributed to the growth of rural settlements, which eventually evolved into urban centers during the period known as the "Second Urbanization" around 600 BCE . Key urban centers like Pataliputra, Ujjain, and Varanasi developed, becoming hubs of trade, administration, and culture.

3. State Formation and Administration: The ability to cultivate larger tracts of land increased agricultural surplus, which in turn boosted state revenues. This surplus facilitated the emergence of complex administrative systems and state structures. The expansion of cultivable land and the resulting wealth enhanced the power of the king, who became the central figure responsible for land distribution, law and order, and revenue collection.

4. Social Hierarchies and Varna System: The Kshatriyas, as warriors and rulers, gained prominence in society due to their role in defending and expanding territories. This elevated their status above the Brahmins in certain regions. The increased agricultural productivity and trade led to a more complex social hierarchy, with Vaishyas and Shudras playing significant roles in the economic activities of the growing urban centers.

5. Iron Craftsmanship: The advancements in iron technology led to the production of more durable tools and weapons, which were crucial for both

agricultural practices and warfare. This facilitated the expansion of territories and the defence against invasions.

6. Trade and Economic Growth: The surplus in agricultural production and the establishment of urban centres fostered trade networks, both within India and with distant regions such as Persia and Southeast Asia.

7. Influence on Religious and Cultural Life: Shift in Religious Practices: The use of iron and the subsequent socio-economic transformations also influenced religious practices and ideologies. For instance, the rise of new religious movements such as Buddhism and Jainism during the period of Second Urbanization reflected the changing social dynamics.

	Sites	Phase	Location & Excavator	Finds
1.	Adamgasr	Mesolithic (5500 B.C.)	Narmada valley, Hoshangabad, M.P.	Rock-shelters, animal bones & pottery
2.	Anjira	Neolithic	Surab Valley, Central Baluchistan	Chert blade industry, bone awls
3.	Atranjikheda	Iron Age	Uttar Pradesh	Iron objects, burnt bricks
4.	Birbhanpur	Mesolithic	Damodar river (W.B)	Post-holes, combined factory
5.	Brahmagiri	Neolithic/Megalithic	Karnataka, *S.M. Wheeler*	South Indian Neolithic sites
6.	Burzahom	Neolithic (3000-1700 B.C)	Kashmir, *Yale*	Two occupation levels
7.	Chandoli	Chalcolithic (1500-1050 B.C)	Maharashtra	Evidence of tin and lead alloying
8.	Chechar-Kutubpur	Neolithic	Biddupur-on the bank of Ganga	Red, grey, spouted and black wares
9.	Chirand	Neolithic and Chalcolithic (2000-1000 B.C)	Allahabad (U.P) / Allahabad University	Crude hard made pottery
10.	Diamabad	Chalcolithic (1400-1000 B.C)	Parvar valley (Maharashtra)	Jorwe culture site
11.	Gumla	Neolithic/Bronze Age	Indus & Gomal rivers by Peshawar University	Aceramic, microliths, cattle bones
12.	Hastinapur	OCP & PGW	Uttar Pradesh	Two glass bangles, cultivated crops, bone dice, glass beads
13.	Lekhania	Mesolithic (1710 B.C.)	Mirzapur (U.P.) / Allahabad University	Rock-shelters
14.	Morhana Pahar	Mesolithic	Narmada Valley, U.P. / A.C. Carlleyle	Rock-paintings & shelters
15.	Waltgal	Southern Neolithic (3000-2000 B.C)	Raichur Doab	Microlithic Industry, handmade pottery

Some Facts of Chalcolithic Culture					
S.N.	Culture	Period	Ware-features	Grown crops	Sites
1	Ahar Culture	2800-1500 B .C	White designed black and red ware.	rice, jwar, ragi, gram, bajra, kulthi , lentils	Ahar, Balahal, Gilund. (Rajasthan)
2	Kayatha culture	2450-1700 B .C	Chocolate-coloured slipped ware, red painted buff ware, combed ware.	rice, jwar, ragi, gram, bajra, kulthi, lentils	Chambal and its tributaries. (Madhya Pradesh)
3	Malwa Culture	1900-1400 B .C	The walwas ware is coarse in fabric with a thick buff surface.	Wheat & barley.	Narmada and its tributaries, Navada toli, Eran, Nagada. (The largest chalcolithic settlement) in M.P.
4	Savalda Culture	2300-200 B.C	Early Farming community in Deccan		Dlmria (Maharashtra)
5	Jorwe Culture	1500-900 B.C	painted black on red with matt surface dishes on a stand, sprouted vases, stemmed cups, jars, basins etc.	rice, jwar, ragi, gram, bajra, kulthi, lentil.	Maharashtra, Prakash, Daimabad and Inamgaon.
6	Prabhas Culture	2000-1400 B.C	Lustrous Red Ware		
7	Rangpur Culture	1700 - 1400 B.C	Lustrous Red Ware (Harappa-Indus belong to this culture civilisation)		Gheol and Kallubhar rivers in Gujarat

Chapter 3| Indus Valley Civilization

The Harappan civilisation was the first urban civilisation in South Asia, contemporaneous with the civilisations of Mesopotamia and Egypt. Of the three aforementioned civilisations, the Harappan civilisation occupied the most area (about 8,00,000 sq km). It was in 1921 that Daya Ram Sahni got the site excavated at Harappa in the Montgomery district of Punjab (now in Pakistan) on the left bank of Ravi. Just after one year in 1922, Rakhal Das Banerjee discovered the remains of civilization at Mohenjodaro in the Larkana district of Sindh, now in Pakistan.

1. IVC or Harrapan?

Earlier historians had called this civilisation the Indus Valley Civilisation, but since then, major settlements have been excavated in the Ghaggar-Hakra belt that spread far beyond the Indus region. Harappa, as the first archaeological site to be discovered, therefore gives its name to the entire civilisation. John Marshall was the first scholar to call this civilization as Indus Valley Civilization. The vast geographical extent of the civilization should make the objection to the terms 'Indus' or 'Indus Valley' civilization obvious. The terms 'Indus–Sarasvati' or 'Sindhu–Sarasvati' civilization is also used by some scholars.

2. Origin

Issues of origin are always complex and often contentious. In his report on Mohenjodaro, John Marshall asserted that the Indus civilization must have had a long antecedent history on the soil of India. However, there were others who put forward **diffusionist** explanations. According to E. J. H. Mackay, a migration of people from Sumer (southern Mesopotamia) may have led to the Harappan civilization. Mortimer Wheeler argued for a migration of ideas, not people—the idea of civilization was in the air of West Asia in the 3rd millennium BCE and the founders of the Harappan civilization had a model of civilization before them.

3. General Features of the Indus Valley Civilization

Urban or Rural: The fact that the Harappan civilization was urban does not mean that all or even most of its settlements had an urban character. A majority were in fact villages.

Size of Settlements: It is not easy to estimate the exact size of ancient settlements, as they are often spread over many mounds and buried under layers of alluvium. The largest settlements include Mohenjodaro (over 200 ha), Harappa (over 150 ha), Ganweriwala (over 81.5 ha), Rakhigarhi (over 80 ha), and Dholavira (about 100 ha).

3.1. Town Planning

The streets and houses of Harappan cities were once thought to be laid on a grid pattern oriented north–south and east–west. There is no strict correlation between the level of planning and the size of a settlement. For example, the relatively small size of Lothal shows a much higher level of planning than Kalibangan, which is twice its size. The details of the plans differ.

Mohenjodaro, Harappa, and Kalibangan have a similar layout, consisting of a raised citadel complex and a lower city. At Lothal and Surkotada, the citadel complex is not separate; it is located within the main settlement. In its most fully developed phase, Dholavira consisted of not two but three parts—the citadel, middle town, and lower town. The fact that some house walls at Mohenjodaro survive up to a height of 5 m is a tribute to the strength of the bricks and the brick-laying skill of the Harappans. A striking feature of Harappan structures is the uniformity in the average size of the bricks—7 × 14 × 28 cm for houses and 10 × 20 × 40 cm for city walls. People lived in houses of different sizes, mostly consisting of rooms arranged around a central courtyard. Doorways and windows generally faced the side lanes and rarely opened onto the main streets. There are remains of staircases that may have led to the roof or a second storey. Floors were usually made of hard-packed earth, often re-plastered or covered with sand. Roofs may have been made of wooden beams covered with reeds and packed clay.

Bathrooms and toilets are facilities people use every day but which most books on ancient history rarely discuss. In the case of the Harappan civilization, there is quite a bit of information on this aspect. Many houses or groups of houses had separate bathing areas and toilets. Well-laid-out streets and side lanes associated with an efficient and well-planned drainage system are other notable features of Harappan settlements. Even the smaller towns and villages had impressive drainage systems. At Harappa and Mohenjodaro, terracotta drain pipes directed wastewater into open street drains made of baked bricks.

The Harappans made elaborate arrangements for water for drinking and bathing. It is possible that

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frequent bathing also had a religious or ritualistic aspect. The sources of water were rivers, wells, and reservoirs or cisterns. Mohenjodaro is noted for its large number of wells. Harappa had much fewer wells but a depression in the centre of the city may represent a tank or reservoir that served the city's inhabitants. There are a few wells at Dholavira, which is noted more for its impressive water reservoirs lined with stone.

3.2. Religious life

Harappan people had features of *Hinduism*, such as worship of the mother Goddess, Pashupati, Shiva, Sacred animals, trees, etc. *Clay figures* of the mother goddess as the symbol of fertility have been found. The three-faced deity wearing a horned head-dress, seated cross-legged on a throne, and surrounded by elephant, tiger, buffalo and rhinoceros, with deer appearing under the seat is the representation of Lord Shiva. The female generative organ (yoni) shows that people were worshipping the Mother Goddess. At Kalibangan, fire altars have been discovered. We do not find any tracer of temples or places for worship at any of the Harappan sites.

Tree worshipping was a culture in this civilization. The **Pipal tree** was the most worshipped tree. They in armlets and Talisman. On a seal, a six-rayed motif is depicted signifying the sun. Clay models of oxen were used as motive offerings. Tablets of clay and copper were used as armlets. Swastik and cross signs were **harbingers** of good luck. Daya Ram Shahni has discovered the famous dancing girl called '**Devadasi**' which is depicted on a seal.

Funerary Customs: Three forms of burials have been found at Mohenjodaro, viz, **complete burials**, **Fractional burials** (only, a collection of bones are buried after the exposure of the body of wild beasts and birds) and **part-cremation burials.**

3.3. Economic Life

Harappan people were comfortable living and prosperous. Their richness was due to surplus agriculture, cattle rearing, and proficiency in various crafts and trades.

Agriculture: Agriculture was the backbone of the Harappan people. Sindh was a fertile part of the country. They produced wheat, barley, peas, kodon, sanwa, jowar, ragi, etc. Other crops including dates, seasam and mustard were also grown. It seems that as early as 180 B.C. the people of Lothal used rice whose remains have been found. The evidence of the sugarcane has not been found yet. Though its presence is to be expected. At Lothal and Rangpur, rice husks and spikelets were found embedded in clay and pottery. A fragment of woven cotton cloth has been found at Mohenjodaro. *The Indus people were the earliest people to produce cotton.* Gabar bands or nalas enclosed by dams were used for storing the water which is found in Baluchistan and Afghanistan. No evidence of channel or canal irrigation has been discovered from the sites of this civilization.

Animal Husbandry: Animals were kept on a large scale and *oxen, buffaloes* (Bubalus bubalis), *goats* (Sus cristatus), *sheep*, and *pigs* were domesticated. *Dogs* and *cats* were also domesticated. The *humped bulls* were favoured by the Harappans. *Asses* and *Camels* were used as *beasts of burden*. Camel bones are reported at Kalibangan. The only plausible evidence of the horse comes from Surkotada belonging to around 2000 B.C. Elephants were well known to the Harappans. They were also acquainted with the rhinoceros, spotted deer, hog deer, wild pig, etc.

Trade and Commerce: Cities like Mohenjodaro, Harappa and Lothal were important centres for metallurgy, producing tools and weapons as well as kitchenware. Rice seems to have been imported to Punjab from Gujarat. Lothal and Surkotada filled a large gap in the growing demand for cotton. Sea shells were exported from Balakot and Lothal to Baluchistan as well as the Indus. Dates, Shilajeet were found at Mohenjodaro.

Major Imports for Indus Valley Civilization

- Gold from Kolar (Karnataka), Afghanistan, Persia
- Silver from Afghanistan, Persia (Iran)
- Copper from Khetri (Rajasthan), Baluchistan, Arabia
- Tin from Afghanistan, Central Asia, Bihar
- Agates from Western India.
- Chalcedony from Saurashtra
- Lead from Rajasthan, South India, Afghanistan, Iran
- Lapis Lazuri from Badakshan (Afghanistan) & Sapphire
- Torquise from Central Asia, Iran.
- Amethyst from Maharashtra
- Jade from Central Asia
- Carnelian from Saurashtra

Trade Mechanism: A copper scale has been found in Harappa. This scale is divided into many parts. The weights were made of stone and they were cubical and spherical in shape. They followed the series in doubling from 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64 and then

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160, 320, 640 and so forth. The smallest weight is found of 13.64 grams. The unit of ratio was 16 equivalents to 13.64 grams.

Crafts and Industries: Weaving was the chief industry at Mohenjodaro. Pottery was an important industry. They were also acquainted with the art of dying and the art of smelting metals. Balakot and Chanhudaro were for shell working and Bangle making Charnnudaro was the centre for the manufacture of beads of carnelian. Bronze Smiths produced images, utensils, tools and weapons. Brick-laying was an important craft of that time. The Harappans had knowledge of boat-making, seal-making and terracotta manufacturing. The Harappans had experts bead makers and Goldsmiths.

Transport and Communications: Harappans had a good transportation system for trade. They used bullock carts and rarely horse carts for on-land journeys. They practised navigation on the coast of the Arabian Sea. Representation of ships and boats are found on seals or graffiti at Harappa.

3.4. Language and Script

The language of the Harappans is still unknown. The number of pictorial signs in the script varies according to different archaeologists. For example G.R. Hunter (1932)-149 signs, A. H.Dani (1963) - 537, Asko Parpola (1973)-396, etc. Those symbols were not alphabetic in their order. They were written in both right to left and left to right.

3.5. Social Life

Social Hierarchy: Indus people believed in simple living and high thinking. The traditional family was the unit of the society. Women were given high honour in society. The family was regulated in the name of the mother. The Indus Civilization had four different classes in which *society was divided - Scholars, warriors, businessmen and labourers*.

Food habits: The Harappans were *non-vegetarians*. Wheat, barley and bread were commonly used. They used to eat *fish, beef, mutton, poultry* occasionally. Coconut, dates, pomegranate, lemon and watermelon were the chief fruits they ate.

Entertainment: They preferred indoor hobbies to outdoor amusements. **Dance** and **music** were their popular amusements. Dices, chess, fishing, hunting and swimming were the sources of entertainment. Marble dolls and animal toys show that the children of Mohenjodaro were well-supplied with playthings.

Costumes, ornaments and Jewellery: The ladies were scantily dressed. They wore a short skirt that reached up to the knee; and it was held by a girdle - a string of beads. *Dhoti* wearing was also in practice. Perhaps they did not use footwear. Cotton was used. There is no evidence of linen or wool. Different types of **hairstyles** were used but very long beards were not preferred. The dancing girl from Mohenjodaro has a ponytail. Beards were trimmed and upper lips were shaven. Completely shaven faces with a small beard on the chin are also noticed.

Mirrors of bronze were very common. Men and women both were fond of **ornaments**. Women wore a fan-shaped headdress. Small cones of Gold, Silver, Copper and Faience were worn on the sides of the head. The Forehead was decorated with a **fillet** or a **headband**. **Ear-rings** were made of coils of gold, silver, copper or faience. Probably no nose ornaments were used.

3.6. Political life

Urbanization represents radical socio-political change. The Harappan political system was organised on the pattern of '*city states*', which were highly disciplined on account of dominant social controls. Harappan rulers were more concerned with commerce than with conquests, and Harappa was possibly ruled by a class of merchants. Harappa was ruled by the two capital cities. The distance between the two capitals was 350 miles.

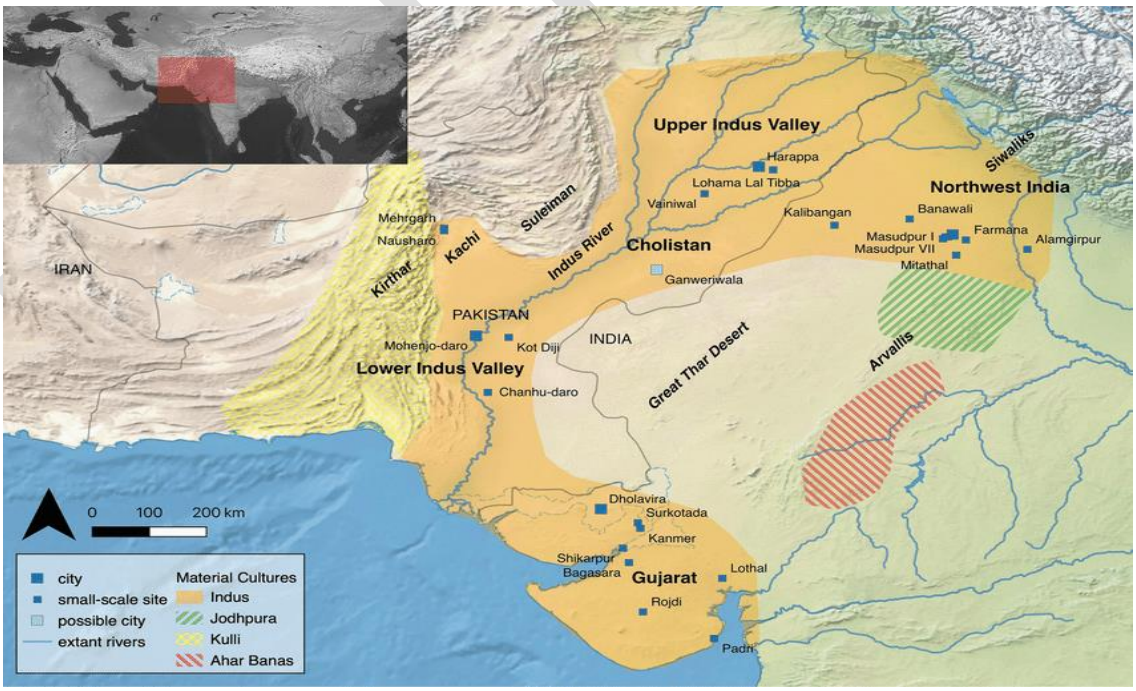
5. Decline of Indus Valley Civilization

At some point in time, things started going wrong in the Harappan cities. Decline had set in at Mohenjodaro by 1900 BCE and the settlement had come to an end by 1750 BCE. One of the most popular explanations for the decline of the Harappan civilization is one for which there is the least evidence. The idea that the civilization was destroyed by Aryan invaders was first put forward by Ramaprasad Chanda, he later changed his mind—and was elaborated on by Mortimer Wheeler (1947). Wheeler argued that references in the *Rig Veda* to various kinds of forts, attacks on walled cities, and the epithet *puramdara* (fort destroyer) given to the god Indra must have a historical basis and reflect an Aryan invasion of the Harappan cities. He identified a place called Hariyupiya in the *Rig Veda* with Harappa. Wheeler also pointed to certain skeletal remains found at Mohenjodaro as proof of the Aryan massacre. Several layers of silt at Mohenjodaro give evidence of the city being affected by repeated episodes of Indus floods. M. R.

Sahni, and later Robert L. Raikes. H. T. Lambrick pointed out that the Indus changed its course, moving some 30 miles eastwards, starving Mohenjodaro and its inhabitants of water. The issue of environmental change, i.e., over-cultivation, overgrazing, and excessive cutting of trees for fuel and farming. This would have resulted in decreasing soil fertility, floods, and increasing soil salinity. Shereen Ratnagar (1981) has argued that the decline in the lapis lazuli trade with Mesopotamia was a factor in the decline of the Harappan civilization.

6. Continuity of Indus Valley Civilization

The decline does not mean the total eclipse of all. For this, we can find the historical continuity from the Harappan period to the later periods of Indian history. The worship of 'Pashupati Shiva' and 'Lingam' has survived these days. Similarly, Mother Goddess, sacred tree, animals, serpent, and different religious symbols such as Swastik, etc. which were prevalent in the Harappan religion, were adopted in later Hinduism and are in Vogue in the present time. In the field of Science and Technology, the Indus Civilization greatly contributed to similar future developments. Harappan civilization was the womb of mathematics. The numerical and decimal systems were evolved there from which 'the Vedic mathematics' is based. Punch-marked coins are an important survival of the Indus Valley. The art of making pottery, baked bricks, beads, jewellery, and different utensils, was adopted in the Vedic civilization.



Important Sites and Major Findings				
Year	**Site**	**Location**	**Excavated by**	**Major findings**
1921	Harappa	Sahiwal District, Punjab on the banks of Ravi	Daya Ram Sahni	Piece of Pottery with Indus Script
				Cubical Limestone Weight
				Faience Slag
				Sandstone Statues of Human Anatomy
				Copper Bullock cart
				Granaries
				Coffin burials (Only founded in Harappa)
				Terracotta Figurines
1922	Mohenjo-Daro	Larkana, District of Sind on the bank of Indus	R. D Banerjee	Great bath
				Granary
				Unicorn Seals (Most numbers of it in here)
				Bronze dancing girl statue
				Seal of a man with deer, elephants, tigers and rhinos around- Considered to be a Pashupati Seal
				Steatite statue of Beard man
				Bronze buffalo
1929	Sutkagendor	Baluchistan on Dast river	Stein	Trade point between Harappa and Babylon
				Flint Blades, Shell Beads
				Stone Vessels, Stone Arrowheads
				Bactria-Margiana Archaeological Complex (BMAC) associated Copper-Bronze Disc
1931	Chanhudaro	Mullan Sandha, Sind on the Indus River	N G Majumdar	Bangle Factory
				Ink-Pot
				Bead makers shop
				The footprint of a dog chasing a cat
				Cart with a seated driver
				Note: It is the only city without a citadel
1935	Amri	Close to Baluchistan, on the bank of the Indus River	N G Majumdar	Antelope evidence
				Rhinoceros' evidence
1953	Kalibangan	Hanumangarh District, Rajasthan on the bank of Ghaggar river	Amlanand Ghose	Lower fortified town
				Wooden drainage
				Copper Ox
				Evidence of earthquake
				Wooden plough
				Camel's bone
				Fire alters
				Furrowed land
1953	Lothal	Gujarat on the Bhogva River near the Gulf of Cambay	R. Rao	Port Town
				Graveyard
				Ivory weight balance
				Copper dog
				First manmade port
				Dockyard
				Rice husk
				Fire alters & Chess-playing
1964	Surkotada	Gujarat	J P Joshi	Bones of horses
				Beads
				Stone Covered Beads
1974	Banawali	Fatehabad district of Haryana	R S Bisht	Beads, Barley,
				Oval shaped settlement
				The only city with radial streets
				Toy plough
				The largest number of barley grains
1985	Dholavira	Gujarat in Rann of Kutchchh	R S Bisht	Exclusive water management
				Only site to be divided into three parts
				Giant water reservoirs, Dams
				Unique water harnessing system
				Embankments
				Stadium
				Rock – Cut architecture

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Chapter 4| Vedic Period

The Harappan culture was followed by another great civilisation and culture known as Vedic culture. It is called Vedic Age as its reconstruction is primarily based on using Vedic texts as sources. Indo-Aryans are believed to be the composers of Vedic texts. Indo-Aryans is basically a linguistic term and refers to speakers of a sub-group of the Indo-Iranian branch of the Indo-European family of languages.

There is still no consensus on the original home of Aryans and different theories are postulated which further continue the debate. The earliest Aryans lived in the land of the (Sapta Sindhu) and probably because of their use of horse chariots and superior military technology, they could establish their political dominance in the region. The region was drained by the seven rivers, viz., the Indus (Sindhu), and its five tributaries, namely, the Jhelum (Vatista), Beas (Vipasa), Chenab (Askini), Ravi (Purushni), Sutlej (Sutudri), and the Saraswati (modern Ghaggar Hakra), which covered mostly the areas of eastern Afghanistan, Punjab, and fringes of western U.P. The rare mention of the river Yamuna (twice) and Ganga (only once) is a pointer to the fact that Rig Vedic Aryans had not inhabited that region as yet. The Vedic corpus is generally divided into Early Vedic and Later Vedic texts;

1. The Rig Vedic Period (1500–1000 BCE): Includes the Rig Veda Samhita and other texts of the family. They are called family books as their composition is attributed to the families of certain seer poets, such as Vishvamitra, Atri, Gritsamada, Vasishtha, and Bharadvaja.
2. Later Vedic Literature/Later Vedic Period (1000–600 BCE): Includes Books 1, 8, 9, and 10 of the Rig Veda Samhita, the Samhitas of the Sama Veda, the Yajur and the Atharva Vedas and the Brahmanas, Aranyakas, and Upanishads attached to all the four Vedas.

1. Rig-Vedic Period

There are many texts written under the genre of Vedic literature which belongs to both *shruti and smriti* (Refer to Chapter 1). Later Vedic Periods saw many changes in its social, political, religious and economic life as compared to the Rig Vedic Period.

1.1. Political Life

The *Rig Veda* is pervaded with the aura of warring tribes. About 30 tribes and clans are mentioned. Five tribes—the Yadu, Turvasha, Puru, Anu, and Druhyu—are collectively known as the 'five peoples' (*pancha-jana*). The Purus and Bharatas are the two dominant tribes. Initially, they seem to have been allies, but at some point, they fell apart. The *Rig Veda* mentions a chief of the Purus named Trasadasyu. It also mentions a famous Bharata king named Divodasa and describes his victory over the Dasa ruler Shambara, who had many mountain fortresses. There are about 300 clearly non-Indo-European words in the *Rig Veda*. These 'loan words' show that the Rig Vedic people were interacting with people speaking Dravidian and Munda languages. There are many tribes with non-Indo-Aryan names in the *Rig Veda*, such as the Chumuri, Dhuni, Pipru, and Shambara. The text also refers to Arya chieftains with non-Indo-Aryan names, e.g., Balbutha and Bribu. All this is indicative of processes of cultural interaction.

The Bharata chief Sudas, grandson of Divodasa, fought against a confederacy of 10 tribes. The mention of the Purus, their former allies, as a part of this confederacy, indicates that political alliances were fluid and shifting. Vishvamitra, the Bharata *purohita*, seems to have been replaced by Vasishtha before the battle, reflecting another sort of behind-the-scenes re-alignment. The great battle took place on the banks of the river Parushni (Ravi). The Bharatas won by breaking a natural dam on the river. Marching on to the Yamuna, they defeated a local ruler named Bheda.

The word *rajan* (or *raja*) occurs many times in the family books of the *Rig Veda*. Since a full-fledged monarchical state had not yet emerged, this word is best translated as 'chieftain' or 'noble', rather than as 'king'. The royal priest accompanied the *rajan* to battle, recited prayers, and supervised the performance of rituals. The importance of royal priests such as Vasishtha and Vishvamitra is reflected in many Vedic hymns. *Bali* refers to an offering made to a god; it also means tribute periodically offered by the clansmen to the *rajan*. The *Rig Veda* mentions assemblies such as the ***sabha*** and ***samiti***. The distinctions between their functions are not entirely clear. The *sabha* seems to have been a smaller, more elite gathering, whereas the *samiti* appears to have been a larger assembly presided over by the *rajan*. Such assemblies may have played an important role in the redistribution of

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resources. The *vidatha* has been understood as a tribal assembly with diverse functions.

The family books contain several terms for socio-political units, many of which were based on kinship. These include *jana*, *vish*, *gana*, *grama*, *griha*, and ***kula***. Their precise meaning, however, is not always clear. The *jana* of the *Rig Veda* can be translated as tribe, *vish* is often translated as people in general or as clan, and *gana* as lineage.

1.2. Social Life

Rig Vedic society was a tribal society and its people lived a seminomadic life. Aryan tribes were called *Jana*s. Their chief (*rajan*) was known as the *Gopati* or *Gopa* (protector of cows), and the chief queen was called the *Mahisi*. The *Janas* often had conflicts with the Panis, who used to hide the cattle of Aryans in the forest and were thus deemed the enemies of Aryans. In order to get their cattle back, the Vedic God 'Indra' was invoked and many battles known as *Gavisthi*, *Gaveshana*, *Goshu*, or *Gavyat* (to search for cows) were fought between the Aryans and the Panis.

The society was not divided into caste lines and even the *Rajans*, the *Purohits*, the artisans, etc., were part of the clan networks. The occupation was not based on birth. Members of a family could adopt different occupations. However, certain differences did exist during the period. *Varna* or colour was the basis of the initial differentiation between the Vedic and non-Vedic people. The Vedic people were fair whereas the non-Vedic indigenous people were dark in complexion and spoke a different language. Authors of Rig Veda distinguished themselves from other groups whom they called "*dasyus*" or "*dasas*". The *dasas* were also referred as *a-vrata* (who do not obey the ordinances of the gods) and *akratu* (those who do not perform sacrifices).

Thus, even though a socially organised "*varna* system" was not prevalent and tribal elements were stronger in the society, Rig Vedic society can still not be considered a totally egalitarian society as social stratification was based on the division of labour and gender. The only mention of the four *varnas* was found in the *Purusashukta* of the tenth *mandal* of the Rig Veda, which talks of Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya and Shudra. The Rig Vedic people were familiar with slavery. Initially, there seems to have been some ambiguity about the relative positions of the higher *varna*s. In the *Panchavimsha Brahmana*, where Indra is associated with the creation of the *varna*s, the Rajanya are placed first, followed by the Brahmana and Vaishya. The *Shatapatha Brahmana* also places the Kshatriya first on the list. Elsewhere, in the same text (*Shatapatha Brahmana*) the order is as follows: Brahmana, Vaishya, Rajanya, and Shudra. *Kula* (Family) was the basic social unit and *Kulapa* was the head of the family.

The society was patriarchal in nature, though the women had important positions in the society since they were educated and had access to the assembly. They composed hymns and received *Upanayana.* Women attended the meetings of the *Vidatha*. Girls were free to choose their life partners. There are no instances of child marriage, *sati*, or *purdah* in the Rig Veda. There were a few instances of levirate (marrying the husband's younger brother on the death of the husband) and widow remarriage. Marriage was usually monogamous, though some references to polygyny and polyandry are also found in the Rig Veda.

1.3. Religious Life

The *Rig Veda* reflects the beliefs and practices of a religious aristocracy. It indicates a diversity of religious practices. For instance, there is mention of people who did not worship Indra, and the Dasas and Dasyus are described as not honouring the Vedic gods and not performing sacrifices. The Vedic hymns divide the universe into the sky (*dyu*), earth (*prithvi*), and the middle realm (*antariksha*). The word *deva* (literally, 'shining', 'luminous') is frequently used for the gods. The gods are sometimes also called *asura*s. Initially, this word referred to a powerful being; in later times it came to be used exclusively in a negative sense for demons.

The *Rig Veda* asserts that there are 33 gods associated with the sky, earth, and the intermediate region, but the actual number of deities mentioned in the text is more. Some gods are mentioned more often than others, but there is no fixed order of importance nor a fixed pantheon. Whichever deity is invoked in a particular hymn is spoken of as a supreme god. Apart from the gods, the *Rig Veda* mentions *gandharva*s (celestial beings), *apsara*s (celestial nymphs, wives of the *gandharva*s), and malevolent beings such as *rakshasa*s (demons), *yatudhana*s (sorcerers), and *pishacha*s (spirits of the dead).

Deities were worshipped through prayer and sacrificial rituals (*yajna*s). Seven types of sacrificial priests are mentioned in the *Rig Veda*—the Hotri, Adhvaryu, Agnidh, Maitravaruna, Potri, Neshtri, and Brahmana—each with his particular tasks clearly laid down. Priests were given a fee

(*dakshina*) in return for the important duties they performed. The *Rig Veda* does not mention temples or the worship of images of deities, which were an important aspect of popular Hinduism of later times.

The *Rig Veda* reflects a naturalistic **polytheism**—a belief in many gods who personified natural phenomena. The connection is clear in some cases from the very name of the deity, as in the case of Agni (Fire), Surya (the Sun), and Ushas (Dawn). For instance, although Indra seems to have been originally associated with the thunderstorm, he rapidly outgrew this connection to develop a much more complex personality. The gods were conceived of as anthropomorphic, i.e., as having a physical form similar to that of humans.

Indra is the most frequently invoked god in the *Rig Veda*. He is vigorous and strong, a great warrior, his weapon is the thunderbolt, and he leads the Aryas to victory in battle. He is bounteous (*maghavan*) and loves to drink *soma*. There is a reference to his mother and father (Tvashtri is often mentioned as his father). Indrani is his consort and the Maruts his companions. There are many references to Indra defeating hostile forces and demons such as Vala, Arbuda, and Vishvarupa. The most important myth connected with him is his victory over the serpent demon Vritra. In this episode, Indra is fortified by the god Soma and accompanied by the Maruts. He kills Vritra with his thunderbolt and frees the waters that had been obstructed by the demon. The *Rig Veda* often mentions Indra as Vritrahan, slayer of Vritra.

Agni is another important god and is often invoked along with Indra. He represents many aspects of fire—the fire of the cremation pyre, the fire that engulfs forests, the fire that burns enemies, the heat generated by *tapa*s (austerity), and the heat of sexual desire. Most important of all, as the sacrificial fire, he is the intermediary between gods and humans. In this role, he functions as a divine priest.

Soma—the personification of the *soma* plant—is closely associated with Indra and Agni, and is credited with many similar exploits. He is described as a wise god, one who inspires poets to compose hymns, a great god who rules over the earth and all humans. In later hymns, Soma is identified with the moon. Varuna and Mitra are frequently invoked together in the *Rig Veda* and are members of an eight-member group of gods known as the Adityas. Varuna is associated with ***kshatra*** (secular power), sovereignty, and kingship. He restricts and punishes evil-doers with the fetters or bonds that he has at his command. He is associated with *maya*, an ability to construct forms. He is an all-seeing god who knows what everybody is up to.

Other deities of the *Rig Veda* include the sun god Surya, son of Dyaus. Surya drives away the darkness by riding in his chariot across the sky and is sometimes visualized as a white horse or an eagle. Vayu is the wind god. The Ashvins are twin gods associated with war and fertility. Vishnu is mentioned infrequently in the Rig Vedic hymns. He is a benevolent god and is in places associated with Indra. Very few Rig Vedic hymns are addressed to Rudra, a deity associated with great destructive potential. These refer to several attributes similar to those associated with Shiva of later-day Puranic mythology. Rudra is a god who inspires fear. He is not offered the same sacrifices as the other gods—the offering to him consists of a ball of food thrown on the ground, similar to that used to propitiate spirits.

Ushas, goddess of the dawn, is mentioned 300 times in the *Rig Veda*, and 20 hymns are addressed to her. Representing the victory of light over darkness, she is generous and invoked by those desiring wealth. Aditi, the mother of the Adityas, is another important goddess. Her name means freedom, and she is invoked to bestow freedom from sickness, harm, and evil. Some hymns speak of her as a mother and connect her with the earth and the cow. Raka is a benevolent, bountiful goddess. Sinivali bestows children. Prithvi (Earth) is a minor goddess, most often invoked together with Dyaus. Vach (speech), Ida (literally, 'the milk and butter offered in the sacrifice'), and Sarasvati (representing the river of this name) are some of the other goddesses mentioned in the *Rig Veda*. However, except for Ushas, goddesses have a relatively insignificant presence in the text.

1.4. Economic Life

Since the Rig Vedic society was a pastoral society, cattle rearing was their dominant activity. The chief measure of wealth was cattle and a wealthy man was known as Gomat, that is to say, one who owned many cattle. A large number of words are derived from the word 'gau' meaning cow. Evidence of trade and commerce is meagre, and there was no concept of private property based on land ownership. The clan as a whole enjoyed rights over the resources. The unit of currency was niskha, which was made of gold. Barter was the model of exchange and the cow was an important unit of value. There was no regular revenue system and the kingdom was maintained by the voluntary tribute (bali) of subjects and bounty won in a battle. Gift exchange and redistribution had

an important economic role in the Rig Vedic society. Such exchanges, known as 'prestation', were done not on an individual level but at the group level.

Apart from economic goods, this also included the exchange of other things such as women, courtesies, hospitality, and military assistance. The priests received dana (gifts) and dakshina (sacrificial offering) for their ritualistic services. Shifting agriculture was practised and the fire was used to burn down forest cover and the patch of land thus cleared was then sown. Apart from yava or barley, no other grain is mentioned. The Rig Vedic people used wooden plough (phala, langala, and sira). Vedic god Indra is also described as Urvarajit (winner of fertile fields), and there are also references to Kshetrapati (guardian deity of agricultural fields). They did not use iron technology but were familiar with copper. Also, there have been very less references to metallurgical activities. A lot of other crafts such as cart-making, carpentry, tanning, sewing, and weaving, were mentioned, though the chariot-maker enjoyed a special status in Rig Vedic society. Chariot racing and dice gambling were popular pastimes.

2. Later Vedic Period

2.1. Later Vedic Polity

The Later Vedic Age is characterised by more complexities in social, political, and economic life. In terms of the political context, the tiny tribal settlements of the Vedic period were replaced by comparatively stronger kingdoms, while royal power increased. The core geographical area of the Rig Vedic texts corresponds to Eastern Afghanistan, Punjab, and western U.P., whereas the core geographical area of Later Vedic texts corresponds to the Kuru–Panchala Region, which comprised the Indo-Gangetic divide and the upper Ganga Valley. The term '*Rashtra*' first appeared in this period. The wars were no longer fought for cows but for territories. The predominantly pastoral society of Early Vedic times had become agricultural. Chiefs grew at the expense of the tribal peasantry and handsomely rewarded the priests who helped them in maintaining their authority. It should be noted that even in Later Vedic times, the king did not possess a standing army and tribal units were mustered in times of war. Traces of election of the chief or king appear in late Vedic texts, but hereditary kingship was emerging. The king's influence was further strengthened by ritual enactments such as the *Rajasuya* (which was royal consecration and conferred supreme power on the king), *Vajapeya* (literally meaning drink of strength; it had a chariot race in which royal chariot was made to win against all kinsmen), and *Aswamedha* (unquestioned control over an area in which the royal horse ran uninterrupted). It was slowly turning in its later stages to an a*ge of the janapadas* instead of *janas*. The king was usually a *kshatriya* and the office of the monarch was made almost hereditary. The king was addressed by different names across different regions.

Types of Marriage in the Later Vedic Period

S.N.	Marriage Type	Description
1	Brahma Vivah	Marriage of a girl with a boy of the same Varna with Vedic rites and rituals.
2	Daiva Vivah	When the father donated his daughter to a priest as a part of Dakshina.
3	Arsa Vivah	A token bride price of a Cow and a Bull was given.
4	Prajapati Vivah	Marriage without dowry.
5	Gandharva Vivah	It was a kind of love marriage
6	Asura Vivah	Marriage by Purchase.
7	Paisach Vivah	Seduction of a girl while sleeping or mentally unstable due to a drink
8	Rakshasa Vivah	Marriage by abduction.

2.2. Later Vedic Society

One of the most important changes from the Rig Vedic society was the rise and growth of social differentiation in the form of the *Varna* system. The Later Vedic society was clearly divided into four *varnas*: Brahmanas, Rajanyas or Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras. Another important institution that began to take shape was *ashrama* or the different stages of life. Together with *Varna*, Later Vedic society came to be known as *Varna-ashrama-dharma* society. The upper three classes known as *Dvija* (twice born) discriminated against both *Shudras* and *Chandalas*. Caste exogamy was extensively practised and a rigid social hierarchy developed, which restricted the social mobility of the earlier period. The increasing cult of sacrifices added enormously to the power of the Brahmanas. Education was largely confined to *dvija* castes and began with the investiture ceremony (*Upanayana*), although women were also initiated at times. Assemblies were then dominated by nobles and affluent men and women were no longer permitted to attend assemblies. *Sabha* and *Samities* continued to hold ground, though not like the Rig Vedic Age, but the

vidatha completely disappeared. The Later Vedic family became large enough to be called a joint family, with three or four generations living together.

The rows of hearths discovered at Atranjikhera and at Ahichchhtra (both in western Uttar Pradesh) show that these were meant for communal feeding or for cooking the food of large families. In the family, a patrimonial (authority of the father) system developed and women were generally confined to household chores and subordinate positions. As compared to the Rig Vedic age, women lost importance in society and there have been references to rare instances of *sati* and child marriage. In one text, women have been counted as a vice along with dice and wine. In another text, a daughter has been said to be the source of all sorrows.

The institution of *gotra* appeared in the Later Vedic culture. Literally, it means 'cow pen' or the place where cattle belonging to the whole clan are kept, but in the course of time, it meant descent from a common ancestor. Marriage between persons of the same *gotra* was forbidden. There were legendary seers, such as Kashyapa, Vashista, Bhrigu, Gautama, Bhardwaj, Attri, Vishwamitra, and Agastya, after whom the *gotras* were named. Kshatriyas and Vaishyas took the same *gotra* names as the families of Brahmans who traditionally performed their domestic rituals. There is mention of the *Chandrayana* Penance for men marrying women of the same *gotra*. *Ashrama* or the four stages of life were prescribed but were not religiously followed. The institution of marriage was also becoming wider in the later Vedic period. The marriage of a man from higher Varna with a girl from lower Varna was called "Anuloma Vivah". It was allowed by the sacred texts. The marriage of a girl of higher Varna with a man of a lower Varna was called "Pratiloma Vivah" and it was not allowed in the texts.

2.3. Later Vedic Age Economy

The Later Vedic culture is also called as PGW–Iron Phase culture, as a particular kind of pottery (painted grey ware) was used during that phase. The main factor in the expansion of the Aryan culture during the Later Vedic period was the beginning of the use of iron, which was introduced around 1000 BCE and is mentioned as *Krishna Ayas*/*Shyama Ayas.* The Rig Vedic people knew of a metal, called *ayas*, which was either copper or bronze. The society was largely rural. However, towards the end of the period, there are traces of the beginning of urbanism (as *nagar* in the sense of a town is mentioned in the *Taittiriya Aranyaka*).

Agriculture emerged as the chief means of livelihood of the Later Vedic people. The forests were cleared by burning the trees, which is also mentioned in the *Satapatha Brahamana* (ruler **Videha Madhava** burned the forests between river Saraswati to river Sedanira or Gandak). Cultivation was done by the plough. Mixed farming (cultivation along with herding) was one of the prime occupations of the Later Vedic people. The land was still communally owned over which the '*vish*' (clan) had many participatory rights, but it was recognised as property and the head of the household who owned the land was termed as '*Grahpati*'. Rice *(Vrihi)* and wheat *(Godhuma)* became the staple diet of the people and lentils were also grown. Also, with the beginning of food production, agricultural produce began to be offered in the rituals. The items of *dana* and *dakshina* included cooked rice. *Tila*, from which the first widely used vegetable food oil was derived increasingly, came to be used in rituals.

Diverse arts and crafts were practised in the Later Vedic period. Tin, lead, silver, iron, gold, bronze, and copper were known to Later Vedic people. There were probably good smiths and smelters as a lot of copper objects have been found at PGW Sites. People had obtained knowledge of glass manufacturing too. *Shresthins* indicate the guilds or organisation of merchants. The exchange was still via barter, but *Niskha* was used as a convenient unit of value although not as a typical currency. Wagons drawn by oxen were probably the most used mode of transport. The Later Vedic people were acquainted with four types of pottery: Painted Grey Ware, Black and Red Ware, Black-slipped Ware and Red Ware. Unlike the Rig Vedic age where only voluntary offerings were taken and per se no revenue collection was done, in the Later Vedic age, the collection of taxes and tributes was made mandatory and was done by *Sangrihitri*. It is equally interesting to note that the Vaishyas appear to be the only tribute payers in Later Vedic times.

2.4. Later Vedic Age Religion

The Later Vedic culture was focused on the centrality of the cult of sacrifice. Sacrifice became more important and elaborate, and assumed both public and domestic character. There was an increase in the frequency and number of the *yajnas*, which generally involved the killing of animals on a large scale and the destruction of cattle wealth. This was probably the result of the growing importance of a class of Brahmanas and their efforts to maintain

their supremacy in the changing society. These *yajnas* brought to them a large amount of wealth in the form of *dana* and *dakshina*. Some of the important *yajnas* were − *Ashvamedha*, *Vajapeya*, *Rajasuya*, etc. The purpose of these *yajnas* was two-fold. Firstly, it established the authority of the chiefs over the people, and secondly, it reinforced the territorial aspect of the polity since people from all over the kingdom were invited to these sacrifices.

Changes in material life naturally resulted in a change in their attitude towards gods and goddesses as well. The two most important Rig Vedic Gods, Indra and Agni, lost their importance and instead of them, Prajapati (the creator) became supreme. Some of the other minor gods became prominent, such as **Vishnu** (conceived as the preserver and protector of people) and **Rudra** (the god of animals). Idolatry appears in the late Vedic phase and just as the society was divided in the later Vedic phase in terms of social classes, similarly some of the social orders adopted their own deities. For example, **Pushan** (who was supposed to look after cattle) came to be regarded as the god of the Shudras. However, towards the end of the Later Vedic age, a strong reaction began to emerge against priestly domination, cults and sacrifices, especially in the land of Panchala and Videha where, around 600 BCE, the Upanishads were compiled.

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Chapter 5| Mahajanpad Era & Rise of Magadh

The sixth century BCE is often regarded as a major turning point in early Indian history. It is an era associated with early states, cities, the growing use of iron, the development of coinage, etc. It also witnessed the growth of diverse systems of thought, including Buddhism and Jainism. Clearly, these were amongst the most important Mahajanpadas. While most Mahajanpadas were ruled by kings, some, known as ganas or sanghas, were oligarchies, where power was shared by a number of men, often collectively called rajas. Each Mahajanpadas had a capital city, which was often fortified. Maintaining these fortified cities as well as providing for incipient armies and bureaucracies required resources. From the sixth century BCE onwards, Brahmanas began composing Sanskrit texts known as the Dharmasutras. These laid down norms for rulers (as well as for other social categories), who were ideally expected to be Kshatriyas. Rulers were advised to collect taxes and tribute from cultivators, traders and artisans. Gradually, some states acquired standing armies and maintained regular bureaucracies. Others continued to depend on the militia, recruited, more often than not, from the peasantry.

Janapada means the land where a Jana (a people, clan or tribe) sets its foot or settles. It is a word used in both Prakrit and Sanskrit.

Oligarchy refers to a form of government where power is exercised by a group of men.

Difference between Gana-Sanghas and Kingdoms	
Gana-Sangha	**Kingdoms**
The chief office was not hereditary and was known as Ganapati or Ganaraja. The Ganas were located in or near the Himalayan foothills in eastern India. Representative form of government. The council discussed and debated the issues in a hall, called Santhagara. Salakas (pieces of wood) were used for voting and Salaka-Gahapaka (collector of votes) ensured honesty and impartiality. The Gana-Sanghas had only two strata- the Kshatriya Rajakula (ruling families) and the Dasa Karmakara (slaves and labourers). Gana Sanghas were more tolerant than the kingdoms. It is because of this tolerance – that Mahavira (Jainism, belonged to the Vajji confederacy) and Buddha (Buddhism, belonged to the Shakya clan) were able to propagate their philosophy in a more unrestricted way in Gana-Sanghas as compared to Kingdoms.	All the powers were vested with the King and his family. The majority of the kingdoms occupied the fertile alluvial tracts of the Ganga Valley. Political power was concentrated in the king who was assisted by ministers, and advisory councils such as Parishad and Sabha. However, with the emergence of the concept of the divinity of the king and more emphasis on priestly rituals, the centrality of the popular assemblies was reduced. The focus was mainly on caste loyalties and loyalty towards the king. The Brahmanical political, social and religious theory was more deeply entrenched in the kingdoms.

Sixteen Mahajanpadas

1. The kingdom of Kashi was situated near its capital city Varanasi. The Jatakas refer to a longstanding rivalry between the kingdoms of Kashi and Kosala, also with Anga and Magadha.

2. The powerful kingdom Kosala had many important towns such as Saketa and Ayodhya including Shravasti as its capital city. Kosala succeeded in conquering Kashi. Pasenadi (Prasenajit), king of Kosala, was the Buddha's contemporary. Kosala and Magadha were linked through matrimonial ties during the time of Prasenajit and the Magadhan king Bimbisara.

3. Anga corresponded roughly to the present-day Bhagalpur and Monghyr districts of Bihar. The Ganga bordered it on the north. Its capital Champa (once known as Malini) was one of the greatest cities.

4. The kingdom of Magadha roughly covered the modern Patna and Gaya districts of Bihar. It was bounded by the Ganga, Son, and Champa rivers on the north, west, and east respectively and the Vindhyan spurs on the south. Its capital was initially Girivraja or Rajagriha, near modern Rajgir. This dynasty came to an end in the 6th century BCE, making way for the Haryankas. Later on, Udain shifted its capital to Patliputra.

5. The principality of the Vajji (Vrijji) was in eastern India, north of the Ganga, extending up to the Nepal hills. They were a confederacy of eight or nine clans. The most important members of the confederacy were the Vajjis, Lichchhavis, Videhas, and Nayas/Jnatrikas. The Vajji confederacy is said to have been led by Chetaka, who was the brother of Trishala (mother of Mahavira) and father of Chellana, wife of the Magadhan king Bimbisara.

6. The Malla principality was located to the west of the Vajjis and consisted of a confederacy of nine clans. There were two political centres—at Kusinara and Pava. The Mallas are said to have originally been a monarchy.

7. The Chedi kingdom was situated in the eastern part of Bundelkhand in central India. Its capital was Sotthivatinagara, probably the same as the Shuktimati or Shuktisahvaya of the *Mahabharata*.

8. Vatsa or Vamsa, south of the Ganga, was noted for its fine cotton textiles. Its capital was Kaushambi, identified with Kosam village on the right bank of the Yamuna. Legends recount the rivalry between kings Udayana of Vatsa and Pradyota of Avanti, and refer to a love affair and marriage between Udayana and Vasavadatta, Pradyota's daughter.

9. The Kuru kingdom was ruled by kings belonging to the Yuddhitthila *gotta*, i.e., the family of Yudhishthira, from their capital at Indapatta (Indraprastha).

10. The kingdom of Panchala included the Rohilkhand area and part of the central doab region, and was divided into two parts by the Ganga. The famous city of Kanyakubja or Kanauj was located in this kingdom.

11. The principality of the Matsyas was located in the Jaipur area in Rajasthan, extending into the Alwar and Bharatpur areas as well. Their capital was Viratanagara (modern Bairat), named after Virata, founder of the kingdom. Buddhist texts usually associate the Matsyas with the Shurasenas.

12. The Shurasenas had their capital at Mathura on the Yamuna. Buddhist tradition describes Avantiputra, king of the Shurasenas, as a disciple of the Buddha.

13. Assaka (Ashmaka/Ashvaka) kingdom was situated in the northwest. Its capital was Potana/Podana or Potali, identified with modern Bodhan.

14. Avanti, in the Malwa region of central India, was divided into a northern and a southern part by the Vindhyas. The two important towns of this kingdom were Mahishmati (identified with modern Maheshwar) and Ujjayini (near modern Ujjain), both of which are mentioned in ancient texts as its capital. Pradyota was a famous king of Avanti, during whose time this kingdom was involved in conflicts with Vatsa, Magadha, and Kosala.

15. The kingdom of Gandhara comprised the modern Peshawar and Rawalpindi districts of Pakistan and the Kashmir valley. Its capital Takshashila (Taxila) was a major centre of trade and learning. King Pukkusati or Pushkarasarin ruled over Gandhara in the mid-6th century BCE.

16. Kamboja included the area around Rajaori, including the Hazara district of the North-West Frontier Province of Pakistan, and probably extended up to Kafi ristan. The Kambojas were a monarchy in the 6th century BCE, but the *Arthashastra* refers to them as a *sangha*.

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Rise of Magadh

Between the sixth and the fourth centuries BCE, Magadha (in present-day Bihar) became the most powerful *mahajanapada*. Modern historians explain this development in a variety of ways: Magadha was a region where agriculture was especially productive. Besides, iron mines (in present-day Jharkhand) were accessible and provided resources for tools and weapons. Elephants, an important component of the army, were found in forests in the region. Also, the Ganga and its tributaries provided a means of cheap and convenient communication. However, early Buddhist and Jaina writers who wrote about Magadha attributed its power to the policies of individuals: ruthlessly ambitious kings of whom Bimbisara, Ajatasattu and Mahapadma Nanda are the best known, and their ministers, who helped implement their policies. The political conflict among the Mahajanapadas ultimately led to the emergence of Magadha as the most powerful state and the centre of a vast empire.

Haryanka Dynasty

Magadha's rise to political supremacy began with **Bimbisara** who ruled for 52 years, from 544 to 492 BCE. Through his conquests and diplomacy, Bimbisara made Magadha the paramount power. He pursued a three-pronged policy: matrimonial alliances, friendship with strong rulers, and conquest of weak neighbours to expand the empire. Its capital was Rajgriha (Girivraja), which was an impressive city and almost impregnable as surrounded by five hills, the openings in which were closed by stone walls on all sides. Earlier, Bimbisara had a rivalry with Avanti's king Pradyota, but later became friends and Bimbisara even sent his royal physician Jivaka to Ujjain (along Dakshinapatha to Avanti) when Pradyota had jaundice. He conquered Anga by defeating its ruler, Brahmadatta. He took three wives: His first wife was from Kosala named Mahakoshala (sister of Prasenjit), who brought in dowry the territory of Kashi, which yielded a revenue of 1,00,000 coins. Lichchhavi Princess Chellana from Vaishali, who gave birth to Ajatashatru, and Khema, daughter of the chief of the Madra clan (Punjab).

Ajatashatru (492-460 BCE): Son of Bimbisara, being impatient to rule Magadha, is believed to have killed his father and seized the throne. Most powerful and aggressive ruler of the Haryanka dynasty and followed his father's expansionist policy through military conquest. He annexed Kosala (ruled by Prasenjit). He first came into conflict with his maternal uncle Prasenjit, who was aggrieved by the treatment meted out to Bimbisara. He asked Ajatashatru to return the territory of Kashi, which was given to his mother in dowry. Ajatashatru refused, and it was only after a fierce battle that Prasenjit agreed to leave Kashi with Magadha. Similarly, he fought with his maternal grandfather, Chetak, the chief of Vaishali and after 16 long years of war, Ajatashatru succeeded in breaking the might of Vaishali. He used two innovative military weapons: War engine, which was used to those stones like catapults (Mahashilakantaka), Chariot with mace for mass-killing (Rathamusala). He began the fortification of Rajgriha to meet the danger of invasion posed by the ruler of Avanti (who had earlier defeated the Vatsas of Kaushambi). The Buddha died during his reign. Ajatashatru arranged the first Buddhist council.

Udayabhadra (Udayin) (460-444 BCE) succeeded his father. He founded the new capital at Pataliputra (modern Patna), situated at the confluence of the Ganga and Son rivers. Pataliputra had a very strategic location as it lay at the centre of the Magadhan kingdom, which then extended from the Himalayas in the north to the Chhotanagpur Hills in the south. Probably he was murdered at the instigation of Palaka, the king of Avanti.

Shishunaga Dynasty

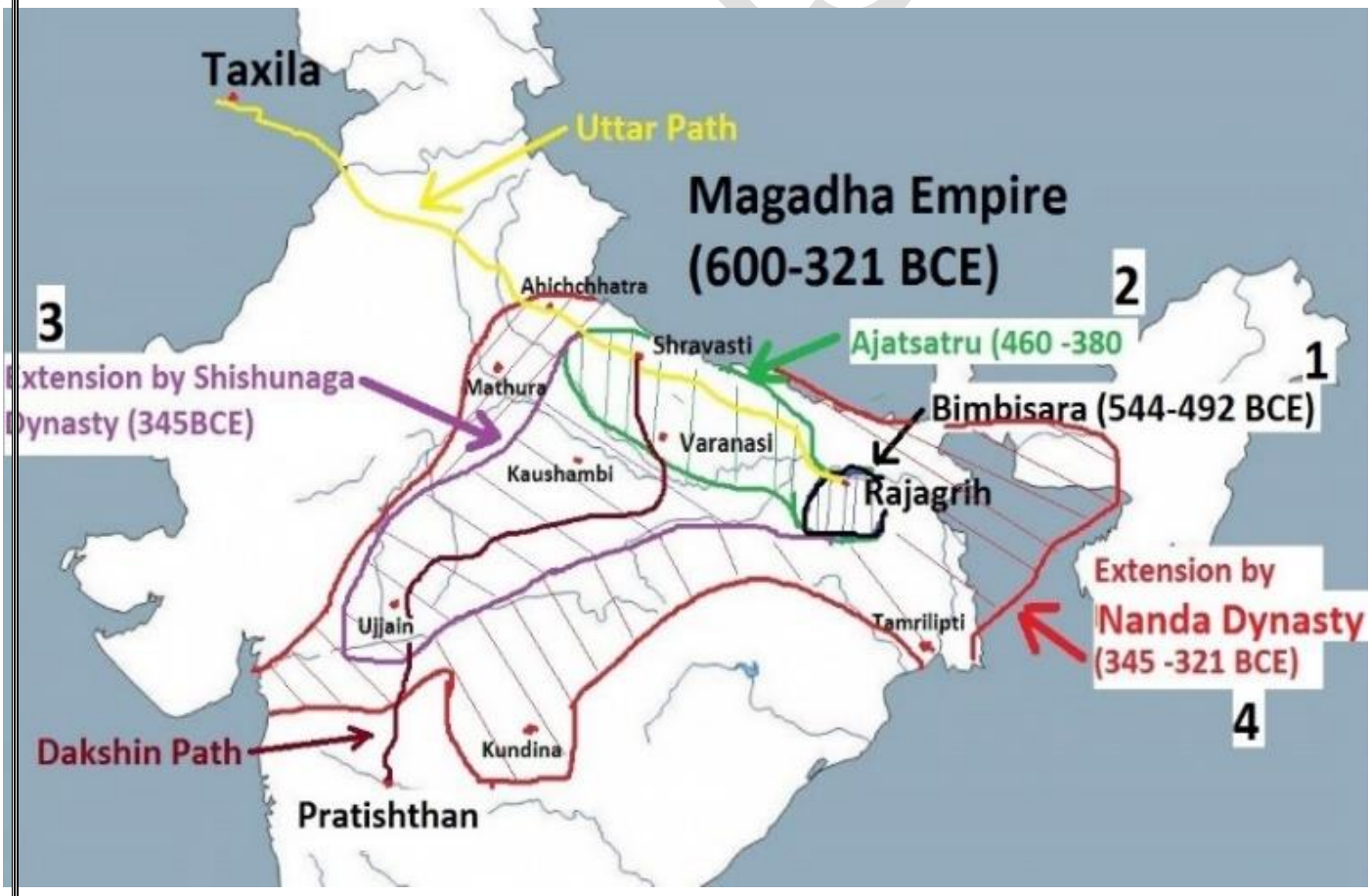
The Haryanka dynasty was followed by the Shishunaga dynasty. Shishunaga was earlier a Viceroy/Amatya at Varanasi (Banaras), and it is believed that the people of Magadha, outraged by the successive parricides of the successors of Udayin, appointed Shishunaga as king. Temporarily he shifted capital to Vaishali. The most important achievement of Shishunaga was to defeat Avanti (Pradyota Dynasty) and make it a part of Magadha. This brought an end to the 100-year-old rivalry between Magadha and Avanti. Kalasoka, a son and successor of Shishunaga, also known as Kakarvarna, succeeded his father. The second Buddhist Council was held at Vaishali during his reign.

Nand Dynasty

The Shishunaga dynasty was followed by the Nand dynasty (345-321 BCE) established **Mahapadma Nanda**. He was also called Ugrasena in Pali texts, because of his large army. According to the Brahmanical texts, he belonged to a low caste or at least a non-Kshatriya caste, while according to the Puranas, he was the son of a king of the Shishunaga dynasty by a Shudra woman, and thus the Nandas were considered adharmika (those who do not follow the norms of Dharma). He was the first

empire builder of India and claimed to be the ekarat, the sole sovereign who destroyed all other ruling princes, and sarva-kshatrantaka, uprooter of the Kshatriyas. He added Kalinga to Magadha and brought an image of Jina as a victory trophy. He also acquired Kosala, which had, in all likelihood, rebelled against him. He made a methodical collection of taxes by regularly appointing officials. He also built canals and did a lot of irrigation work.

Dhanananda was the last important king of the Nanda dynasty. He is identified with the Agrammes or Xandrames of Greek classical writers. He is credited with a huge army; it is believed that Alexander attacked Punjab during his reign but his huge army prevented them from advancing towards Magadha. He is also known for his invention of Nandopakramani (a particular measuring standard). He is believed to be an arrogant and oppressive ruler who imposed heavy taxes on the common man. His greed and exploitation made him quite unpopular among the masses, and ultimately Chandragupta Maurya under the able guidance of Kautilya, took the advantage of this public resentment and uprooted the Nanda rule and set up the Maurya empire.



Chapter 6| Buddhism & Jainism

Reasons for the Origin of New Religious Order

- The Kshatriyas' reaction against domination of the Brahmanas.
- Rise of new agricultural economy which demanded animal Husbandry.
- Patronizing of Buddhism and Jainism by Vaishyas and other mercantile groups who wanted better social status and a reign of peace
- Ready acceptance of simple, ascetic, peace-centred principles of Buddhism and Jainism by general folk

6.1. Rise of New Religious Identities

The mid-first millennium BCE is often regarded as a turning point in world history: it saw the emergence of thinkers such as Zarathustra in Iran, Kong Zi in China, Socrates, Plato and Aristotle in Greece, and Mahavira and Gautama Buddha, among many others, in India. Many ideas found in the Upanishads (*c.* sixth century BCE onwards) show that people were curious about the meaning of life, the possibility of life after death, and rebirth. We get a glimpse of lively discussions and debates from Buddhist texts, which mention as many as 64 sects or schools of thought.

6.2. Buddhism

Early Life: According to these traditions, Siddhartha, as the Buddha was named at birth, was the son of a chief of the Sakya clan. He was born in 563 BCE on Vaishakha Poornima Day at Lumbini (near Kapilavastu, Nepal) to Suddhodana (chief of the republican Sakya clan, who ruled from Kapilavastu in the Kosala Kingdom). His mother Mahamaya (princess of the Kosala dynasty), gave birth and died seven days after his birth. Siddhartha was thus raised by his stepmother Gautami. It is believed that soon after he was born, certain Brahmanas saw the 32 marks of a *Mahapurusha* (great man) on his body and predicted that either he would be a world conqueror or a world renouncer. His father wanted to keep him away from the path of renunciation, hence he shielded him from all sorrows and brought him up in luxury and comfort. He had a sheltered upbringing within the palace, insulated from the harsh realities of life. At the early age of 16 years, he was married to Yashodhara and had a son named Rahula. He is also known as Sakyamuni and Tathagata.

Enlightenment: However, at the age of 29, after seeing an old man, a sick man, a corpse, and an ascetic, he decided to become a wanderer and left his palace with Channa, the charioteer, and his favourite horse, Kanthaka, in search of truth (*Mahabhinishkramana*/Great Renunciation) and wandered for six years. He meditated with established teachers of that era – firstly with Alara Kalama and then with Uddaka Ramaputta, but was not convinced by their instructions that man could obtain liberation from sorrow by mental discipline and knowledge only. Later on, accompanied by five wandering ascetics, but he abandoned them and left for Sarnath. He then moved towards the village of Senani, where he was offered a bowl of milk-rice by a low-caste village girl, Sujata. Accepting from a grass-cutter a gift of *kusa* grass for a mat, he took a seat under a *Peepal* tree facing east. Here he resolved not to rise again until enlightenment was attained. Thus, at the age of 35, he ultimately attained Nirvana/Enlightenment at Gaya, Magadha (Bihar) under a Peepal tree at Uruvela, on the banks of river **Niranjana**, and came to be known as the Buddha, the Enlightened One. The Peepal tree was known as the famous Bodhi tree. The Buddha delivered his first Sermon on deliverance from suffering to his five former companions in a deer park at Sarnath. This event is known as 'DhammaChakka-Pavattana' meaning 'turning the wheel of dharma'. His five disciples soon realised the truth themselves and became Arhats. The Buddha wandered about, teaching his doctrine for over four decades, and established an order of monks and nuns known as the Sangha. He finally attained Parinibbana at the age of 80 at Kusinara (lying in Mallas). It is believed that his last words were, "All composite things decay, strive diligently".

Representation of Buddha

- Lotus and Bull – Birth
- Horse – Renunciation
- Bodhi Tree – Mahabodhi
- Dhammachakra Pravartana – First Sermon
- Footprints – Nirvana

Teachings: The Buddha's teachings have been reconstructed from stories, found mainly in the *Sutta*

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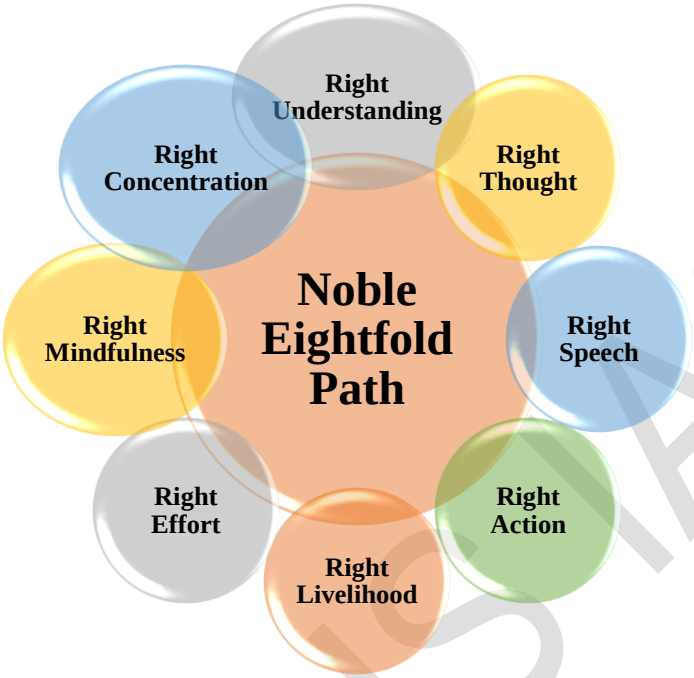
Pitaka. When a grief-stricken woman whose child had died came to the Buddha, he gently convinced her about the inevitability of death rather than bring her son back to life. According to Buddhist philosophy, the world is transient (*anicca*) and constantly changing; it is also soulless (*anatta*) as there is nothing permanent or eternal in it. The Buddha regarded the social world as the creation of humans rather than of divine origin. Therefore, he advised kings and *gahapatis* to be humane and ethical. Buddhism believes in the Four Noble Truths and Eightfold Path. These truths are the Truth of Suffering, The Truth of the Cause of Suffering, The Truth of the End of Suffering, and The Truth of the Path that Leads to the End of Suffering.



Nibbana/Nirvana is the ultimate goal of Buddha's teachings. It does not mean physical death; rather, it signifies dying out or extinction of desire, attachment, greed, ignorance, hatred, and even the sense of ego. It should be noted that Buddhism accepts the transmigration and impermanence, but rejects the idea of God and soul (atman). According to Buddha, the soul is a myth. In the Buddhist universe, there are many realms (worlds) and many different kinds of beings; one can be born as any one of them. Karma in the Buddhist tradition is the result of an action depending on the intention more than the action itself.

Followers of the Buddha: Soon there grew a body of disciples of the Buddha and he founded a *sangha*, an organisation of monks who too became teachers of *dhamma*. These monks lived simply, possessing only the essential requisites for survival, such as a bowl to receive food once a day from the laity. As they lived on alms, they were known as *bhikkhus*. Initially, only men were allowed into the *sangha*, but later women also came to be admitted. The Buddha's foster mother, Mahapajapati Gotami was the first woman to be ordained as a *bhikkhuni*.

6.2.1. Stupas

Buddhist literature mentions several *chaityas*. It also describes places associated with the Buddha's life – where he was born (Lumbini), where he attained enlightenment (Bodh Gaya), where he gave his first sermon (Sarnath) and where he attained *nibbana* (Kusinagara). Gradually, each of these places came to be regarded as sacred. We know that about 200 years after the time of the Buddha, Asoka erected a pillar at Lumbini to mark the fact that he had visited the place.

Why were stupas built? This was built to preserve the relics of the Buddha (his bodily remains or objects). Buddhist text *Ashokavadana* tells that Asoka distributed portions of the Buddha's relics to every important town and ordered the construction of stupas over them.

How were stupas built? Inscriptions found on the railings and pillars of stupas record donations made for building and decorating them. Some donations were made by kings such as the Satavahanas; others were made by guilds, such as that of the ivory workers who financed part of one of the gateways at Sanchi.

The structure of the stupa: The stupa (a Sanskrit word meaning a heap) originated as a simple semi-circular mound of earth, later called *anda*. Gradually, it evolved into a more complex structure, balancing round and square shapes. Above the *anda* was the *harmika*, a balcony like structure that represented the abode of the gods. Arising from the *harmika* was a mast called the *yashti*, often surmounted by a *chhatri* or umbrella. Around the mound was a railing, separating the sacred space from the secular world.

6.2.1.2. Motifs in Buddhist Stupa

Early Buddhist Stupa art in India represents a remarkable fusion of indigenous folk motifs, narratives, and common cultural symbols to articulate and propagate Buddhist ideals. This

art form not only reflected the cultural milieu of its time but also effectively transformed these elements to convey the teachings and values of Buddhism in a way that was accessible and engaging to the general populace. Here's a detailed analysis of how this transformation was achieved:

1. Inclusion of Local Deities and Spirits:

- Naga and Nagi Sculptures: The Stupas, such as those at Sanchi and Bharhut, often incorporated images of Naga (serpent deities) and Nagi, which were venerated in local folk traditions as protectors of water sources and fertility.
- Yaksha and Yakshini: These nature spirits, associated with fertility and abundance in folk beliefs, were prominently depicted in early Buddhist Stupa art. For instance, Yakshas and Yakshinis at Sanchi and Bharhut were reinterpreted to embody virtues like generosity and protection, aligning them with Buddhist values of compassion and benevolence.

2. Depiction of Bodhisattvas:

- Narrative Clarity: The Bodhisattvas, depicted in Stupa art, embodied the ideal of selfless compassion and the aspiration to attain Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings. These figures often depicted in graceful, serene postures, illustrated stories of their past lives and sacrifices, which served as moral exemplars for the laity.

3. Jataka Tales:

- Moral and Ethical Lessons: The Jataka tales, which narrate the previous lives of the Buddha, were prominently depicted on Stupas such as those at Sanchi and Amaravati. These tales conveyed moral lessons and ethical behavior, emphasizing virtues such as honesty, generosity, and kindness.
- Visual Storytelling: The intricate relief panels on Stupas illustrated these stories in a way that was visually engaging and educational, enabling people from all walks of life to understand and internalize Buddhist teachings.

4. Buddha's Life Events:

- Iconography of Buddha's Postures: Different postures (mudras) of the Buddha, such as the Bhumisparsha (earth-touching) mudra, which signifies the moment of enlightenment, were used to narrate significant events in his life. These depictions served to inspire and instruct followers on the path to enlightenment. Mara Vijaya Mudra and Abhaya mudra are others postured which are mostly depicted.

5. Chakra Symbol:

- Wheel of Dharma: The Chakra or Dharma wheel, a prominent symbol in Buddhist art, represented the cyclical nature of existence and the teachings of the Buddha. Its depiction on Stupas signified the spread and perpetuation of the Dharma, urging followers to practice the path of righteousness.

6.2.2. Buddhist Councils

First Buddhist Council was conducted under the patronage of King Ajatasatru of the Haryanka dynasty. It was held in 483 BC just after Buddha's demise, at Sattapani caves in Rajagriha under the leadership of **Mahakassapa**. Ananda composed the Suttapitaka (Buddha's Teachings) and Mahakassapa composed the Vinaypitaka (monastic code). The second Buddhist Council was conducted under the patronage of King Kalasoka of the Sisunaga dynasty, held at Vaishali in 383 BC under the presidentship of **Sabakami**. The third Buddhist Council was conducted under the patronage of Emperor Ashoka of the Maurya dynasty, held in 250 BC at Pataliputra presided over by **Mogaliputta Tissa**. The Abhidhamma Pitaka was composed here making the almost completion of the modern Pali Tipitaka. The

Fourth Buddhist Council was conducted under the patronage of King Kanishka of the Kushan dynasty. It was held in the 1st century AD (72 AD) at Kundalvana in Kashmir. Vasumitra and Ashvaghosha presided over this council in which all deliberations were conducted in Sanskrit. This council resulted in the division of Buddhism into two sects namely, Mahayana (the Greater Vehicle) and Hinayana (the Lesser Vehicle). The Mahayana sect believed in idol worship, rituals, and Bodhisattvas. They regarded the Buddha as God. Hinayana continued the original teachings and practices of the Buddha. They adhere to the scriptures written in Pali while the Mahayana includes Sanskrit scriptures as well.

6.2.3. Spread of Buddhism

Buddhism left an abiding mark on the history of India and it gradually became popular in Magadha

and other parts of the country. With the support of Emperor Ashoka, it further spread its wings to Central Asia, West Asia and Sri Lanka, gradually transforming into a world religion. Buddhism appealed to the common man as, unlike Brahmanism, it was far more liberal and democratic. Since it attacked the *varna* system, it particularly won the support of the lower classes. It was open to people of all castes, and even women were admitted to the Sangha.

Vajrayana

The Vajrayana sect was started by Guru Padmasambhava, and developed in India and neighbouring countries, notably Tibet in around the 8th century. Vajrayana, in the history of Buddhism, marks the transition from Mahayana speculative thought to the enactment of Buddhist ideas in individual life. The followers of Vajrayana believed that salvation could be best attained by achieving the magical power, which they called Vajra. The chief divinities of this new sect were the Taras. It became popular in Eastern India, particularly Bengal and Bihar.

6.2.4. Reasons for the Decline of Buddhism

Buddhism, which once flourished in the Indian subcontinent, experienced a gradual decline for a variety of reasons. These reasons include internal factors related to the transformation and practices of Buddhist institutions, social dynamics, and external factors such as persecution and invasions. The decline of Buddhism in India is a multifaceted process that involved a combination of socio-political, economic, and cultural factors.

6.2.4.1. Internal Factors

1. Accumulation of Wealth and Monastic Corruption: As Buddhism gained popularity, it attracted significant donations from merchants, monarchs, and the general populace. These donations led to the accumulation of considerable wealth within Buddhist monasteries and institutions. The wealth and resources amassed by Buddhist monasteries led to corruption and complacency among monks. Monks, who were initially expected to lead austere lives and wander to propagate the teachings of the Buddha, began to settle in lavish monasteries, deviating from their original ascetic practices and the spirit of mendicancy.

2. Entry of Women and Monastic Discipline: The inclusion of women in the Buddhist monastic order was initially seen as progressive. However, in some instances, it led to issues related to monastic discipline. There were reports of monks engaging in improper relationships, leading to the objectification of women and causing disillusionment among lay followers. This undermined the moral authority of the monks and contributed to a decline in public support for Buddhism.

3. Linguistic Shift to Sanskrit: Early Buddhist texts were composed in Pali and Prakrit, languages that were accessible to the common people. Over time, there was a shift towards using Sanskrit, a language associated with the Brahmanical elite, for Buddhist scriptures and scholarly works. For example, Ashvaghosha's Buddhacharita, a biography of the Buddha, was written in Sanskrit. This linguistic shift alienated the common people, as Sanskrit was less accessible and more difficult for the lay population to understand.

6.2.4.2. External Factors

1. Persecution and Destruction by Hindu Monarchs: Pushyamitra Shunga, who came to power in the 2nd century BCE, is often cited as a ruler who persecuted Buddhists and destroyed Buddhist stupas. His actions contributed to the decline of Buddhism in the regions under his control. Sasanka, a 7th-century ruler of Bengal, is known for his antagonism towards Buddhism. He destroyed the Bodhi tree under the influence of Harshavardhan's conversion to Buddhism and sought to suppress Buddhist practices in his kingdom.

2. Invasions and Destruction by Muslim Rulers: Bakhtiyar Khalji's Invasion: The final blow to Buddhism in India came with the invasion of Bakhtiyar Khalji, a Muslim general who destroyed the Nalanda Mahavihara, a prominent Buddhist university and center of learning, in the late 12th century.

3. Competition with Hinduism and Jainism: Hinduism underwent a significant revival and transformation during the Gupta period and later. The resurgence of devotional movements

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(Bhakti) and the integration of Buddhist concepts into Hindu practices led many Buddhists to revert to Hinduism. Jainism, which shares many similarities with Buddhism, also offered a non-Vedic spiritual path that appealed to many followers. Its continued presence and resilience in India provided a viable alternative to Buddhism.

6.2.4.3. Socio-Political and Cultural Dynamics

1. Integration into Local Traditions: Over time, many Buddhist practices and teachings were absorbed into the broader Hindu tradition. The Buddha came to be revered as an avatar of Vishnu in certain Hindu texts, which facilitated the assimilation of Buddhist communities into the Hindu fold.

2. Decline of Royal Patronage: Initially, Buddhism enjoyed substantial royal patronage, which facilitated its spread and growth. However, with the rise of Hindu rulers who favored Brahmanical traditions, Buddhist institutions lost political and financial support, leading to their gradual decline.

3. Economic Shifts: The decline of key trade routes and the shift in economic centers contributed to the reduction in the wealth and influence of Buddhist monastic institutions that had thrived on patronage from traders and merchants.

4. Social Mobility and Caste Dynamics: The rigid caste system of Hindu society provided a structured social order that Buddhism, with its more egalitarian approach, did not fully address. Over time, the flexibility of the caste system in absorbing different social groups weakened the appeal of Buddhism's more radical social ideals.

Scholars of Buddhism

1. Asvaghosha was the author of Buddhacharita in Sanskrit. He was a contemporary of Kanishka. He was a poet, dramatist, musician, scholar, and debater.
2. Nagarjuna was considered to be the founder of the Madhyamaka school of Mahayana Buddhism. He was a friend and contemporary of Satvahana King Gautamiputra of Andhra.
3. Asanga and Vasubandhu were two brothers who flourished in the Punjab region in the fourth century CE. Asanga was the most important teacher of Yogachara or Vijnanavada school founded by his guru, Maitreyanatha. Vasubandhu's greatest work, Abhidharmakosa, is still considered an important encyclopaedia of Buddhism.
4. Buddhaghosa lived in the fifth century and was a great Pali scholar. His best-known work is the Visuddhimagga 'Path of Purification', a comprehensive summary and analysis of the Theravada understanding of the Buddha's path to liberation.
5. Dinnaga was known as the founder of the Buddhist logic.
6. Dharmakirti lived in the seventh century AD and was another great Buddhist logician, a subtle philosophical thinker and dialectician.

6.3. Jainism

The Jaina doctrine is much older than the Buddhist one, but it is difficult to say precisely how old it is. The Buddha and Mahavira were contemporaries and there are some similarities between their teachings, for instance in their rejection of the authority of the Veda, their non-theistic doctrine, their emphasis on renunciation and human effort as a means to attaining salvation, and their establishment of a monastic order for men and women. However, there are also several marked differences in their philosophical ideas. The word Jaina means follower of a jina, which means victor, a person who has attained infinite knowledge and teaches others how to attain moksha, i.e., liberation from the cycle of rebirth. Tirthankara is another word for jina and means 'ford builder,' i.e., one who builds fords that help people across the ocean of suffering. The Jaina conception of time consists of an endless sequence of half-cycles called utsarpinis and avasarpinis (respectively progressive and regressive in terms of degrees of happiness), lasting vast spans of time, and further divided into six stages known as kalas. There were supposed to be 24 tirthankaras, the first tirthankara was Rishabhadeva. Neminatha, the 22nd one (Gujarat region), and the 23rd was Parshvanatha, who lived in Benaras. Vardhamana was the 24th Tirthankara and came to be known as Mahavira (great hero). All the jinas are supposed to have taught the same doctrine. The jina is considered a human being endowed with superhuman insight and knowledge. According to Jaina tradition, he is born with certain unusual characteristics that mark him out for his future destiny.

6.3.1. Life of Mahavir

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Vardhamana, the future Mahavira, was born in c. 599 BCE at Kundagrama, a city near Vaishali, the capital of Videha. Like the Buddha, Mahavira had an aristocratic Kshatriya background. His father Siddhartha was chief of the Jnatri clan, his mother Trishala the Videha king's sister. The Kshatriya bias of the Jaina tradition is stronger than its Buddhist counterpart. He came to be known as Mahavira (great hero). He was also known by the names of Jitendriya (one who has conquered his inner desires) and Arihant (worthy). He possessed avadhijnana (superhuman insight and cognition). Initially, he led a householder's life, married Yashoda, and had a daughter named Priyadarshana. But he renounced the world in search of truth at the age of 30 and became an ascetic. He wandered for 12 years, practising severe austerities, fasting, and meditation. At the age of 42, it is believed that on the banks of Rijupalika river, outside the town of Jrimbhikagrama, and in the fields of a householder named Samaga, he attained kevalajnana (omniscience or infinite knowledge). He passed away and became a Siddha (fully liberated) at the age of 72 years in c. 527 BCE at Pavapuri near Patna.

6.3.2. Teachings of Mahavir

To achieve liberation of the soul, a Jaina must follow the three jewels of Jaina ethics, popularly called *Triratna*. They are: Right faith (*Samyag darshana*): This does not mean believing what you are told, but means seeing (hearing, feeling, etc.) things properly, and avoiding preconceptions and superstitions that get in the way of seeing clearly. Right knowledge (*Samyag jnana*): This means having an accurate and sufficient knowledge of the real universe – this requires a true knowledge of the five (or six) substances and nine truths of the universe – and having that knowledge with the right mental attitude. Right conduct (*Samyag charitra*): This means living one's life according to Jaina ethical rules; avoiding doing harm to living things; and freeing oneself from attachment and other impure attitudes and thoughts. In order to help attain *Triratna* one must observe *Pancha Mahavrata* (five great vows): Non-violence (*Ahimsa*), Truth (*Satya*) Non-stealing (*Achaurya or Asteya*), Celibacy/Chastity (*Brahmacharya*, added by Mahavira), Non-attachment/Non-possession (*Aparigraha*)

Jain Council

1. First Council was held at *Pataliputra* by Sthulabahu in the beginning of the third century BC and resulted in the compilation of 12 Angas to replace the lost 14 Purvas.

2. Second Council was held at *Valabhi* in the 5th century AD under the leadership of Devaradhi Kshamasramana and resulted in the final compilation of 12 Angas and 12 Upangas.

6.3.3. Spread of Jainism

Gradually, Jainism spread to many parts of India. Like the Buddhists, Jaina scholars produced a wealth of literature in a variety of languages – Prakrit, Sanskrit and Tamil. Jainism gradually spread to western India where the Brahmanical religion was weak. The early Jainas adopted the Prakrit language of the common people to preach their doctrines and discarded the Sanskrit language. This greatly helped in widening the follower base of Jainism. And, with the support of kings who greatly patronised Jainism, like Chandragupta Maurya (he himself became a Jaina ascetic and spent his last years in Karnataka), it became popular in southern India too. The great famine that occurred in Magadha 200 years after the death of Mahavira also contributed to its spread in southern India. According to tradition, the famine lasted for about 12 years; and in order to protect themselves, many Jaina followers under the leadership of **Bhadrabahu.**

6.3.4. Division in Jainism

By the end of the fourth century B.C., there was a serious famine in the Ganges valley leading to a great exodus of many Jaina monks to the Deccan and South India (Sravana Balgola) along with **Bhadrabahu** and Chandragupta Maurya. They returned to the Gangetic Valley after 12 years. The leader of the group, which stayed back at Magadha, was Sthulabahu. The changes that took place in the code of conduct of the followers of Sthulabahu led to the division of the Jaina into Digambaras (sky-clad or naked) and Svetambaras (white-clad).

6.3.5. Decline of Jainism

Several factors attributed to the declining popularity of Jainism. In India, it had to compete with both Hinduism and Buddhism. The absence of popular religious preachers after the death of Mahavira, its division into two important sects, the absence of protection by later rulers and the revival of Hinduism all contributed to the decline of this religion. Besides, it also was unable to spread to any considerable extent beyond the limits of India and never reached the popularity of Buddhism. The followers of Jainism also abstracted from an active policy of conversion.

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Chapter 7| Mauryan Empire

The growth of Magadha culminated in the emergence of the Mauryan Empire. Chandragupta Maurya, who founded the empire (321 BC), extended control as far northwest as Afghanistan and Baluchistan, and his grandson Asoka, arguably the most famous ruler of early India, conquered Kalinga (present-day coastal Orissa).

1. Sources

The accounts of Megasthenes (Indica) and Kautilya (Arthashastra) are the most important sources of the Mauryan empire. The Mauryas are mentioned in later Buddhist, Jaina and Puranic literature, as well as in Sanskrit literary works. Another source is the 'Mudrarakshasa' written by Vishakhadatta in the 5th century A.D. gives an interesting account of how Chandragupta with the help of Kautilya and a Paurava prince defeated the Nandas. Malvikagnimitram written by Kalidasa throws enough light on the last years of the Mauryan rule and the ascendance of Pushyamitra Sunga. Asoka's inscriptions are the most important archaeological evidence which inscribed his messages to his subjects.

2. Chandragupta Maurya

Chandragupta Maurya was the founder of the Mauryan dynasty. He took advantage of the growing weakness and unpopularity of the Nandas in the last days of their rule. With the help of Chanakya, he defeated the Nandas and established the rule of the Maurya dynasty. He himself attended the court and gave justice. He appointed all the high officials of the states such as the 'Sachivas' or 'Amatyas' 'Mantrins' or the High Ministers, the 'Purohita' or the High Priest, Spies, 'Adhayakshas', who maintained correspondence with the Mantri parishad. The administration of Patliputra was carried out by six committees entrusted with sanitation care of foreigners, registration of birth and death, regulation of weights and measures and similar other functions. He was called *Sandrocottus* by the Greek scholars (identified by William Jones). Greek sources even suggest a meeting between Chandragupta and Alexander (who invaded northwest India during 327–326 BCE). They also account for the conflict between Chandragupta Maurya and Seleucus Nikator (who was one of the generals of Alexander, and after his death, had succeeded in gaining control over most of the eastern Asiatic provinces). Chandragupta defeated him around 301 BCE and Seleucus was compelled to yield *Arachosia* (Qandahar area of south-east Afghanistan), *Gedrosia* (south Baluchistan), and *Parapomisadai* (area between Afghanistan and the Indian sub-continent, such as Kabul, Herat, Gandhara) to him in return for 500 elephants. Seleucus sent an ambassador to the Mauryan court, Megasthenes (who wrote the *Indica*). According to Jain texts and tradition, Chandragupta adopted Jainism and went to the hills of Shravana Belagola (near Mysore) with Bhadrabahu and committed *Sallekhana* (death by slow starvation).

3. Bindusara

Chandragupta was succeeded by his son Bindusara. He defeated the rulers of 16 kingdoms and added their lands to his empire. Under him, the Mauryan Empire spread across the whole of the Indian subcontinent. Except for Kalinga (Orissa) and a few kingdoms in the south. Greek writers address him as *Amitrochates* (destroyer of foes), while the *Mahabhasya* refers to him as *Amitraghat* (killer of enemies). It is rather strange that Buddhist sources are silent on Bindusara. However, stories from the Ajivika sect do mention a fortune-teller who prophesied to Bindusara about his son Ashoka's future greatness. He Conquered 'the land between the two seas', i.e., the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal.

4. Ashoka

Ashoka was the most famous Mauryan king and one of the greatest rulers. After Bindusara's death in 273 BCE, there was a four-year succession conflict. He was appointed the viceroy of Taxila and Ujjain (both cities handled commercial activities) during the reign of Bindusara. According to *Divyavadana*, Bindusara wanted his son Susima to succeed him, and Ashoka was the choice of Bindusara's ministers. Later, with the help of a minister named Radhagupta, and after killing 99 brothers, Ashoka finally acquired the Magadha throne and thus, after four years, came his formal consecration. Ashoka's mother was a daughter of a Brahmana of Champa named **Subhadrangi**.

Ashoka had a love marriage with his wife Mahadevi (mother of Mahendra and Sanghamitra. He had also other queens Asandhimitta, Padmavati, Tissarakhita (who tried to get the Bodhi tree cut), and Karuvaki (only queen to be mentioned in the Queen's Edict who had son *Tivara*). He organised the third Buddhist council at Pataliputra in 250 BC, after which he sent Buddhist missionaries to Ceylon and Suvarnabhumi. In the course of his second Dharmayatra tour, he visited Lumbini. He Banned

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animal sacrifice, regulated the slaughter of animals for food, and established *dharmashalas*, hospitals, and *sarais* throughout his kingdom.

Kalinga War (261 BC): When Ashoka became the king, Kalinga was the only kingdom which was not under Mauryan control. Kalinga was important as it controlled the land and sea routes to south India and south-east Asia. Ashoka attacked Kalinga and conquered it after a fierce battle. The war with Kalinga was a turning point in the life of Ashoka. The death, destruction and suffering that he saw in the war made him very sad. He realized the futility of fighting a war and vowed not to fight any more wars. He devoted the rest of his life to serving his people. Like his predecessors, Ashoka assumed the title of **Priyadarshi** (pleasing to look at) and Devanampriya (beloved of Gods). In the Sarnath inscription, he adopted the third title, i.e., **Dharmshoka.**

Ashoka's Contemporaries	
Antiochus II Theos	Syria
Ptolemy II Philadelphus	Egypt
Magas	Cyme
Antigonus Gonatas	Macedonia
Alexander	Epirus

Name of Ashoka	Sources
Ashoka	Maski Minor rock edict
Devanampriyas Ashoka Rajas	Gurjara minor rock edict
Raja Ashoka	Nittur minor rock edict
Raja Ashoka Dewanampiya	Udegolumn minor rock edict
Piyadassi Raja Magadh	Bhabru-Bairat minor rock edict
Piyadassi Raja	Barabar cave inscription
Piyadassi	Kandhar major rock edicts and Deepvamsa
Ashoka Maurya	Rudradaman's Junagarh rock edict
Ashoka Vardhan	Puranas

5. Decline of the Mauryan Empire

According to Buddhist texts, Ashoka ruled for twenty-seven years. The subsequent history of the Mauryas under his successors is very inadequately known. This is because a state of disintegration seemed to have set in immediately after Ashoka's death. Pillar Edict VII mentions **Tivara** as a son of Ashoka. Three other sons- **Kunala**, **Jaluka** and **Mahendra** are known to literature. It appears on the evidence of the Vayu Purana that Kunala ruled for eight years, but the extent of his dominions is not indicated therein. Moreover, Jain and Buddhist writers tell us that **Samprati**, the son of Junal, who was incapable of ruling because of blindness, immediately succeeded Ashoka to the throne of Patliputra. The tenth and the last of the Mauryas was ***Brihadratha*** who, according to the testimony of **Banabhatta**, was murdered by his general **Pushyamitra** and who ascended the throne in 187 B.C. The empire founded by him is known as the **Sunga Dynasty**. With Brihadratha's death (185 B.C.) this historic rule of the Mauryas came to an end within less than half a century of Ashoka's death and 137 years since its foundation by Chandragupta Maurya.

Mauryan Rulers	
321–298 BCE	Chandragupta
298–273 BCE	Bindusara
269–232 BCE	Ashoka
232–224 BCE	Dasharatha
224–215 BCE	Samprati
215–202 BCE	Shalishuka
202–195 BCE	Devavarman
195–187 BCE	Shatadhanvan
187–185 BCE	Brihadratha

Historical Debate: Harprasad Shastri holds that Brahmanical reaction was responsible for the downfall of the Mauryan empire. H.C. Raichaudhuri talks about the pacifist policy of Ashoka as the decline of Mauryan empire. D.D. Koshambi says that heavy economic pressure was the chief cause of the downfall of the Mauryan empire. Ghosal says that the propagation of Buddhism during Ashoka's period disturbed Brahmanical social and religious order, which weakened the state. Romila Thapar says that the nature of organisation or administration and the faulty conception of the state ultimately caused the downfall of the empire.

6. Dhamma

Ashoka's *dhamma* did not involve the worship of a god or the performance of a sacrifice. He felt that just as a father tries to teach his children, he has a duty to instruct his subjects. He was also inspired by the teachings of the Buddha. There were a number of problems that troubled him, i.e., People in the empire followed different religions, and this sometimes led to conflict, animals were sacrificed, and slaves and servants were ill-treated. Besides, there were quarrels in families and amongst neighbours. Ashoka felt it was his duty to solve these problems. So, he appointed officials, known as the *dhamma mahamatta* who went from place-to-place teaching people about *dhamma*. Besides, Ashoka got

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his messages inscribed on rocks and pillars, instructing his officials to read his message to those who could not read it themselves. Ashoka also sent messengers to spread ideas about *dhamma* to other lands, such as Syria, Egypt, and Greece, and his son Mahendra and daughter Sanghmitra to Sri Lanka. He built roads, dug wells, and built rest houses. Besides, he arranged for medical treatment for both human beings and animals.

7. Administrative Controls

There were five major political centres in the empire – the capital Pataliputra and the provincial centres of Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri, all mentioned in Asokan inscriptions. The Mauryan empire was divided into three different political rules; Metropolitan State, Core Area, and Peripherical Area. This system is called as 'complex system of administration by historian Romila Thapar. Megasthenes mentions a committee with six subcommittees for coordinating military activity. Of these, one looked after the navy, the second managed transport and provisions, the third was responsible for foot soldiers, the fourth for horses, the fifth for chariots and the sixth for elephants. The activities of the second subcommittee were rather varied: arranging for bullock carts to carry equipment, procuring food for soldiers and fodder for animals, and recruiting servants and artisans to look after the soldiers. Asoka also tried to hold his empire together by propagating *dhamma,* the principles of which, as we have seen, were simple and virtually universally applicable. This, according to him, would ensure the well-being of people in this world and the next. Special officers, known as the *dhamma mahamatta,* were appointed to spread the message of *dhamma*.

Mauryan	Mantriparishad
Mantrin	Chief Minister
Purohita	High Priest
Senapati	Commander-in-charge
Yuvaraj	Crowned Prince
Samaharta	Collector of Revenue
Yukta	Subordinate Officer-in-charge of Revenue
Prashasti	Head of Prisons
Sannidata	Head of Treasury
Nayaka	Head of City Security
Paur	City Police
Byabharika	Chief Judge
Karmantika	Head of Industries and Factories
Dandapala	Head of Police
Durgapala	Head of Royal Fort
Annapala	Head of the Food Grains Department
Rajjukas	Officers responsible for land measurement and fixing its boundary.
Pradesika	Head of District Administration

8. Inscriptions of Ashoka

The inscriptions are the most important feature of the Mauryan Empire which talks about the different policies of the Mauryan empire King Ashoka, especially his Dhamma policy. There are three categories of inscriptions found across the Indian subcontinent, i.e., Major Rock Edicts, Minor Roc Edicts, and Pillar Edicts.

8.1. Important Fourteen Major Edicts

First Edict: Declared prohibition of animal sacrifice.
Second Edict: Medical treatment of humans and animals, planting beneficial medicinal herbs and roots, fruits, and the digging of wells.
Third Edict: Mentions *Pradeshikas*, *Rajukas*, and *Yuktas* and their need for going on tours of inspection every five years as part of their other duties, preaching *dhamma*, and also adopting a liberal attitude towards *Brahmanas* and *Shramanas*
Four Edict: *Bheri Ghosha* (war drum) was replaced by *Dhamma Ghosha*.
Fifth Edict: Appointment of *Dhamma Mahamattas*.
Eighth Edict: Royal pleasure tours (*Vihara-yatras*) replaced by *dhamma* tours (*dhammayatras*).
Thirteenth Edict: The Kalinga war changed his attitude and Ashoka, who was the worshipper of Shiva, turned towards Buddhism. *Digvijay* was replaced by *Dhamma Vijay*, the sword was replaced by *Dhamma*, and the war drum (*Bheri Ghosha*) became law (*Dhamma Ghosha*). His *dhamma* contained the essence (good qualities) of all the religions of the world.

8.2. Pillar Edicts

The majestic free-standing Ashokan pillars probably signify the axis of the world (*axis mundi*) that separated heaven and earth. Pillar edicts have been found at Lauriya-Araraj, Lauriya Nandangarh, Rampurva, Nigali Sagar, Sarnath, Topra, and Meerut. It is rather interesting to note that two pillars, one from Topra and the other from Meerut, were shifted to Delhi by Feroz Shah Tughlaq. There are pillars without inscriptions such as the bull capital pillar at Rampurva, the pillar with the lion capital at Vaishali, and the Kolam pillar, which is also without a capital.

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9. Mauryan Art

Maurya Empire contributed significantly to the field of arts including architecture, sculpture, engineering, polishing, etc. The palace of Chandragupta was made of wood. Ashoka constructed as good as 84,000 stupas. These buildings were solid and domic, made of rock or bricks. Seven rock-cut sanctuaries lying about 25 miles north of Gaya, Bihar, four on the Barabar hills and three on the Nagarjuna hills belong to the time of Ashoka and his successors. The caves are a fine example of Mauryan art. The caves were used for religious ceremonies and also as assembly halls. The Mauryans introduced stone masonry on a large scale. Fragments of stone pillars and stumps indicating the existence of an 80-pillared hall have been discovered at Kumrahar on the outskirts of Patna.

- **Single lion** capital at Rampurva at **Lauriya** Nandangarh.
- Single bull capital at Rupurva.
- **Four lion** capital at Sarnath and Sanchi.
- A carved elephant at Dhauli and an engraved elephant at Kalsi.

The pillars represent the masterpiece of Mauryan sculpture. Each pillar is made of a single piece of sandstone, only their capitals which are beautiful pieces of sculpture in the form of lions or bulls are joined with a pillar on the top. The Mauryan artisans also started the practice of hewing out caves from rocks for monks to live in. The earliest example is the Barabar caves in Gaya. Stupas were built throughout the empire to enshrine the relics of Buddha. Of these, the most famous are at Sanchi and Barhut.

Another remarkable feature was the art of polishing monuments, pillars, caves made of hard rocks, etc. The art of engineering equally flourished. Civil Engineering was in a highly advanced state and, therefore, so many spectacular buildings, stupas, and pillars could be constructed with perfection and efficiency. Also, the art of jewellery attained remarkable progress. The **punched marked silver coins** of the Mauryas which carry the symbols of the **peacock**, and the hill and crescent were also a part of Court Art. The other type of art included the folk tradition of arts represented by figures of Yaksha and Yakshinis found in Besnagar, Daidrganj, etc. The abundance of beautiful pottery called **Northern Black Polished Ware** (NBPW) and terracotta figurines was another item of popular art.

10. Other Important Features of the Mauryan Empire

Army: Mauryas owned a big army. According to Pliny, Chandragupta maintained 6,00,000-foot soldiers, 30,000 cavalry and 900 elephants. According to Magasthenese, the army was administered by six committees consisting of five members each, taken from a board of 30 officers.

Espionage: It was an important part of the Maurya administration; and was of two types, i.e., **Santha** and **Sanchar**, the former worked by remaining stationed at a public place and the latter by moving from place to place. The spies were the ears and eyes of the king. They were also called '*Cudhapurshas*'.

Revenue Administration: There were various sources of state revenues: cities (durga), rural areas (rashtra), mines (khan), road and traffic (vanikpatha), pastures (Vraja), Plantations (setu) and forests (vana).

Import Duties: Prabeshya or import duties were fixed at 20 per cent of the cost price. *Panyadhyaksha* and *Pattanadhyaksha* were respectively responsible for verifying every import to the state. They were also responsible for the export of each article from the state and collected the revenue known as nishkramya.

Sales Tax: Taxes were imposed on every article before it was sold or purchased by Sulkadhyaksha. 9.5 per cent on items sold on the basis of calculation, 5 per cent on the items sold on the basis of measurement, and 6.5 per cent on the goods sold on the basis of weight.

Social Conditions: Kautilya's Arthashastra and Megasthene's Indica give a detailed view of the society and social condition of the people. Varna or the caste system and stages of religious discipline took a definite shape, which corresponds to the Hindu caste system. Slavery was an established institution. **Women** were placed in high esteem. Yet, **prostitution** was an established institution. Festivals and merry gatherings were common. The people led a simple and peaceful life and were inspired by a sense of morality and idealism. The Jainism and Buddhism were the main religions. In addition, several minor religions including Ajivikas were also in existence. The Mauryan rulers took much pain to spread education and to set up literary standards for their subjects as well. The universities of Taxila and

Banaras earned world fame for teaching Brahmanical and Buddhist literature.

Economic Conditions: It was mainly based on agriculture as cultivators formed a majority of the population, though trade was also important.

Agriculture: Some lands were owned by a state called Sita Lands which were either cultivated by labourers or leased out to cultivators. Private Landowners are required to pay taxes in the form of **Bali**, **bhaga, shulka, kara,** etc.

Trade: The state was also a big trader. It also collected tolls through officials. Trade was also internal to foreign countries. It exported spices, pearls, diamonds, cotton textiles, ivory works to Greeks and Verma. It imported horses, gold, glass, linen, etc. from other countries. The balance of trade was very much in favour of India.

11. Conclusion

The Mauryan Empire, which flourished from 321 to 185 BCE, stands as a pivotal chapter in Indian history, having laid the foundational stones for subsequent political and cultural developments. Under the astute leadership of figures like Chandragupta Maurya and Ashoka, the empire unified much of the Indian subcontinent, establishing a centralized administration, a robust economic system, and a network of infrastructure that facilitated trade and communication. The dissemination of Buddhism under Ashoka's patronage significantly influenced the cultural and religious landscape of not only India but also Southeast Asia and beyond. In contemporary India, the Mauryan legacy is celebrated for its contributions to governance, the spread of Buddhism, and its ideals of tolerance and welfare. Notably, the national emblem of India, adopted from the Sarnath Lion Capital of Ashoka, symbolizes the enduring influence of Mauryan values, representing strength, courage, and the commitment to uphold justice and truth. This emblem, along with the principles it embodies, underscores a continuity of ideals from the Mauryan era that continue to inspire the nation's social and political ethos.

Other Important Inscriptions	
Inscription Name	**Descriptions**
Allahabad – Kosam/Queen's Edict/ Kausambi or Schism Edict	Ashoka warns members of the *Sangha* against causing division in the ranks. Samudragupta's inscription is on this edict itself. Jahangir was probably responsible for its removal to the fort at Allahabad.
Girnar Rock Inscription of Rudradaman (Kathiawar)	Mentions the Sudarshan Lake constructed by Pushyagupta, a *rashtriya* (means provincial governor) of Saurashtra during Chandragupta Maurya's reign
Kandahar Inscription, Bilingual Greek, Aramaic inscription, Nigali Sagar Inscription (Nepal)	To record the first enlargement of the stupa (14 years after his consecration) and later Ashoka's visit to the site (20 years after his consecration)
Rummindei Inscription (Nepal)	To commemorate the birthplace of the Buddha, Ashoka visited Lumbini, worshipped here and gave tax concessions to the villagers. It records that *the village of Lumbini was exempted from bali and was to pay only one-eighth of bhaga.*
Sannati Inscription (Karnataka)	Site of all 14 Major Rock Edicts as well as two separate Kalinga edicts.
Kalinga Edict (Bhauli and Jaugada)	Mentions "*All men are my children*"
Saugaura Copper Plate Inscription and Mahasthan	The inscription of Chandragupta Maurya; mentions relief measures adopted during famine in Magadha
Minor Rock Edict 1	Indicates that Ashoka turned towards Buddhism gradually (nearly after 2.5 years in power), and not suddenly
Minor Rock Edict 3	Ashoka greets the *Sangha*, professes his deep faith in the Buddha, *dhamma*, and *Sangha* and recommends six Buddhist texts for monks, nuns, and the general laity
Brahmagiri Minor Rock Edicts I-II	Local Administration

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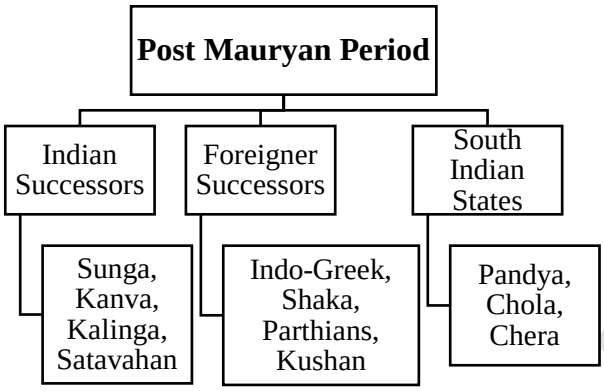
Chapter 8| Post-Mauryan Period

The period between 185 BCE and 319 CE did not witness the emergence of a large kingdom as compared to Maurya. However, this period is marked by a shift in political focus from Magadha to north-western India. There was a series of invasions and the rise of numerous regional kingdoms. In this period, the cities expanded, and urban culture gained a certain predominance. The economy saw an increasing use of currency. The period, in short, contributed much to the rich and versatile heritage of the sub-continent as we are aware.



1. Indian Successors of Mauryas

After the decline of the Maurya Empire in the early 2nd century BCE, northern and central India saw the emergence of various regional powers, the most prominent of which was the Shunga dynasty, founded by Pushyamitra Shunga around 185 BCE. The Shungas, known for their patronage of Hinduism, ruled much of the Mauryan heartland and resisted invasions, such as those by the Indo-Greeks. They were succeeded by the Kanva dynasty around 75 BCE, which continued to maintain control over central India until they were overthrown by the Satavahanas. In the Deccan, the Satavahana Empire emerged as a significant power, promoting trade and cultural development, and eventually expanding into central India. These successor states continued to influence Indian culture and politics, setting the stage for later empires like the Gupta dynasty.

1.1. Shunga Dynasty (185 BCE−73 BCE)

The last Maurya king Brihadartha was murdered in 185 BCE by his own commander-in-chief, Pushyamitra Shunga, while he was inspecting his troops. Pushyamitra's empire extended over only part of the erstwhile Maurya empire, including Pataliputra, Ayodhya, Vidisha, and modern-day Punjab. The ten Sunga kings ruled this dynasty. Pushyamitra Sunga performed two Ashvamedha sacrifices, as mentioned in the Ayodhya stone inscription of King Dhana. He defeated the Bactrian Greek king, Demetrius. He was succeeded by his son Agnimitra on whom Kalidas, in his Malavikagnimitra, narrates the love story of Malavika, a maiden of the queen, and Agnimitra. **Bhagabhadra**/**Bhagavata** was probably the fifth king. **Devabhuti,** known as Devabhumi, was the last ruler who was killed by his *Brahmana* minister Vasudeva Kanva, who founded the Kanva dynasty.

The Shungas were important patrons of culture at a time when some of the most important developments in Hindu thought was taking place. Patanjali's Mahabhasya was composed in this period. Artistry also progressed with the rise of the Mathura art style. Heliodorus pillar was built in Vidisha under the Shungas, at the instigation of Heliodorus, ambassador of the Indo-Greek king Antialcidas. The pillar originally supported a statue of Garuda.

Buddhist scriptures such as the Asokavadana ancient Tibetan historian Taranatha have written about the persecution of Buddhists. Pushyamitra is said to have burned down Buddhist monasteries, destroyed stupas, massacred Buddhist monks and put rewards on their heads, but some consider these stories as a probable exaggeration. Two dedications by King Brahmamitra and Indragnimitra are recorded at the Mahabodhi Temple in Bodh Gaya and have been claimed to show Shunga support for Buddhism. These kings however are essentially unknown and do not form a part of the Shunga recorded genealogy, but they are thought to be post-Ashokan and to belong to the period of Sunga rule.

1.2. Kanva Dynasty (73 BCE-28 BCE)

Vasudeva Kanva was initially a minister of the Shunga Emperor Devabhuti, who then assassinated the former emperor and usurped the throne. The Kanva ruler allowed the kings of the Shunga dynasty to continue to rule in obscurity in a corner of their former dominions. There were four Kanva rulers. They were descendants of the sage Saubhari. He was succeeded by his son Bhumimitra. Coins bearing the legend Bhumimitra have been discovered from the Panchala realm. Copper coins with the legend "Kanvasya" have also been found from Vidisha, as well as Kaushambi in the Vatsa realm. Bhumimitra ruled for fourteen years and was later succeeded by his son Narayana. Narayana ruled for twelve years. He was succeeded

by his son Susharman who was the last king of the Kanva dynasty. After the defeat at the hands of Satavahanas and the fall of the Kanva dynasty, the Magadha empire came to an end. The defeat of the Kanva dynasty by the Satavahana dynasty was a localised event in Central India and numismatic and epigraphic evidence suggests that Magadha later came under the hegemony of the Mitra dynasty of Kaushambi from the 1st century BCE until the 2nd century CE. The Puranas suggest that the last king of the Kanva dynasty was killed by Balipuccha, who founded the Andhra dynasty, but there is a lack of numismatical and archaeological evidence to support this.

1.3. Early State of Kalinga

Ashoka had conquered Kalinga through a violent battle in which the loss of men and property was enormous. After Ashoka, Kalinga became prominent under the kings of the Chedi dynasty. Unfortunately, not much information about the kings of the dynasty is available except for Kharavela, who probably lived in the first century BCE. His achievements are recorded in an inscription, known as the Hathigumpha inscription, situated in the Udaigiri hills near Bhuvaneshvar in Orissa.

King Kharavela (1st century BCE): He probably belonged to *The Mahameghavahanas* of Kalinga. He seemed to have wrested Kalinga from Mauryans and founded an independent line of kings, the Chedis of Kalinga. He is also known as Bhikshu-Raja, and he constructed a great palace known as the 'Palace of Victor'. He is famous for the Hathigumpha Inscription, which is engraved on the Udaigiri hills near Bhuvaneshwar. It is the second inscription by Naganika after his Nanaghat inscription. He was a follower of Jainism and provided cave shelters for Jaina monks in Udaigiri Hills. The Hathigumpha Inscription proves that Jainism entered Orissa and probably became the state religion within 100 years of the death of Mahavira. The inscription is so named because the image of an elephant is carved out of stone next to the boulder carrying the inscription. The inscription tells us that he was a follower of Jainism and had fought many successful battles against his neighbours.

1.4. The Satavahanas (2nd c BC – 2nd c AD)

As we have discussed earlier, the Maurya rule was succeeded by the Sungas and the Kanvas in the north. However, in Deccan and in central India, the Satavahanas succeeded the Mauryas though after a gap of almost a century. The Satavahanas are considered identical to the 'Andhras' of the *Puranas*.

The Satavahanas claimed *Brahmana* descent and performed Vedic rituals and worshipped gods like Krishna, and Vasudeva. Another striking feature of the kings pertaining to this dynasty was that they used matronyms such as Gautamiputra and Vashishthiputra, although they were not matrilineal or matriarchal in any sense. The Satavahanas assumed the title of *Dakshinapathapati* (*Lord of the Dakshinapatha*). The Satavahanas are also known for their tax-free land-grant, Brahmadeya.

Simuka was the founder of the Satavahana Dynasty. He built Jain and Buddhist temples.

Satakarni I: He is the third king of this empire. He ruled around 70 to 60 BC. He extended his kingdom through military conquest. After Kharavela was dead, Satakarni I conquered Kalinga. He got the fame of 'Lord of Dakshinapatha'. The name of his wife was Nayanika. She wrote an inscription named Naneghat. In this, she described the king, Satakarni I, as Dakshinapathapati. He also performed Ashvamedha Yagya and brought Brahmanism back to Deccan, its origin.

Gautamiputra Satkarni (106–130): It appears initially the Shaka Kshatrapas of Western India succeeded in dislodging the Satavahanas from the western and central region, but later the fortunes of the Satavahanas were revived by most famous ruler, Gautamiputra Satkarni. He not only defeated the Shakas but also raised the power and prestige of the Satvahanas to greater heights. It was under his reign that the empire was at its peak. He also wrested Malwa and Kathiawar from the Shakas. His empire extended from Malwa in the north to Karnataka in the south, having general authority over the present-day Andhra region. In the Nashik inscription, he is also described as ***ekabamhana*** (a peerless Brahmana) and ***khatiya-dapamanamada*** (one who destroyed the high-handedness and pride of the Kshatriyas).

He donated land to the Buddhist monks, the *Mahasamghikas*, at Karle (the Karle Inscription mentions the grant of 'Karajika'village near modern Pune, Maharashtra) and at Nashik. He assumed the titles of *Rajaraja* and *Maharaja*. In the later period of his reign, he probably lost some of the conquered Kshaharata territories to the Kardamaka line of the Shaka Kshatrapas of Western India, as evident in the Junagadh Inscription of the Rudradaman I.

Yajna Sri Satakarni (165–194) was one of the later kings who recovered north Konkan and Malwa from the Shaka rulers. He was a lover of trade and navigation, as evident from the motif of the ship on his coins.

The successors of Yajnashri Satakarni included Gautamiputra Vijaya Satakarni, Chanda Satakarni, Vasisthiputra Vijaya Satkarni, Pulumavi, and Hala (probably the 17th king in the line, also a great poet who authored the *Gatha Sattasai*, which is a collection of 700 erotic poems in the Maharashtri Prakrit dialect). In the mid-3rd century, the Satavahana dynasty came to an end and various forces came into power in their stead such as the Vakatakas in the Deccan, the Kadambas in Mysore, the Abhiras in Maharashtra, and the Ikshvakus in Andhra emerged as the main rulers.

Polity and Administration

The Satavahana king was represented as the upholder of *dharma* and he generally strove for the royal and divine ideal set forth in the *dharmashastra*s. In order to attribute divinity to kingship, most kings were represented as possessors of supernatural powers and qualities of mythical heroes such as Rama, Arjuna, Bhima, and so on. The Satavahanas retained some of the administrative units of Ashokan times. The kingdom was divided into subdivisions called *aharas* or *rashtras*, meaning districts. There were also officers called *amatyas*/mahamatras who were perhaps ministers or advisors of the king. But, unlike in Mauryan times, certain military and feudal traits are found in the administration of the Satavahanas. For instance, the *Senapati* was appointed provincial governor. The military character of the Satavahanas is also evident with the use of terms like *kataka* and *skandhavaras* in their inscriptions, which denote military camps and settlements attached to a particular king and also serve as administrative centres. The Satavahana kingdom had three grades of feudatories: *Raja* (who had the right to strike coins), *Mahabhoja* and *Senapati*. The Satavahana kings were the first in Indian history to make tax-free land grants to Buddhists and Brahmanas to gain religious merit.

Material Culture

Through contact with the North (Satavahana), the people of Deccan learnt the use of coins, burnt bricks, ring wells, the art of writing, and so on. There was regular use of fire-baked bricks and the use of flat, perforated roof tiles which must have aided in the longevity of the construction. The drains were covered and were also underground to lead wastewater into soakage pits. They were also fairly acquainted with the use of iron and agriculture. They probably exploited the rich mineral resources of Deccan such as iron ores from Karimnagar and Warangal and gold from Kolar fields. Unlike the gold coins of the Kushanas, they mostly issued lead coins (which they probably imported from the Romans) apart from copper and bronze coins. The Satavahanas also produced cotton and in different foreign accounts, Andhra was famous for its cotton products.

Social Organisation

Since the Andhras are identified with the early Satavahanas, they were probably a local Deccan tribe who were gradually Brahamnised. They claimed to be Brahmans and considered it their primary duty to uphold the *varna* system. They worshipped Vaishnava gods such as Krishna and Vasudeva. Though they made liberal sacrificial fees to the Brahmanas, they also promoted Buddhism by granting land to Buddhist monks, especially to Mahayana Buddhists. **Nagarjunakonda** and **Amravati** in Andhra Pradesh and **Nashik** and **Junar** areas of Maharashtra became important Buddhist sites under the Satavahanas and their successors, the Ikshvakus.

Architecture

During the Satavahana phase, many *chaityas* (sacred shrines) and *viharas* (monasteries) were cut out of the solid rock in the north-western Deccan or Maharashtra with great precision and skill. The Karle Chaitya in the western Deccan belongs to this era. The Nashik inscriptions of Nahapana and Gautamiputra Satakarni, which are on the walls of the three viharas, is another important architectural site belonging to this period. The official language of the Satavahanas was Prakrit, though the script was Brahmi. One famous Prakrit text, ***Gathasattasai***, is attributed to a Satavahana king called Hala, which consisted of 700 verses all written in Prakrit.

2. Foreign Successors of Maurya

Following the decline of the Maurya Empire, a series of foreign powers established their dominance in northwestern India, significantly influencing the region's cultural and political landscape. The Indo-Greeks, successors to Alexander the Great's legacy in the east, established the Greco-Bactrian Kingdom around the 2nd century BCE, with rulers like Menander I promoting Hellenistic culture while adopting local traditions and Buddhism. They were followed by the Indo-Scythians, or Sakas, around the

1st century BCE, a nomadic group from Central Asia who integrated into the existing culture and continued the trend of syncretism. The Parthians, another group from the Iranian plateau, briefly held sway in the region, contributing to the rich cultural tapestry with their Zoroastrian influences. The most enduring of these foreign rulers were the Kushans, originally from the Yuezhi tribe in Central Asia, who established a vast and prosperous empire in the 1st to 3rd centuries CE under leaders like Kanishka the Great. The Kushans played a pivotal role in the flourishing of trade along the Silk Road, the spread of Mahayana Buddhism, and the development of a vibrant syncretic culture that combined elements of Greek, Persian, Indian, and Central Asian traditions.

2.1. Indo–Greeks/Bactrian Greeks

After the death of Alexander in 323 BCE, many Greeks came to settle on the north-western borders of India with Bactria. The rulers of Bactria came to be called the Bactrian Greeks as they were originally *satraps* (subordinate rulers) of the Seleucid Empire of West Asia. The Scythians were pushed back from China after the construction of the Chinese Wall. In order to escape the wrath of the nomadic Scythian tribes, the Bactrian Greeks were forced to invade India.

- **Demetrius** (King of Bactria) invaded India around 190 BCE and probably also came into conflict with Pushyamitra Shunga. He conquered the south of the Hindu Kush.
- **Menander**/**Milinda** (165–145 BCE) is the most celebrated Indo-Greek ruler who not only stabilised Indo-Greek power, but also extended his empire's frontiers in India. His empire extended over parts of both Bactria and northwestern India and appears to have included southern Afghanistan and Gandhara, the region west of the River Indus. He had his capital at ***Sakala*** (modern Sialkot, Punjab). He was converted to Buddhism by Nagasena has been identified with King Milinda mentioned in the famous Buddhist text *Milindapanho.*
- **Hermaius** (The last ruler of this dynasty) was defeated by the Parthians around the last quarter of the 2nd century BCE, which led to the end of Greek rule in Bactria and the area to the south of the Hindu Kush.

2.2. The Shakas/Scythians

'Shaka' is the Indian term used for the people called the Scythians, who originally belonged to Central Asia. Interestingly, Patanjali in his Mahabhasya refers to the Shakas as '**Anirvasita** (pure) Shudras'. The Shakas advanced into Bactria, Parthia, and the Indus plains. There were five branches of the Shakas who finally settled with their seats of power in different parts of India and Afghanistan:

1. Afghanistan-**Vonones** and **Spalirises**.
2. Punjab with Taxila as their capital: - **Maues**
3. Mathura: - **Azilises**
4. Western India (Gujarat): - Rudradaman I
5. Deccan.

Important Rulers of Shaka

Maues/Moga/Moa (90 BCE) was probably the first Shaka king in India who established power in Gandhara. His coins carried figures of typically Indian deities like ***Abhisheka Laxmi***. **Azes** was associated with the Vikram Samvat era of 58 BCE, which is used to mark Azes' accession. This era was earlier reckoned with the victory of an Ujjain king named **Vikramaditya** over the **Shakas**.

Rudradaman I (130 CE–152 CE). He was the most famous of all the Shaka *Kshtarapa* rulers. His empire was spread over almost the whole of western India which included Sindh, Gujarat, Konkan, Narmada Valley, Malwa and Kathiawar except the Nashik and Pune areas. He improved the Sudarshan Lake from Chandragupta Maurya's reign, located in the semi-arid zone of Kathiawar, and this task is described in the famous Junagarh or Girnar Inscription (dated in the Shaka year 72, i.e., 150–151 CE). He had also defeated Gautamiputra Satkarni, the lord of the *Dakshinapatha*, twice, but did not destroy him as he was a close relative. Rudradaman's daughter was married to Gautamiputra Satakarni's son Vasishthiptra Pulumavi.

2.3. Scytho-Parthians/*Shaka-Pahlavas*

In the mid-1st century CE, the Shakas' domination in northwest India was followed by that of the Parthians. **Gondophernes/Guduvhara** was the most famous and important Parthian king and it was during his reign that **St. Thomas** came to India to propagate Christianity.

2.4. Kushans

The Kushans were also referred to as *Yueh–Chis* (Moon tribe) They first occupied Bactria, where they displaced the Shakas, and gradually seized Gandhara, replacing the rule of the Greeks and the Parthians in these areas. Their empire extended from

the river Oxus to the river Ganga, from Khorasan in Central Asia to Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh.

Kujula Kadphises/Kadphises I (15 CE – 64 CE) amalgamated the five clans of the *Yue-chi* tribe and laid the foundations of a unified Kushana empire. He minted coins in copper and is believed to have imitated the Roman '*aurei*' type coins to facilitate trade. His coins also suggest an association with Buddhism. He adopted the epithet '*dharmathida*' and '*sachadharmathida*'.

Vima Kadphises/Wema Kadphises II (64 CE – 78 CE) was the son of Kadphises I and started as a co-ruler with his father for some time but later ruled independently. He conquered Gandhara from the Parthians and further spread the kingdom to the east of the Indus to the Mathura region. He issued a large number of gold coins. He was a firm devotee of Shiva and proclaimed himself as '**Mahishvara**' on his coins. All his coins (both gold and copper) have unmistakable signs of Shiva with his trident bull.

Kanishka (78CE – 101 CE): He was the son of Kadphises II and is perhaps the most famous Kushana king, under whose reign the Kushana empire reached its zenith. It expanded from Central Asia to Afghanistan and north-western India, further east into the Ganga valley and southwards into the Malwa region, and included Varanasi, Kaushambi, and Shravasti in Uttar Pradesh and Sanchi in Madhya Pradesh. The centre of this huge empire was **Bactria**, as evident in the use of the Bactrian language in Kanishka's coins and inscriptions. The famous **Rabatak Inscription** (in modern Baghran province, Afghanistan) presents valuable information on Kanishka. He adopted the title of '**Devputra**', and has been shown wearing a '**peaked helmet**' on some coins.

Kanishka had two capitals: **Purushapura** and **Mathura**. He is remembered for two major reasons. He started the **Shaka era** (78 CE), which is accepted as the **beginning** of his reign. He held the fourth Buddhist council at Kundalavana (near Srinagar) under the presidency of Vasumitra and Aswaghosha. According to legends, it was **Passa**, a Buddhist monk who advised Kanishka to commence the fourth Buddhist Council. Kanishka also patronised the Gandhara and Mathura schools of sculpture. At Mathura, a headless statue of Kanishka depicting him as a warrior has been found. He controlled the famous Silk Route in Central Asia. Another striking aspect of Kanishka's personality was his attitude of religious tolerance as the king's coinage depicts motifs drawn from a great variety of religious traditions: **Indian** (the motifs of the *Shiva* and the *Buddha*), **Greek** (motifs of Greek deities such as *Helios*- a sun god and *Selene*-moon goddess), and West Asian (such as motifs of Persian gods *Atash*-fire god, and *Mithra*-sun god). Towards the end of his long reign, it appears that he led an unsuccessful military expedition into Central Asia against the Chinese and was defeated by General **Pan-Chao** and forced to pay tribute to the Chinese emperor **Ho-ti**.

The immediate successors of Kanishka were **Vasishka**, **Huvishka**, **Kanishka II** (who adopted the title of 'Kaiser'), and Vasudeva I, who during his reign, around the mid-2nd century CE took the title ***Shaono Shao Vasudevo Koshano***, which indicates that by this time the Kushanas were totally **Indianized**.

2.5. The Impact and Contribution of Contacts with Central Asia

1. Pottery and Architecture: They introduced the use of burnt bricks for flooring and tiles for both flooring and roofing. Red pottery techniques, which were widely used in Central Asia, were replicated in the Indian Subcontinent too.
2. Trade and Agriculture: Due to the establishment of intimate contacts between Central Asia and India, trade between the two regions also flourished. India imported a good deal of gold from the Altai mountains of Central Asia. It is rather pertinent to note that even though it was the Indo-Greeks who introduced gold coins in India, it was the Kushanas who were the first rulers in India to issue gold coins on such a wide scale. The Kushanas also promoted agriculture.
3. Military Knowledge and Equipment: Being excellent horsemen themselves, the Shakas and the Kushana introduced better cavalry and popularised the use of riding horses on a large scale. They also brought in caps, helmets, and boots used by warriors. The practice of making leather shoes began in India during this period in all likelihood.
4. Administrative Organisation: The Central Asian conquerors introduced new styles of administration. For instance, the Indo-Greeks introduced the practice of military governorship wherein they appointed military governors called *strategos* while the Kushanas introduced the '*Satrap'* system of government.
5. Science and Technology: Post-Mauryan Indian astronomy and astrology have a huge Greek influence. The term *'horashastra*' used for astrology in Sanskrit was derived from the Greek term 'horoscope'. The Greek coins, which were properly shaped and stamped, were a great improvement on punch-marked coins.

6. Indian Society: One of the striking aspects about the Central Asian conquerors was that not only did they assimilate with the Indian society, but they also added new ingredients to Indian culture and enriched it immensely.

7. Impact on Buddhism: The origin of Mahayana Buddhism owes a lot to the Central Asian influence. The monks and nuns could not afford to lose the cash donations from the growing body of traders and artisans and thus now started accepting gold and silver, took to non-vegetarian food and wore elaborate robes.

8. Art and Literature: There were three major schools of sculptural art which developed in this period. These were: **Gandhara** School of art, **Mathura** school of art, and **Amravati** school of art.

- The Buddha is depicted with a garment draped in Graeco-Roman fashion, and with very curly hair. These beautiful images of the Buddha are ranked among the best pieces of sculptures to have been recovered.
- The Brahmanical influence on the art school of Mathura is also evident. During the Kushana period, a number of sculptures of Brahmanical deities were carved, which included *Kartikeya*, *Vishnu*, and *Kubera*.

9. Literature: The Central Asian rulers also patronised and helped in the growth of Sanskrit literature. The earliest specimen of *kavya* style and that too in chaste Sanskrit is found in the Junagadh Inscription of Rudradaman I. Some of the great creative authors such as Ashvaghosha enjoyed the patronage of the Kushanas. Some of the important Buddhist texts such as *Mahavastu* and *Divyavadana* belonged to this period.

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Chapter 9| Sangam Age

The Sanskrit word 'Sangha' means a group of persons or an association. The three important kingdoms of the Cholas, the Pandyas and the Cheras, combinedly were known as **Tamilakam**.

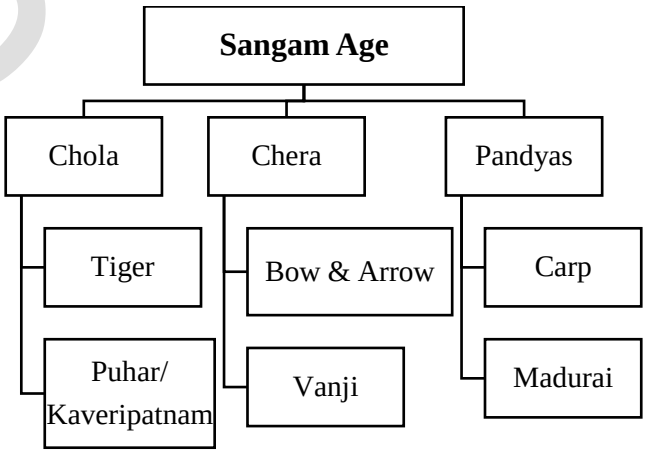
Sangam Literature

Sangam was a college or assembly of Tamil poets held under the Royal patronage of Pandayan Kings in Madurai. It is said that the assembly lasted for 9,990 years and was attended by 8,598 poets and 197 pandyas. According to the legends, there were three Sangams (Academy of Tamil poets) held in ancient South India popularly called Muchchangam. The First Sangam is believed to be held at Madurai, attended by gods and legendary sages. No literary work of this Sangam is available. The Second Sangam was held at Kapadapuram, only Tolkappiyam survives from this. The Third Sangam was also held at Madurai. A few of these Tamil literary works have survived and are useful sources to reconstruct the history of the Sangam period.

The Sangam corpus includes six of the eight anthologies of poems included in the *Ettutokai* (The Eight Collections), and nine of the ten *pattus* (songs) of the *Pattuppattu* (The Ten Songs). The style and certain historical references in the poems suggest that this literature is most likely composed between the 3rd Century BCE and the 3rd century CE. Around the mid-8th century, they were compiled into anthologies, which were further collected into the super-anthologies (the anthologies of anthologies) called the *Ettutokai* and the *Pattuppattu*. It is rather interesting to note that the anthologies include a total of 2381 poems ascribed to 473 poets, out of whom 30 poets were women. Apart from these poems, the first two books of the *Tolkappiyam* (a book on Tamil grammar and poetics written by Tolkappiyar) are also a part of the corpus of Sangam Literature. There is also mention of the *Agattiyam*, which was the first known book on Tamil grammar. It was supposedly written by the sage Agathiyar and is believed to be lost beyond redemption. The sage Agathiyar, according to Hindu legends, brought the Tamil language and its syntax to the Tamil people from the god Shiva. It is believed that Tolkappiyar, the author of *Tolkappiyam*, was the disciple of Agathiyar. Poems within Sangam literature was composed on two broader themes of *akam* (love) and *puram* (mostly based on war but also included public poetry such as poems on good and evil, community and kingdom).

Sangam literature can be divided into two groups: narrative and didactic. The narrative texts are called Melkannakku (18 Major Works consisting of eight anthologies and ten idylls) and are considered works of heroic poetry in which heroes are glorified and perpetual wars and cattle raids are frequently mentioned. The didactic works are called Kilkanakku (18 Minor Works).

A large number of Tamil didactic works such as Tiruvalluvar's *Tirukkural* (famous work on ethics, philosophy, polity, and love, and considered the fifth Veda of Tamil Nadu), Tamil epics such as *Silappadikaram* written by Ilango Adigal (considered the brightest gem of early Tamil literature which deals with the love story of Kovalan, who prefers a courtesan Madhavi of Kaveripattnam to his noble wedded wife Kannagi) and *Manimekalai* (a sequel to *Silappaddikaram* and is considered the 'Odyssey of Tamil poetry', which deals with the adventures of the daughter born of the union of Kovalan and Madhavi and her subsequent conversion to Buddhism) were written in the period between the 5th and 6th centuries. Bharatam, a Tamil epic, was composed of Perudevanar. It also has great importance in Tamil literature.



Chola

The kingdom of the Cholas with its capital at ***Kaveripattanam*** was started from the Kavery delta to the adjoining region of modern Tanjore and Trichinopoly. One of their early kings, ***Karikala*** (A.D. 190), who figures very prominently in ancient literature, is credited with victories over the rulers of the neighbouring Pandya and Chera kingdoms and is believed to have even extended his authority over **Ceylon**. He constructed 160 km of embankment along the Kaveri River. It is mentioned that this was built with the labour of 12,000 slaves brought as captives from Sri Lanka. He defeated a confederacy

of Pandyas, Cheras and their allies at the **Battle of Venni**. **Tondaiman Ilandiraiyan** was another important Chola ruler who ruled from Kanchi either as an independent ruler or as a subordinate ruler of Karikala. He was a gifted poet, and in one of his poems, he emphasised the personal character of the king.

Chera

The earliest reference to the Chera (Keralaputra) kingdom can be traced in the Ashokan inscription. Its capital was *Vanji*. The people of Chera Kingdoms were a sea-faring people who, established close commercial relationships with Egypt and the Roman Empire. Tondi, Musiri, Kaveripathanam and Korkai were among the well-known trade centres of Peninsular India. **Udiyanjeral** is the earliest known Chera king. **Nedunjeral Adan** was one of the prominent kings of the Chera dynasty, who probably defeated seven crowned kings and won the coveted title of *adhiraja*. It is also claimed that he not only defeated an enemy on the Malabar coast but also captured several *yavana* traders and later released them after taking ransom. **Senguttuvan** was Nedunjeral Adan's son and was their greatest king, also known as the Red or Good Chera. He won a battle against the Mokur chieftain. He also claimed to have invaded the north and fought against an Aryan chieftain in order to obtain stone for an image of Kannagi (the heroine of the *Silappadikaram* and considered the goddess of chastity), and crossed the Ganga and had a bath in the Ganga before bringing the stone back to his country. **Kudakko Ilanjeral Irumporai** was one of the last Chera kings mentioned in the Sangam texts, who is also believed to have won wars against the Cholas and Pandyas.

Pandyas

The kingdom of the Pandyas with its capital at *Madurai* extended to the modern districts of Madura, Ramnad, Tinnevelly and the southern parts of Travancore. A Pandya king is also known to have been sent as an embassy to the court of the Roman emperor **Augustus** and **Trojan**. **Nedunjeliyan I** was the earliest known king of Pandays. It is believed that he died of remorse due to his tragic role (as he ordered the execution) in the death of Kovalan, the hero and the husband of Kannagi of the *Silappadikaram.*. It is believed that at a very young age, he defeated a confederacy of Cheras, Cholas and five other chieftains in the battle of *Talaiyalanganam*.

Sangam Polity

The Tamils during the Sangam period were ruled by powerful kings. The kings were regarded as **Vendar** while the local chieftains were called **Mannar**. The form of government was a hereditary monarchy. The eldest son usually succeeded the father. The crowned king held impressive courts to which the subjects were allowed. **The king was regarded as God**. The theory of the divine right of kingship was accepted. But he was always assisted and guided by wise men whether a minister, a poet or a purohitar. These wise men were divided into two categories—**Aimperukulu** consisting of Purohita, the army chief, the ambassador, the spies and the ministers; and **Enperayam** consisting of accountants, executive officials, treasury officials, palace guards, and the leading men among his subjects. Wars occurred on the pretext of cattle-lifting.

Aimperukku Officials	
Purohitar	Priest
Senapatiyar	Army Chief
Amaichhar	Minister
Dutar	Ambassador
Orrar	Spy
Enadi	Captain of the army
Umanchatha	Collector of merchandise
Makamattor	Members of a guild
Veellalar	Rich peasants

Enperayam Officials	
Karanattiyalavar	Accountant
Karumakarar	Executive officials
Kanasassurram	Treasury Officials
Kdaikappalar	Palace guards
Nagaramandar	Leading men among the king's subjects
Padaittalaivar	Chiefs of the infantry
Yanai Virar	Chiefs of elephantry
Ivuli	Chiefs of cavalry

Justice

Sangam literature does not describe any posts of Judge disputes that were settled by learned men of high character, and the judgement was based on integrity and impartiality. The Cholas have gained great respect because of this. The king was the supreme magistrate. The town court was called '***Avai***' and the village court was knonw as '***Manrams***' which might have been pachayats, were distributed across *Mandalam* (kingdom) in *Nadu* (districts) and *Ur* (town).

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Society

The Sangam society was based on binary fission, i.e., Vyarntoc (high-born people), Ilipirappalar (low-born people). However, Tholkappiyan mentions four categories of castes– Andanar (Brahmanas,) Arasar (kings), Vaisiyar (Traders), Velalar (Farmers). Moreover, these communities, called **parciyas** experienced untouchability among higher classes. Women took part in various fields, i.e., they contributed in literature, evidence is from their poetry, and they were allowed to choose their life partners (*love-marriage* was permitted). *Widows* lived a miserable life and the *sati* system was practiced in higher classes of society. The kings and nobles patronised dancers for their entertainment.

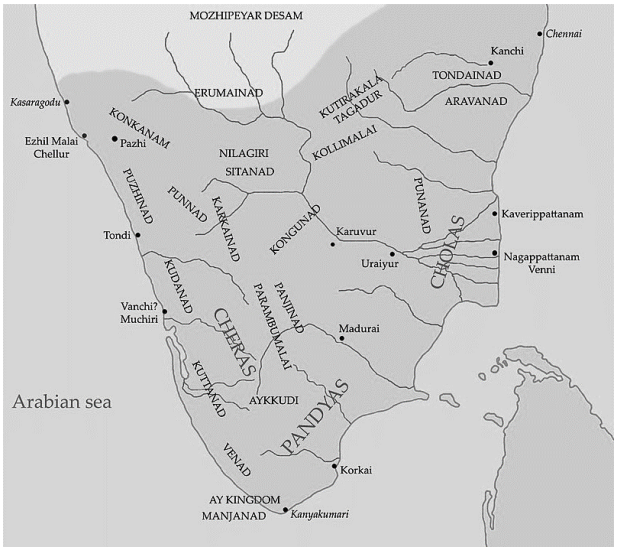
Economy

The Sangam economy was the most prosperous. The common people included agriculturists or cow herders, hunters and fishermen. Indigenous industries such as textile, weapon making, ship-building, carpentry, metal smelting, etc. There were also a large number of merchants who indulged in comprehensive trade with foreign countries, particularly with Rome. Roman **coins** of **Augustus Caesar's** period have been found in a large number in South India. However, South Indians did not have a system of coinage and they bartered their goods. Examples of honey and roots exchanged for fish oil and of sugarcane and cornflakes for venison and toddy are mentioned.

Religion

Sangam religion is based on the synthesis of the non-Aryan Tamils and the Aryan Vedic deities. The people of Sangam Tamil generally worshipped stones, water, stars and planets. The Sangam religious worship is classified into three categories– (i) Worship of indigenous Gods, (ii) Worship of exotic Hindu Gods (iii) Worship or faith in exotic non-Hindu rituals. The people worshipped ***Murugan***, ***Tirumal, Balram*** and ***Indra*** in the temple known as **Nagar, Koil, Kottam, Purai or Devalayam**. The worship of Vedic deities was also not uncommon. The Vedic practices of Yagna (Velvi) Sraddha and Panda were practised by the Sangam people. The Sangam poems reflect the emergence of new bases of royal prestige and legitimacy by performing Brahmanical sacrifices. For instance, a Pandya ruler, Mudukudumi, took the title *Palshalai* (one who has many sacrificial halls). The influence of Buddhism, Jainism and Ajivikas was paramount.

Sangam Terms	
Enadi	Captain of army
Vallalas	Rich peasants
Arasar	Ruling class
Orrar	Spies
Avai	Small village assembly
Irai/Karai	Land tax
Ulgu/sungam	Tolls and custom duties
Nagar	Temple
Perundaram	Higher officials
Sirutaram	Lower officials
Avanam	Market place
Panar	Birds
Vedars	Hunters
Marakkhdi	Warrior class
Kuravar	Hill tribes
Varalis	Dancing girls
Lamaram	Missile
Kalavu	Sacred marriage
Umanar	Salt maker
Korravai	Goddess of victory
Kadurai	Diety of forest
Eripatti	Tank



Chapter 10| Gupta Empire

The Guptas are most likely Vaishyas in origin who were ruling from Pataliputra. Gupta period is often considered as the 'golden age' of India's past as it is often remembered for certain key classical features, such as the political unification of a large part of the subcontinent under a mostly centralized government, the production of exceptional Sanskrit literary works, sophisticated stone sculpture and architecture, and innovative developments in the field of science and technology. It is said that Shrigupta/Mahagupta founded the Gupta Empire in 319. He was succeeded by his grandson Chandragupta I, son of Ghatotkach.

Chandragupta-I (319–335/336): He is the first important king of the Gupta Dynasty who laid the foundations of the Gupta Empire and claimed the title of *maharajadhiraja* (king of kings). He started the Gupta era in 319−20. He enhanced his power and prestige by marrying Kumaradevi, princess of Lichchhavi clan of Nepal. Coins were struck in the joint names of the emperor. In fact, Samudragupta was referred to as *Lichchhavi-dauhitra* (grandson of the Lichchhavis) in the famous *Allahabad prashasti*.

Samudragupta (335/336–375): He was a son of Chandragupta I who followed a policy of war and conquest and enormously enlarged his kingdom. His rule was one of the expansions marked first by the conquest of his immediate neighbours and then by campaigns to the east and the south, where chiefdoms and kingdoms were subdued and forced to pay tribute to him. Due to this policy of his, the historian V. A. Smith has called him the 'Napoleon' of India. His achievements are recorded in a long inscription engraved on the Allahabad pillar (Prayaga prashasti), whose surface also contains inscriptions of Ashoka and later, the Mughal emperor Jahangir. It was composed in pure Sanskrit by Harisena (court poet and *kumaramatya)* who described himself by different titles such as *sandhivigrahika* (minister for peace and war) and *mahadandanayaka* (judicial/military officer).

He celebrated his conquests by performing an *ashvamedha* and by issuing *ashvamedha* coins marking the occasion. He was called *Anukampavan* (full of compassion) as he granted permission to the Buddhist king of Ceylon, Meghavarman, to build a monastery and rest house for pilgrims from Ceylon at Bodh Gaya. He was a great patron of art and adopted the title of Kaviraja (king among poets). His love for music is attested by his coins that represent him playing on the veena (lyre) on occasion. Though Hindu by practice, he extended his patronage to other religions, and one of his ministers was the great Buddhist philosopher Vasubandhu. Samudragupta is remembered for his patronage of art and literature.

Allahabad Pillar Inscription/Prayag Prashasti

The *prashasti* divides Samudragupta's opponents into four categories: rulers slain, whose dominions Samudragupta annexed outright; 'frontier' kings, who were forced to pay homage; rulers defeated, but reinstated as tributaries; and 'distant' kings, who acknowledged Samudragupta as an emperor by sending him embassies.

The Prayag *prashasti* mentions the defeat of the twelve South Indian rulers (together) by Samudragupta (including Vishnugopa of Kanchi). However, instead of annexing the southern kingdoms, he adopted the policy of political conciliation and reinstated the defeated kings on their thrones. The ruler of Ceylon sent an embassy to secure privileges for Sinhalese monks at Bodh Gaya. The inscription adds that *Samudragupta also received tributes from many kings of south-east Asia*.

Chandragupta II (376 – 413/15): According to some legends, Samudragupta was succeeded by his elder son **Ramagupta**, but Chandragupta II killed him. It is also believed that during Ramagupta's tenure, the Gupta empire was invaded by a powerful Shaka king. Ramagupta lost the battle and signed a humiliating treaty that allowed his wife to be sent to the enemy camp. It is said that Chandragupta II had to kill his brother and marry his wife, Dhruvadevi, to safeguard the honour of the Gupta dynasty.

The peak of the territorial expansion of the Gupta empire was reached during Chandragupta II's reign (also known as Chandragupta Vikramaditya), who extended the limits of his empire by conquests and marital alliances with other royal dynasties of the period. He married Kuberanaga, the Naga princess,

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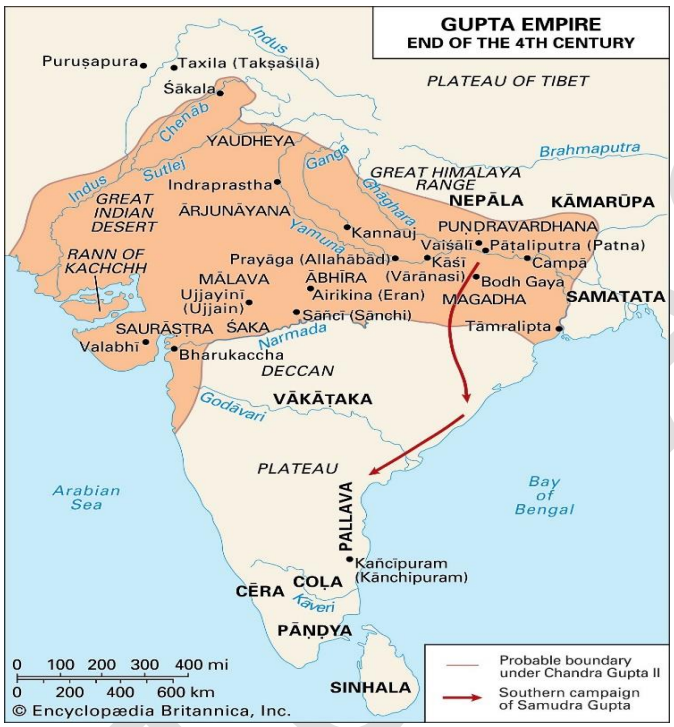
and had a daughter, Prabhavati, with her. Prabhavati was married to Rudrasena II of the ruling Vakataka dynasty in Deccan. After the death of her husband, Prabhavati ruled the territory as regent to her minor sons with the help of her father. During this twenty-year period, the Vakataka realm was practically a part of the Gupta empire.

Chandragupta exercised indirect control over the Vakataka kingdom. With his great influence in this central Indian region, he was able to target his other enemies better. Thus, he conquered western Malwa and Gujarat from the Shaka satraps. This conquest took the expanse of the Gupta empire to the western sea coast. This contributed to the prosperity of Malwa and its chief city Ujjain, which was also Chandragupta II's second capital.



An iron pillar inscription at Mehrauli in Delhi indicates that his empire included even north-western India and Bengal. He took the title of *Vikramaditya*, that is, the one who is as powerful as the sun, and *Simhavikrama*. He was the first ruler to issue silver coins. He also issued copper coins and is referred to as *Chandra* on his coins. He also issued gold coins called *dinara*. The Udaigiri cave inscriptions refer to his *digvijaya*, that is, his conquest of the whole world. Fa Hien/Faxian, the famous Chinese traveller, visited India during his reign. His court at Ujjain was adorned by nine famous scholars known as the *Navaratnas* ('nine gems'), i.e., Kalidasa, Amarasimha, Varahamihira, Dhanvantri, Ghatakarapara, Shanku, Kahapanaka, Vararuchi, and Vetala Bhatta.

Kumaragupta I (415 – 455): He adopted the title of *Shakraditya* and *Mahendraditya* and performed the ashavmedha sacrifice. He founded the Nalanda University. He was a worshipper of lord *Karttikeya*. During the last years of his reign, peace was disturbed on the northwest frontier due to the invasion of the Huns of Central Asia. In the mid-5th century, the *ye-tha*, known as White Huns (Hepthalites), became powerful in the Oxus valley. After occupying Bactria, the Huns crossed the Hindukush mountains and entered India by occupying Gandhara. Their first attack during his reign was repulsed by Prince Skandagupta. Kumaragupta I also struggled against Pushyamitra, an uncertain chieftain.

The Bilsad inscription is the oldest record of his reign and dates to Gupta year 96, which corresponds to 415. Other inscriptions of Kumaragupta's reign are the Karandanda, Mandsor, and Damodar Copper plate inscriptions.

Skandagupta (455 – 467): He first defeated Pushyamitra and then faced and repulsed the Huns successfully. Junagarh/Girnar's inscription of his reign tells that *his governor Parnadatta got the* Sudarshan Lake *repaired*. He adopted the title *Vikramaditya*. The Gupta empire continued to exist but central control weakened and local governors became feudatory kings with hereditary rights.

Following Skandagupta's death, the empire was clearly in decline and the later Gupta coinage indicates their loss of control over much of western India after 467–469. Skandagupta was followed by:

1. Purugupta (467–473)
2. Kumaragupta II (473–476),
3. Budhagupta (476-495),
4. Narasimhagupta (495–530)
5. Kumaragupta III (530–540)
6. Vishnugupta (540–550)
7. Vainyagupta and Bhanugupta.

The first epigraphic evidence of Sati has been found in the Eran Pillar Inscription of Bhanugupta, Madhya Pradesh. Some records suggest that the first example of Sati appears in the Gupta Period in 510

AD. After about this time, instances of Sati began to be marked by inscribed memorial stones.

Decline of the Guptas

Though their rule lasted till the middle of the sixth century A.D. the imperial glory had ended a century earlier. There are several reasons for the decline of the Guptas, i.e., (i) invasion by the Hunas, (ii) rise in feudalism, (iii) weak successors, (iv) financial difficulties, (v) decline of foreign trade, and (vi) absence of large professional army to maintain vast empire.

Revenue & Trade

There were of eighteen types of taxes in which land revenue and *Bhaga* were the chief source of income. The inscription of Pallavas and Vakatakas show that taxes were enforced on buffalo milk, curd and also on fruits and flowers. The forests, meadows and salt mines, added to the income of the state. During this period, the ship-building industry was at peak. *Tamralipti*, a port in Bengal, was an important trade centre and from there trade was carried on with the eastern countries like China, Ceylon, Java and Sumatra. In Andhra, there were many ports on the banks of the rivers, Godavari and Krishna; *Tondai* was a famous port of Chola state. Kalyana, Chol, Broach and Cambay were the important ports of the South.

Important Officials at the Central Level	
Mahabaladhikrita	Commander-in-Chief
Mahadanayak	Chief justice
Mahapratihar	An official for the royal palace.
Mahasandhivigrahak	An official for post-war conciliation
Dandapashika	Head of the police department
Bhandagaradhikreta	Head of the royal treasury
Mahapaksha-Patalik	Head of the accounting department
Vinaysthitisansathapak	Head of the Education Department
Sarvadhyaksha	Inspector for all central departments
Mahashwapati	Controller of cavalry
Mahamahipilapati	Controller and executor of Elephantry
Vinaypura	Official to present guests at king's court
Yuktapurusha	Office to keep account of war booty
Khadyatpakika	Inspector of royal kitchen
Ranabhandagarika	Officer-in-charge of army stores
Mahanarpati	Head of foot soldiers (infantry)

Administration

The Gupta kings adopted pompous titles such as parameshavara, maharajadhiraja and paramabhattaraka which signify that they ruled over kings in their empire. Kingship was hereditary, but royal power was limited by absence of a firm practice of primogeniture. The throne did not always go to the eldest son. The most important officers in the Gupta empire were the *kumaramatyas*. The Guptas organized a system of rovincial and local administration. The empire was divided into divisions (*bhuktis*) and each bhukti was placed under the charge of an *uparika*. The bhuktis were divided into districts (*vishayas*), which were placed under the charge of *vishyapati*. Land taxes increased while those on trade and commerece decreased; land tax was between 1/4 to 1/6 of the produce. ***Visthi*** (Forced labour) prevailed. Religious functionaries were granted land called *Agrahara*.

Art & Architecture

The Gupta period witnessed exceptional growth in the field of architecture, sculpture, painting and terra cotta. That is why the period is also known as the '*Golden Age of Ancient India*'. In architectural types it gave entrance to a new age which is particularly noticed in the architectural style of the temples. In fact, it initiated a creative and formative period for the foundation of a typical Indian temple architecture. Apart from temple architecture rock-cut architecture also reached their zenith. The most remarkable of these are to be found in Ajanta, Ellora, Aurangabad (Hyderabad) and Bagh (Central India). Bragnabucak rock-cut shrines although lesser in number than those of the Buddhist, were not rare either.

Reference may be made in this connection to the Udaygiri series of shrines near Bhilsa in Bhopal state. The shrines are both rock-cut Brahmanical shrines and are also to be found at Badami in the Bijapur district. Jaina caves are to be found at Badami as well as at *Aihole*. The art of painting, including *terra-cotta* and clay modelling, was considered a secular character during this period and became more popular than stone sculpture. The best specimens of paintings of the period are to be found on the walls of the *Ajanta caves, Bagh cave in Gwalior, Settannavasal temple* at *Puddukkottai* and at *Badami*. Incidents of the life of Buddha were the main theme of the Gupta painters. The Painting '*Dying Princess*' in one Ajanta cave has earned the admiration of Burgress,

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Fergussion, Griffiths and many others. The Gupta art of painting has been praised by art critics for its brilliance of colour, richness of expression and delicacy of execution. The artists of the Gupta age were also superb in casting metals and making of copper statues. The iron pillar at Delhi made at the time of Samudragupta is a marvel of the metallurgical skill of the Gupta period artists.

Literature

During the period of the Gupta dynasty, Sanskrit literature greatly flourished. It would not be unfair to say that there was never such a literary outburst in India especially in the sphere of Sanskrit language. Prose and poetry both were written during this period. The Allahabad Pillar Inscription shows that Harisena was a poet of great eminence. The manner in which, he has described the achievement of Samudragupta by Chandragupta signifies he was a poet of great calibre. Poetry, verse and drama of a very high class were composed and written in this age. The name of Kalidasa shines like a glittering star in the period. It is very difficult to say which of his work is the best but *Shakuntalam* is the most popular of his plays. Before the Shakuntalam, Kalidasa had already composed two plays, the *Malavikagnimitra* and the *Vikramorvasiya*. His two Mahakavyas, *Raghuvamsa* and *Kamarasambhava* and the lyrical poem *Meghaduta* are universally regarded as g*ems of Sanskrit poetry.* Philosophical literature was also written during this period. The Hindus, Buddhists and Jains all wrote on the principles of their respective religions. A commentary was written on Sankhya philosophy and also on Mimansa Sutra. In this perioed Vatsayana wrote a commentary on the philosophy of law, although his views were contradicted, later on, by Dingnaga Chandra, a great intellect, wrote a book called '*Dashpadarthastra*'.

Mathematics

In the field of mathematics, *Aryabhatiya* written by *Aryabhata*, who belonged to Pataliputra is important work. It seems that this mathematician was well versed in various kinds of calculations. A Gupta inscription of Allhabad suggests that the decimal system was known in India at the beginning of the fifth century A.D. In the field of astronomy, a book called *Romaka Sidhanta* was compiled. It was influenced by Greek ideas, as can be inferred from its name. *Aryabhatta* was the first to use the *decimal system*. He formulated the rule for finding out the area of triangle which led to the origin of *trigonometry* and calculated the value of **pie (π)**. He laid the foundation of algebra in his aryabhatiya. The most famous work of this time was *Suryasidhanta*. Brahmagupta in 7th century A.D. began to apply algebra to astronomical problems. The three major contributions in the field of mathematics are the notational system, the decimal system and the use of zero.

Metallurgy

The Gupta craftsmen distinguished themselves by their work in iron and bronze. In the case of iron objects, the best example is the iron pillar found at Mehrauli in Delhi. Manufactured in the fourth century A.D. believed to be erected by *Kumaragupta*, the pillar has not gathered any rust in the subsequent 15 centuries, which is a great tribute to the technological skill of the craftsmen.

Astronomy

Aryabhatta and *Varahmihir* were prominent astronomers. The former found out the cause of lunar and solar eclipses; calculated the circumference of the earth; was the first to reveal that the sun is stationary and the earth revolved around the sun. Varahamihir's well-known works are *Brihatsamhita* and *Panch Sidhhantika*. Brahmagupta wrote the *Brahma Sphutic Siddhata* in verse and laid the foundation of the law of gravitation.

Medicine

Sushruta and *Charak* were the two great physicians of this period. The *Sushruta Samhita* describes the methods of operating cataracts, stone diseases and various other ailments. Charaka is considered to be the father of Indian Medicine. *Vrihad Vagabhatta*, a well-known physician, guided by the work of Charaka, wrote *Astanghridaya*.

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Literary Works During Gupta Period	
Kalidasa	Raghuwansa, Ritusamhara, Meghaduta, Vikramovarshiya, Malvikagnimitra and Abhijnanasakuntalam
Batsabhatti	Ravanabodha
Dandin	Kavyadarshana and Dasakumarcharita
Bharavi	Kiratarjuniyam
Bhartahari	Nitishataka
Sudaraka	Mrichchakatika
Bhasa	Swapnavasavadatta, Charudatta and Pratignayaugandharayana
Visakhadatta	Mudrarakshasa and Devichandraguptam
Harisena	Pryag-Prasasti
Ishwar Krishna	Sankhyakarika (base on Sankhya philosophy)
Prashastipada	Padartha Dharmasangraha
Acharya Vyasa	Vyasa Bhasya (based on Yoga philosophy)
Vatsyayana	Nyaya Bhasya (on Nyaya philosophy)
Religious Works	The Ramayana and the Mahabharata,
Amarsimha	Amarakosha
Chandragomin	Chandravyakarana
Dandin	Kavyadarsha
Vishnu Sharma	Panchatantra and Hitopadesha
Smritis	Vaynavalkyasmriti, Parasharsmriti, Brihspatismriti, Naradasmriti and Katyayanasmriti
Aryabhatta	Aryabhattiya, Dashjitikasutra
Varahmihira	Aryashtashata
Brahmagupta	Brhatsamhita, Panchasidhantika and Brahmasidhanata

The Vakatakas (225-510)

The Satavahanas were succeeded by the Vakatakas, a local power in northern Maharashtra and Vidarbha (Berar). The Vakatakas, who were Brahmanas themselves, are known from a large number of copper plates and grants issued to the Brahmanas. They were great champions of the Brahmanical religion and performed several Vedic sacrifices. Their political history is of more importance to North India than to South India. Culturally, they became a channel for transmitting Brahmanical ideas and social institutions to the south. The founder of this dynasty was **Vidya Shakti** but his son **Pravarsena** could be its real founder in western and central India. In the 5th century A.D., Vakatakas extended their power in Malwa. **Harisena** was the last important monarch controlling all the central Deccan. They were uprooted by the growing power of **Chalukyas** of Badami, **Pallavas** of Kanchipuram and **Pandyyas** of Madurai.

The Vakatakas had matrimonial ties with the imperial Guptas (Rudrasena II was married to Prabhavatigupta, the daughter of Chandragupta II), the Nagas of Padmavati, the Kadambas of Karnataka, and the Vishnukundins of Andhra. The rock-cut Buddhist *vihara*s and *chaitya*s of the Ajanta Caves were built under the patronage of the Vakataka king, Harisena. They are also credited with having built a few temples in Tigwa and Nachanakuthara. They made a remarkable contribution in the field of painting.
Vindhyashakti I (Around 250-270) founded the Vakataka dynasty, who probably ruled from Purika. The Ajanta Inscriptions of the time of Harisena describes him as a *dvija* and praises him for his military achievements. It is claimed that *the sun was obscured by the masses of dust raised by his horses' hooves, and he is compared with the gods Puramdara (Indra) and Upendra* (*Vishnu*).

Pravarasena (270-330): He extended the empire southwards into Vidarbha and adjoining areas of the Deccan, with his capital at Kanchanaka (modern Nachna). His son Gautamiputra married the daughter of the Naga king Bhavanaga, which cemented an important political alliance. By military exploits and matrimonial alliances, he extended his kingdom from Bundelkhand in the north to Hyderabad in the south, and to commemorate his victories, he performed an *asvamedha* sacrifice and a *vajapeya* sacrifice. He was the only Vakataka king who took the title of *samrat*, while all other kings took the modest title of maharaja. After the death of Pravarasena, his four sons divided the empire and ruled independently in separate provinces.

Gautamiputra in all likelihood died during the lifetime of his father and hence, his son Rudrasena I succeeded his grandfather Pravarsena to the throne and ruled from Nandivardhana, near modern Nagpur. Sarvasena, another son of Pravarasena, started ruling independently from Vastugulma as his capital, which is identified as modern Bassien in Vidarbha.

By 340 CE, the Vakatakas were divided into two lines, one ruling from Nandivardhana and the other ruling from Vatsagulma. It is rather interesting to note that in spite of these divisions in the Vakataka kingdom, the contemporary Gupta rulers never attacked the Vakatakas. This may be due to the Guptas' belief that the Vakatakas could be useful to them in defeating the Western Kashtrapas.

Nandivardhana Branch/Line

Rudrasena I (340-365): He was the founder of the Vakataka Nandivardhana branch, which ruled from Nandivardhana (near Nagpur). He is known to have been a worshipper of Lord *Mahabhairava*, the fierce form of Shiva.

Prithvisena I (365–390): Described in later Vakataka inscriptions as a righteous conqueror, he was compared to the epic hero Yudhishthira due to his comparable qualities of truthfulness, transparency, compassion, and humility. Padmapura seems to have been an important administrative centre during his time. During the later parts of his reign, the Guptas and the Vakatakas entered into a matrimonial alliance since Prithvisena's son Rudrasena II, the crown prince, was married to Prabhavatigupta, the daughter of Chandragupta II. Prithivisena also was a Shaiva like his father.

Rudrasena II (390–395): Ruled only for a period of five years as he died prematurely, leaving behind three minor sons Divakarasena, Damodarasena, and Pravarasena. His wife Prabhavatigupta ruled as the regent until 410. *Unfortunately*, Divakarasena also died prematurely and did not live long enough to ascend the throne but his younger brothers Damodarasena and Pravavarasena II did. In fact, the seal of Prabhavatigupta's Maregaon plates describes her as the '*mother of two kings.*'

Pravarasena II (395 – 440). Largest number of Vakataka inscriptions belong to his reign. He is credited with the founding of a new capital at Pravarapura, which is identified as Paunar in the presentday Wardha district. Even though he was a devotee of Shiva, he composed a Prakrit *kavya* glorifying Rama, the *Setubandha*/*Ravanavaha*. He entered into a matrimonial alliance with the contemporary Kadambas (near Mysore). His son Narendrasena was married to a princess of Kuntala, Ajihata Bhattarika, the daughter of Kakutsavarman of the Kadamba dynasty.

Narendrasena (440 – 460): It is believed that after the death of Pravarsena II, a struggle for succession happened in which Narendrasena emerged successful. He had to face the invasion of the Nala king, Bhavadottavarman, both in the beginning and at the end of his reign. In between, he made some conquests, and had to face the stiff opposition of the Nalas all along.

Prithivisena II (460 – 480) is the last known ruler of the Nandivardhana branch of the Vakataka dynasty, who is credited with the revival of the fallen fortunes of the Vakatakas. His inscriptions refer to his *having twice rescued the sunken fortunes of Vakatakas*. He had to face the invasion of Harisena of Vatsagulma line thrice, and the invasion of Bhavadottavarman of the Nala dynasty. He also appears to have fought with the Traikutaka king, Dahrasena of southern Gujarat. After Prithivisena II's death, it is presumed that Harisena of the Vatsagulma line of the Vakatakas conquered his successors and united the Nandivardhana line with his own.

Vatsagulma Branch/Line

The second major Vakataka line was the Vatsagulma branch, which had its capital at Vatsagulma (modern Washim in Akola district, Maharashtra). The founder *of the* Vatsagulma line of the Vakatakas was Sarvasena, the son of Pravarasena I.

Sarvasena (330 – 355): He adopted the title *dharma-maharaja* and was believed to be a renowned Prakrit poet, and his lost work, the *Harivijaya*, was lauded by later writers. Some of his verses were incorporated into the *Gathasattasai*.

Vindhyashakti II/Vindhyasena (355 – 400): He ruled for almost four decades. He is believed to have defeated the Kadambas of Banavasi, who ruled over Kuntala (north Karnataka). His son and successor **Pravarasena II** appear to have ruled for a period of fifteen years. Pravarasena II was followed by **Devasena**, who was a pleasure-seeking ruler, but luckily had the services of a very capable minister, **Hasthibhoja**. His successor Harisena was the ablest and the greatest ruler of this line.

Harisena (475 – 500): The last known king of the Vatsagulma line, who not only **united** the two

Vakataka branches but also extended his territories by **conquering** Kuntala, Avanti, Kalinga, Kosala, Konkan, and Andhra. His kingdom extended from Malwa in the north to southern Maharashtra in the south, and from the Bay of Bengal in the east to the Arabian Sea in the west. Dandin, a poet of the 6th century CE, described Harisena as "*powerful, truthful and bountiful, glorious, lofty, and a penetrating critic of ethical and economic compendia*". The Thalner copper plates (which record the gifts of villages of bronze workers and goldsmiths) belong to his reign and many of the Ajanta caves were executed during his reign. In one of the inscriptions at Cave XVI and the Ghatotkacha cave, there is mention of his minister Varahadeva. With the death of Harisena II, the glory of the Vakatakas ended and the Nalas, the Kadambas, the Kalachuris, and Yasodharman of Malwa occupied their territory.

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Chapter 11| Post-Gupta Period

By the end of the fifth century, the Gupta Empire broke up into several independent states. The first powerful ruler who emerged after Gupta was Harshvardhan who ruled from 606 to 647 from Thaneswar and later on from Kannauj.

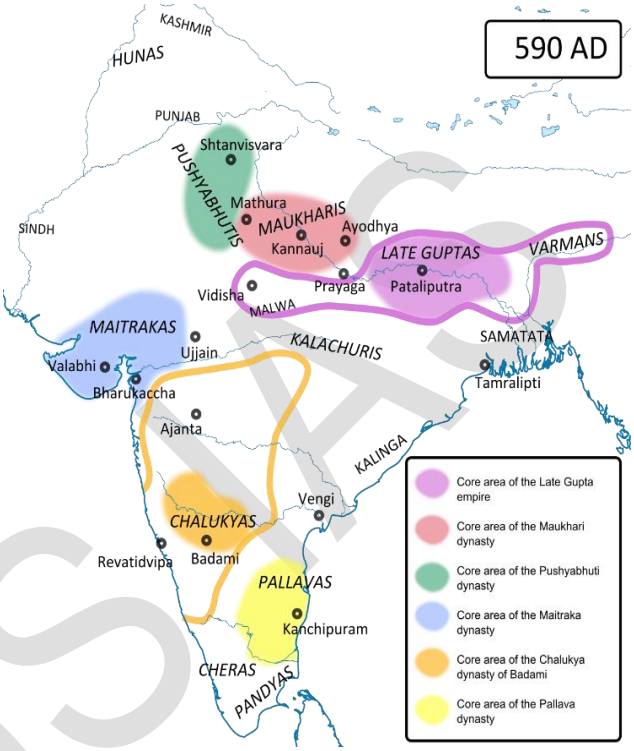
1. Hunas Invasion

The Huna were a Central Asian Xionite tribe that consisted of four hordes: Northern Huna, also known as the Black Huns; Southern Huna, the Red Huns; Eastern Huna, the Celestial Huns; and the White Huns, the Western Huna. The White Huns, those who invaded the Gupta Empire during the reign of Kumaragupta, were also known as the Hephthalites. The Bhitari pillar inscription states that Skandagupta defeated the Hunas who were led by Toraman in 458.

After Skandgupta died in 467, Hunas, under the leadership of Mihirkula (also known, as Mihirgula or the "Indian Attila"), were successful in their invasion of India. They temporarily overthrew the Gupta Empire. Mihirkula ruled from his capital at Sakal, which is today the modern Sialkot. They occupied areas as far south as Eran and Kausambi, greatly weakening the Gupta Empire. The Hunas were ultimately defeated by a coalition of Indian princes that included an Indian king Yasodharman (Malwa) and the Gupta emperor, Narasimhagupta Baladitya. They defeated a Huna army and their ruler Mihirakula in 528 and drove them out of India.

2. The Chalukyas

Chalukyas of Badami: The most notable of the early medieval dynasties of the Deccan was that of the Chalukyas. **Jayasimha** was the first Chalukyan king. But **Pulakeshin** I is generally attributed to be the first Chalukyan king. He was succeeded by Maharaja **Kirtivarman** in 566. **Pulakeshin II** was the most prominent ruler of the dynasty who ruled from 608 and was a contemporary of Harshavardhan. He defeated Harshavardhan in the battle of Narmada (618-19) when he tried to expand his areas in the southern peninsula. Pulakeshin then entered into a treaty with Harsha, with the Narmada River designated as the border between the Chalukya Empire and that of Harshavardhana. His fame was far extended even up to Persia, with whom he exchanged embassies. He was **defeated** and killed by the Pallava ruler **Narsimvarman**. 32 years later in 674, one of Pulakeshin's sons avenged his father's death and captured Kanchi. Pulakeshin's queens were princesses from the Alupa Dynasty of South Canara and the Western Ganga Dynasty of Talakad, both of which were families that had strong familial and marital connections with the Chalukya dynasty.



The Badami Chalukya dynasty faced a brief decline after the death of Pulakeshin II due to internal conflicts, allowing the Pallavas to occupy Badami for thirteen years. The dynasty's fortunes were revived under Vikramaditya I, who expelled the Pallavas from Badami and restored order, taking the title "Rajamalla" to signify his sovereignty over the Pallavas. The long and prosperous reign of Vijayaditya (696–733) was notable for significant temple-building efforts.

The empire reached its zenith again during the reign of Vikramaditya II (733–744), who repeatedly invaded the Pallava territory of Tondaimandalam, defeating Pallava Nandivarman II. He showed magnanimity towards the people and monuments of Kanchipuram, avenging past humiliations by inscribing a Kannada victory note at the Kailasanatha Temple. Under his rule, the Chalukyas repelled Arab invasions in southern Gujarat and subdued several traditional Tamil kingdoms, including the Pandyas, Cholas, Cheras, and a Kalabhra ruler. The Chalukya empire eventually extended from the Kaveri River in the south to the Narmada River in the north. The dynasty ended with the overthrow of the last Chalukya king, Kirtivarman II, by Rashtrakuta King Dantidurga in 753.

2.1. Eastern Chalukyas of Vengi

Pulkeshin II's brother, **Kubja Vishnu Vardhan** established a new dynasty with its capital at the ancient city of Vengi. The Eastern Chalukyas were compelled to acknowledge the supremacy of the Rashtrakutas. Despite occasional military victories, such as those by Vijayaditya II (c. 808–847), it was during Bhima I's reign (c. 892–921) that the Eastern Chalukyas managed to secure a degree of independence. However, after Bhima I's death, the Andhra region once again faced succession struggles and Rashtrakuta interference in Vengi's affairs. The fortunes of the Eastern Chalukyas shifted around the year 1000. King Danarnava was killed in battle in 973 by Bhima of the Telugu Choda dynasty, who then ruled the region for twenty-seven years. During this period, Danarnava's two sons sought refuge in the Chola kingdom. The death of Choda Bhima during his invasion of Tondaimandalam, a Chola territory, ushered in a new phase of Chola-Chalukya relations. Saktivarman I, Danarnava's elder son, was crowned as the ruler of Vengi in 1000, albeit under the suzerainty of Rajaraja Chola I. This burgeoning alliance between the Cholas and the coastal Andhra kingdom was unacceptable to the Western Chalukyas, who had supplanted the Rashtrakutas as the dominant power in the western Deccan. Despite efforts to curb Chola influence in the Vengi region, the Western Chalukyas were unsuccessful.

2.2. Western Chalukyas of Kalyani

The Chalukyas experienced a resurgence in 973, after a period of more than 200 years of relative obscurity during which the Rashtrakutas controlled much of the Deccan. Tailapa II, a Rashtrakuta vassal governing from Tardavadi-1000 in Bijapur district, overthrew Karka II and re-established Chalukya dominance in the western Deccan, reclaiming much of the former Chalukya empire. The Western Chalukyas ruled for over 200 years and were frequently at odds with the Cholas and their kin, the Eastern Chalukyas of Vengi. **Vikramaditya II Tribhuvanmall** (1076-1126) is considered the most prominent ruler of this dynasty. His reign, which lasted for fifty years, was marked by the abolition of the Saka era and the introduction of the Vikrama Era, which became the standard for subsequent Chalukya inscriptions. Vikramaditya VI was a highly ambitious and capable military leader, who managed to terminate Chola dominance over Vengi (coastal Andhra) and assert the Western Chalukyas as the leading power in the Deccan. He was regarded as the hero of Bilhana's *Vikramankadevacharita*. The era of the Western Chalukyas was significant for the development of Kannada and Sanskrit literature. Their reign came to an end towards the close of the 12th century, with the emergence of the Hoysala Empire, the Pandyas, the Kakatiya, and the Seuna Yadavas of Devagiri. Jagadekamall II was the last ruler after whose death his Kalachuri minister Vijjala usurped his throne.

2.3. Chalukya Architecture

The Badami Chalukya period was significant for the development of South Indian architecture from the 6th to the 8th centuries, known for their unique "Chalukyan architecture" or "Karnata Dravida architecture." Their temple construction mainly focused on Aihole, Badami, Pattadakal, and Mahakuta.

1. Early Phase (Late 6th Century):
- Pulakeshin I (Reign: 540–567 CE) initiated the temple-building activity which saw early cave temples at Aihole and Badami.
- Three Cave Temples at Aihole: Constructed under Kirtivarman I in which one Vedic, one Jain, and an incomplete Buddhist temple.
- Four Cave Temples at Badami: Commissioned by Mangalesha. Cave 3 (Vaishnava temple, 578 CE): Built during the reign of Mangalesha, featuring large sculptures of Hindu deities like Harihara, Mahishasuramardhini, Varaha, Narasimha, Trivikrama, Vishnu seated on Anantha, and Nataraja.

2. Second Phase (c. 600):
- Lad Khan Temple at Aihole (c. 620): Built under Pulakeshin II. Known for perforated stone windows and river goddess sculptures.
- Meguti Jain Temple at Aihole (634): Constructed during the reign of Pulakeshin II.
- Durga Temple at Aihole: Initiated under Pulakeshin II with its hybrid northern and southern Indian architectural styles.
- Huccimalli Gudi Temple at Aihole: Another temple from the period of Pulakeshin II, noted for introducing a vestibule.

3. Third Phase (8th Century):
- Virupaksha Temple and Mallikarjuna Temple at Pattadakal (740–745): Commissioned by Lokamahadevi and Trailokyamahadevi, the queens of Vikramaditya II, after his victory over the Pallavas.
- Sangamesvara Temple at Pattadakal (725): Constructed under Vikramaditya II.
- Papanatha Temple and Galaganatha Temple: Early examples of Nagara-Dravida fusion from the reign of Vikramaditya II.
- Bhutanatha Group of Temples at Badami.

2.4. Literature

During the reign of the Chalukyas, both the Badami and Western Chalukya periods made significant contributions to the literary and cultural landscape of South India. The Badami Chalukyas, under rulers like Pulakeshin II, saw the flourishing of Sanskrit and Kannada literature. The Aihole Inscription of Pulakeshin II, composed by his court poet Ravikirti in 634 CE, stands out as a classical work of poetry in both languages. References in inscriptions attest to Kannada being recognized as the "natural language" during this time, with notable literary works like the Kappe Arabhatta record from around 700 CE being early examples of Kannada poetics. The Western Chalukyas, known for their patronage of learning, produced figures like Vijnaneshwara, author of Mitakshara—a seminal treatise on Hindu law, and King Someshvara III, who compiled Manasollasa, an encyclopedic work encompassing various arts and sciences. Meanwhile, in the Eastern Chalukya domain, Telugu literature began to flourish with Nannaya Bhatta emerging as its pioneer in the 11th century. Together, these dynasties fostered a rich literary tradition in Kannada and Telugu, marking a golden age of cultural achievement in the Deccan region.

3. Pallavas (600-757)

The Pallava dynasty, one of the most influential kingdoms in ancient South India, held sway over a vast territory stretching from the northern part of Andhra Pradesh to the River Kaveri in the South. Their capital was Kanchipuram, a city renowned for its cultural and architectural splendour.

During the seventh century, the Pallavas rose to prominence, eclipsing the authority of other neighbouring kingdoms such as the Cholas. Notably, the Pallava king Narasimhavarman dealt significant blows to rival powers. He defeated the Chalukyas, seizing their capital Vatapi (Badami), and subdued other southern dynasties like the Cholas, Cheras, and Pandyas.

The Pallava rulers left an indelible mark on the region's history and culture. Sivaskanda Varman, an early Pallava ruler, performed grand Vedic sacrifices, while his successor, Simhavarman (also known as Simhavishnu), expanded the kingdom to include Sri Lanka. Mahendravarman, a poet and adept administrator, introduced the magnificent rock-cut temple architecture for which the Pallavas are renowned. His son, Narasimhavarman I, emerged as the greatest of the Pallava monarchs, securing victories against formidable foes and founding the iconic city of Mamallapuram (Mahabalipuram). Subsequent rulers continued to assert Pallava authority, though faced challenges from rival kingdoms like the Chalukyas and the Cholas. Ultimately, the dynasty succumbed to the ascendancy of the Chola Empire, with the last Pallava ruler, Aparajitavarman, meeting his demise in battle against the Cholas.

Pallava Rulers		
Ruler	**Reign**	**Key Achievements/Characteristics**
Sivaskanda Varman	4th century	Considered the greatest among early rulers; performed Ashwamedha and other Vedic sacrifices
Simhavarman/Simhavishnu	575–600	Was a Buddhist; included Sri Lanka in his kingdom; defeated contemporary Tamil ruler
Mahendravarman	600–630	Poet, composed Vichitrachita and Mahavilasa Prahasana; introduced rock-cut temple architecture; converted from Jainism to Saivism; engaged in rivalry with Pulakesin II of Chalukya dynasty
Narasimhavarman I	630 – 668	Defeated and killed Pulakesin II; assumed title 'Vatapikonda'; vanquished Cholas, Cheras, and Pandyas; sent naval expedition to Sri Lanka; founded Mahabalipuram; patronized Nayannar saints; noted for agricultural prosperity
Last Rulers		After Mahendravarman II, his son Parameswaravarman became the king. During his rule, Kanchipuram was occupied by the Chalukyas. Nripatunga was an important king who defeated a Pandya king. There were a few other rulers. The last ruler of the Pallava dynasty was Aparajitavarman who was killed in battle with the Cholas.

Despite their eventual decline, the Pallavas left a lasting legacy in South Indian history through their architectural marvels, cultural patronage, and military conquests, shaping the region's socio-political landscape for centuries to come.

3.1. Chalukyas- Pallavas Struggle

The main cause of the struggle between Pallavas and Chalukyas was the supremacy. The Pandyas, who were in control of the Madurai and Tinnevelly district of Tamil Nadu, joined this conflict as a poor third. Although both the Pallavas and the Chalukyas supported Brahmanism, performed Vedic sacrifices and made grants to the Brahmanas, the two quarrelled with each other for prestige and territorial resources. Both tried to establish supremacy over the land lying between the **Krishna** and the **Tungabhadra**. The first important event in this long struggle took place in the reign of **Pulakeshin II** (609-642). He overthrew the Kadamba capital at *Banavasi* and compelled the Ganges of Mysore to accept his suzerainty. He also defeated Harsha's army on the Narmada and checked his march towards the Deccan. In his conflict with the Pallavas, he almost reached the Pallava capital, but the Pallavas purchased peace by ceding their northern provinces to Pulakeshin II. Pulakeshin II invasion of the Pallava territory failed. The Pallava king **Narasimhavarman** (630-668) occupied the Chalukya capital at Vatapi in about 642, when Pulakeshin II was probably killed in the fight against the Pallavas. Narsimhavarman adopted the title of **Vatapikonda** or the conqueror of Vatapi. He is also said to have defeated the Cholas, the Cheras, the Pandyas and the Kalabhras. By the end of the seventh century, the conflict had subsided but it was again resumed in the first half of the eighth century. The Chalukya king **Vikramaditya II** (733-745) is said to have overrun Kanchi three times. In 740, he completely overthrows the Pallavas. His victory ended the Pallava supremacy in the far south although the ruling house continued for more than a century afterwards. However, the Chalukyas could not enjoy the fruits of their victory over the Pallavas for long for their own hegemony was brought to an end in 757 by the Rashtrakutas.

4. Vardhanas (Pushyabhutis of Thanesar)

An important ruling family that gained prominence after the decline of the Gupta was the Pushyabhutis, whose capital was at Thanesar (near Kurukshetra, Haryana). Two major historical sources providing information regarding the Pushyabhuti dynasty are the Harshacharita, a biography of Harsha written by Harsha's court poet Banabhatta, and travelogues of the Chinese pilgrim Hsuan Tsang/Xuanzang. Not much is known about the first three kings of the dynasty. Most likely, the dynasty came into prominence with the accession of Prabhakar Vardhana, who was able to defeat the Hunas and improve his position in the regions of Punjab and Haryana.

4.1. Prabhakar Vardhana (mid-6th century)

Prabhakar Vardhana was the fourth king of the dynasty who laid the foundations of the Pushyabhuti dynasty. He was a great general with several military victories. He established important marital alliances with the Maukharis of Kanyakubja/Kannauj by marrying his own daughter Rajyashri to Maukhari ruler Grahavarman. Following his death, his elder son Rajya Vardhana came to the throne, but Shashanka, the king of Gauda, treacherously killed him.

Harsha's sister, Rajyashri, was married to Grahavarman, the Maukhari king. Some years later, Grahavarman was defeated and killed by King Devagupta of Malwa, who then captured and imprisoned Rajyashri. Rajyavardhana, Harsha's brother and the reigning king at Sthanesvara, could not tolerate this affront to his sister and family. He launched a campaign against Devagupta and emerged victorious. However, Shashanka, the King of Gauda in Eastern Bengal, who had entered Magadha posing as Rajyavardhana's ally, was secretly in league with Devagupta and treacherously murdered Rajyavardhana. In the aftermath, Rajyashri fled into the forests. Upon learning of his brother's murder, Harsha decided to retaliate against the deceitful King of Gauda. Although his campaign against Shashanka did not reach a decisive conclusion, Harsha turned back after a point. At the age of 16, Harsha ascended the throne, determined to rescue his sister and avenge the deaths of his brother and brother-in-law. He successfully rescued Rajyashri just as she was about to commit self-immolation.

4.2. Harsha Vardhana (606−647)

Harsha Vardhana was the last great Hindu king of ancient India. Hsuan Tsang addressed him as Shiladityaraja. He was initially a Shaiva and supported Buddhism to a great extent, and made generous endowments to Buddhists. He was only sixteen years of age when he ascended the throne, but he still proved to be a great soldier and an efficient ruler. Numerous military victories marked Harsha's reign, and he brought most of north India

under his control as he got control of the five 'Indies (regions)' - Punjab, Kannauj, Bengal, Orissa, Mithila and assumed the title of 'Siladitya' (as mentioned in travel records of Chinese traveller Xuanzang (Hsuan Tsang). He also got a victory against the ruler of Sindh in the north-west. He defeated the Vallabhi king, Dhruvasena II, as mentioned in the Nausasi copper plate inscription. However, he was then defeated by Pulkesin II of western Chalukyan King of Badami on the banks of Narmada, who conferred himself with the title of "Sakalauttarapathanatha'', meaning "Lord of the entire north". Harsha's empire probably included Thaneswar, Kannauj, Ahichchhatra, Shravasti, and Prayag, and he extended his empire into Magadha and Orissa. Initially, the Capital of Harsha was Thaneswar, but it was shifted to Kannauj.

The Chinese pilgrim Hsuan Tsang, also known as the Prince of Travelers and author of Si-Yu-Ki, visited India from 629–644 CE. He earned Harsha's friendship and left a vivid account of the beauty, grandeur, and prosperity of Kannauj. He gives a detailed account of a grand assembly held at Kannauj in 643 CE, attended by Hinduism, Jainism, and Buddhism representatives. Xuanzang and others gave discourses on Mahayana doctrines. The death of Harsha was followed by a period of political confusion that continued up to the 8th century when the Gurjara Praticharas and the Rajput rulers emerged as a big force in northern India.

Harsha convened a great assembly at Kanauj to popularise the doctrines of Mahayana Buddhism. This assembly was attended by Hsuan Tsang, Bhaskarvarman (Kampura ruler), kings of 20 countries and a number of priests. The most important construction was the gold statue of the Buddha which was tall as the king himself. After Kanauj, he held a great assembly at Prayag which was attended by all the tributary princes, ministers, and nobles. An image of the Buddha, the Sun and Shiva were worshipped on this occasion. Hsuan Tsang was invited by Harsha to witness his 6-quinquennial distribution of gifts and alms (Mahamoksha Prashad) at Prayag.

Harsha paid great attention to the strength of the army. His army included elephants, infantry and cavalry. Ordinary soldiers were called Bhatas and Chatas. Infantry officers were called Baladhikritas and Mahabaladhikritas. Cavalry officers were called Brihadisvaras.

Harsha's revenue system was divided into four parts, i.e., expenditure of kings, for scholars, endowments of officials and public servants, and for religious purposes. Bali, Hiranya (paid by peasants and merchants in cash) and Bhaga (land tax paid in kind) were the three main taxes. King's share was one-sixth of the agricultural produce. Udranga was the frontier tax while uparikara was a tribute to the divisional officer. Forced labour (vishti) were prevalent.

Hsuan Tsang pointed out that Pataliputra lost its prominence and its place was taken by Kanauj. Most of the towns had outer walls, which were wide and high. The streets were narrow. Houses had balconies made up of wood and coated with lime mortar. Floors were smeared with cow dung. Free hospitals were constructed to provide medical treatment.

4.3. Religious Practices & Literary Works

Harsha, the Indian ruler, exhibited eclectic religious practices and beliefs throughout his life. His royal seals indicate that his forebears worshipped the Hindu sun god, Surya, while his elder brother followed Buddhism, and Harsha himself was a Shaivite Hindu, a devotee of Shiva. His land grant inscriptions identify him as a Parama-Maheshvara, denoting supreme devotion to Shiva, a sentiment echoed by his court poet, Bana.

Despite his Shaivite leanings, Harsha showed considerable interest in Buddhism. His play, Nagananda, centres around the Bodhisattva Jīmūtavāhavana and opens with an invocation to the Buddha, celebrated for overcoming the demon Māra. This verse is also separately preserved in Tibetan translations as the Marajit-Stotra. Within the play, Gauri, Shiva's consort, plays a pivotal role by resurrecting the protagonist with her divine powers.

The Chinese Buddhist traveler, Xuanzang, depicted Harsha as a devout Buddhist, noting his prohibition of animal slaughter for food and his establishment of monasteries at sites associated with Gautama Buddha. Harsha reportedly built numerous 100-foot-tall stupas along the Ganges and set up hospices for travelers and the destitute across India. He convened annual assemblies for scholars from around the world, distributing charitable alms, and every five years, he organized a significant gathering known as Moksha. Xuanzang describes a 21-day religious festival in Kanyakubja where Harsha, along with other kings, conducted daily rituals before a golden Buddha statue. However, Harsha's own records describe him as a Shaivite Hindu, suggesting that if he did convert to Buddhism, it occurred later in his life. Xuanzang's accounts indicate that Harsha supported scholars from all religions, not exclusively Buddhist monks. Historians like S. R.

Goyal and S. V. Sohoni argue that Harsha remained a Shaivite Hindu, and Xuanzang's portrayal as a devout Buddhist was due to his patronage of Buddhist monks.

Harsha is traditionally credited with authoring three Sanskrit plays: Ratnavali, Nagananda, and Priyadarsika. There is some debate about the authorship, with some suggesting that Dhāvaka, a poet in Harsha's court, wrote these plays on commission. However, scholar Wendy Doniger supports the view that Harsha himself was the true author of these works.

4.4. Arunsava & Wang Xuance Conflict

In 648, Emperor Tang Taizong of the Tang dynasty dispatched Wang Xuance to India following an envoy sent by Emperor Harsha to China. Upon his arrival, Wang discovered that Harsha had passed away, and the new ruler, Aluonashun (likely Arunāsva), attacked Wang and his 30 mounted followers. Wang Xuance managed to escape to Tibet and subsequently organized a joint military campaign with over 7,000 Nepalese-mounted troops and 1,200 Tibetan infantry. On June 16, they launched a successful assault on the Indian state, earning Wang Xuance the esteemed title of "Grand Master for the Closing Court." Additionally, he procured a notable Buddhist relic for China. During this campaign, the Nepali and Tibetan forces under Wang Xuance's command captured 2,000 prisoners from Magadha.

5. Ikshavakus

On the decline of the Satvahana power in the eastern part of the peninsula there arose the Ikshavakus in the Krishna Guntur region. They seem to have been a local tribe who adopted the dignified name of the Ikshavakus in order to show the antiquity of their lineage. A record of the Vijayapuri king Ehuvala Chamtamula traces his ancestry to the legendary Ikshvakus. The Ikshvakus of Vijayapuri seems to be the same as the 'Shriparvatiya Andhras' mentioned in the Matsya Purana. The dynasty's founder Vasishthiputra Chamtamula rose to power after the decline of the Satavahana power. He is attested by the Rentala and Kesanapalli inscriptions. The records of the later Ikshvaku kings describe Chamtamula as a great performer of the Vedic sacrifices such as Agnishtoma, Vajapeya and Ashvamedha. He was succeeded by his son Virapurushadatta. The Ikshvaku kings were Shaivites and performed Vedic rites, but Buddhism also flourished during their reign. Several Ikshvaku queens and princes contributed to the construction of the Buddhist monuments at present-day Nagarjunakonda. They were overthrown by the Pallavas.

6. Shashank of Gauda

King Shashanka was a notable historical figure who established the first distinct political entity in a unified Bengal known as Gauda during the 7th century. His rule was typically placed around 590 to 625 CE, and his capital was located at Karnasubarna, which is situated in Murshidabad district in present-day West Bengal.

Shashanka's reign marked a significant period in the history of Bengal. He was succeeded by his son, Manava, who held power for a brief period of eight months before Gauda was divided among other regional powers. The neighbouring rulers, Harshavardhana and Bhaskaravarman of Kamarupa, seized control of the territory, with Bhaskaravarman even managing to capture Karnasubarna.

Shashanka is also credited with the creation of the Bengali calendar. The term "Bangabda" (Bangla year) appears in inscriptions found in Shiva temples that predate the Akbar era by several centuries, indicating that a Bengali calendar existed well before Akbar's time.

As a contemporary of Harsha and Bhaskaravarman, Shashanka's interactions with these rulers are significant in the broader context of South Asian history. However, his legacy is marred by accounts of his antagonism towards Buddhism. According to a 12th-century text, Shashanka was responsible for destroying Buddhist stupas in Bengal and is reputed to have cut down the Bodhi tree at the Mahabodhi Temple in Bodh Gaya, where Buddha attained enlightenment.

7. Kamarupa Kingdom

Kamarupa was a significant kingdom in Eastern India, corresponding to present-day Assam and known as Pragjyotisha in ancient times. Davaka was another prominent kingdom in the region, mentioned alongside Kamarupa in the Allahabad Inscription of Samudragupta. The kingdom extended to parts of Northern and Western Bengal, bordering China, and included Davaka.

Kamarupa was governed by a single dynasty from the time of the Mahabharata until the 7th century, concluding with the reign of Bhaskaravarman. Historical sources include the Dubi and Nidhanpur

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copper plates, genealogical seals from Nalanda, and accounts by Banabhatta and Hiuen-Tsang.

The dynasty claimed descent from Narakasura, son of Vishnu (as Varaha) and Bhumi-Devi (Earth), hence known as the Bhauma dynasty. Naraka's son, Bhagadatta, participated in the Mahabharata war, and his successors are said to have ruled for 3,000 years before the advent of Pushyavarman.

7.1. Notable Rulers of Kamarupa

1. Pushyavarman (350-374 AD): The first king, known as the 'lord of Pragjotish' and titled 'Maharajadhiraja'.
2. Samudravarman (374-398 AD)
3. Balavarman (398-422 AD)
4. Kalyanavarman (422-446 AD)
5. Ganapativarman (446-470 AD)
6. Mahendravarman (470-494 AD)
7. Narayanavarman (494-518 AD): Performed horse sacrifices, indicating independence from the Gupta empire.
8. Bhutivarman (518-542 AD): Under his reign, Kamarupa included the entire Brahmaputra valley, Sylhet, and extended to the Karatoya river.
9. Chandramukhavarman (542-566 AD)
10. Sthitavarman (566-590 AD): Conducted a horse sacrifice.
11. Susthitavarman (590-595 AD): Possibly an ally of Mahasenagupta.
12. Supratishthitavarman (595-600 AD): Imprisoned by Sasanka of Gauda but later ruled briefly.
13. Bhaskaravarman (600-650 AD): Allied with Harshavardhana and expanded into Bengal after the defeat of Sasanka.

Bhaskaravarman's rule was noted for his alliance with Harshavardhana, which helped him expand his influence over Bengal. Hiuen-Tsang's accounts reveal Bhaskaravarman's control over parts of North Bengal and his influence on the Buddhist monastery at Nalanda.

The dynasty ended with the death of Bhaskaravarman, after which the kingdom fell to a Mlechchha ruler named Salastambha, similar to the decline seen in Harshavardhana's kingdom.

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